

The Art of Giving:

A Collection of Talks on Dāna

(First edition)



Sayadaw U Janakābhivamsa

Dhammagonyee Pa-Auk Tawya (Hlegu), Yangon

*“yaṃ kiñcārammaṇaṃ katvā, dajjā dānaṃ amaccharī;
pubbapete ca ārabhha, atha vā vatthudevatā.”*

*Those who are free from stinginess
should give donations for whatever reason
— dedicating to departed petas,
and to the guardian devas of the place.*

Khu.2.128 (Petavatthupāḷi, uragavaggo, piṭṭhadhītalikapetavatthu)



Buddhasāsaṇaṃ ciraṃ tiṭṭhatu

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Biography of Sayadaw U Janakābhivaṃsa



Sayadaw U Janakābhivaṃsa was born in 1976 in Magway, Myanmar. He was ordained as a novice monk (sāmaṇera) at a monastery in Magway on 16 June 1991 and received higher ordination as a bhikkhu on 20 June 1995 at Atulakari Sinmin Monastery, Phaya Gyi Taik in Mandalay, where he pursued Buddhist Pāḷi studies.

In 2002, Sayadaw U Janakābhivaṃsa passed the “Sāsanadhaja Dhammācariya” examination conducted by the Department of Religious Affairs under the Ministry of Religious Affairs, Government of the Union of Myanmar. He was awarded the prestigious title of “Sāsanadhaja Dhammācariya” on 18 July 2002. In the same year, he also passed the Pariyatti Sāsanahita Dhammācariya examination held by the Pariyatti Sāsanahita Association of Mandalay, earning the title of “Bhaddanta Janakābhivaṃsa Pariyatti Sāsanahita Dhammācariya” (Abhivaṃsa degree) on 17 July 2002.

The Pariyatti Sāsanahita Dhammācariya examination is widely recognized as the highest academic achievement in Pāli language and Buddhist studies. The "Abhivaṃsa" degree is equivalent to a Ph.D. in Buddhist Pāli studies. Notably, among the many candidates who sit for this rigorous examination annually in Myanmar, only an average of three successfully pass and receive the title of "Abhivaṃsa."

In 2002, Sayadaw began his role as an official teacher of the Pāli language at Phaya Gyi Taik in Mandalay. From 2007 to 2008, he served as a member of the State Main Committee of Buddhist Education and was appointed as a questioner for the Dhammācariya examination by the Ministry of Religious Affairs, Government of the Union of Myanmar.

In 2005, Sayadaw U Janakābhivaṃsa joined Pa-Auk Tawya Forest Monastery (Main) to learn and practice Samatha and Vipassanā meditation under the guidance of the Most Venerable Pa-Auk Tawya Sayadaw (Sayadawgyi). He deepened his training during the six-month Intensive Meditation Retreat in 2010 and the four-month Intensive Meditation Retreat in 2013, both led by Sayadawgyi. He also spent the 2015 vassa (Buddhist Rains Retreat) in Maymyo, where Sayadawgyi was conducting an intensive retreat for advanced meditators.

Since 2014, Sayadaw U Janakābhivaṃsa has served as the Resident Teacher of the Pa-Auk Meditation Centre in Singapore. Additionally, he is the abbot and meditation teacher at Dhammagonyee Pa-Auk Tawya in Hlegu Township, Yangon.

Sayadaw is fluent in both Myanmar and English. Over the years, he has delivered Dhamma talks and led meditation retreats across Myanmar and internationally, including in Singapore, Malaysia, Indonesia, Vietnam, the United States, Taiwan, Thailand, South Korea, and Nepal.



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Introduction

All the Buddhas taught the same summary of Dhamma Practice:

*Sabba pāpassa akaranam
kusalassa upasampadā
sacitta pariyodapanam
etaṃ Buddhāna sāsanaṃ*¹

Avoid all evil, accomplish wholesome deeds,
purify one's own mind—this is the teaching of the Buddhas.

All Buddhas teach the performance of wholesome deeds. Among these, *dāna*—giving or generosity—is the doorway to performing wholesome deeds.

The Importance of Dāna in Buddhist Practice

Among the ten bases of meritorious actions (*dasa-puñña-kiriya-vatthu*)², *dāna* is the first. In terms of accumulating

¹ Khu.1.41 Dhammapade (Dhammapada Verse 183)

² Abhi.Ṭṭha.1.201 (Dhammasaṅgaṇī-aṭṭhakathā, 1. Cittuppadakathā, kāmāvacarakusalapadabhājanīyaṃ, kāmāvacarakusalaṃ niddesavāra-kathā, puññakiriya-vatthādikathā):

The ten bases of meritorious acts (*dasa puññakiriya-vatthu*): 1. Produced by giving (*dānamaya*), 2. Produced by morality (*sīlamaya*), 3. Produced by meditation (*bhāvanāmaya*), 4. Associated with respect (*apacitisahagata*), 5. Associated with service (*veyyāvaccasahagata*), 6. Sharing of merits (*pattānuppadāna*), 7. Rejoicing in merits (*abbhanumodana*), 8. Produced by



wholesome kamma for oneself, *dāna* is the first. When we simplify the ten bases into three categories—*dāna*, *sīla*, and *bhāvanā*—*dāna* remains first. In our interactions with others, among the four means of sustaining favourable relationships (*cattāri saṅgahavatthūni*)³, *dāna* is also first. For the realisation of the state of an Omniscient Buddha, a *Pacceka Buddha*, or an *Arahant*, among the ten perfections (*pāramī*), *dāna-pāramī* is likewise first.

For the Bodhisatta, the final fulfilment and perfection of *pāramī* in his final human life as King Vessantara focused primarily on *dāna-pāramī*. For many of the great disciples of the Buddha, the outstanding wholesome deeds (*adhikāra*) they performed before making their aspirations and receiving their definite prophecy were also mainly related to *dāna*.

From this, we can understand the importance of *dāna* in the path of practice—as a means to accumulate wholesome kamma and especially as foundational support for higher practices that eventually lead to escape from the suffering of the cycle of rebirths.

[Dhamma] discourse (*desanāmaya*), 9. Produced by listening [to Dhamma] (*savanamaya*), 10. Setting one's view straight (*diṭṭhijukamma*).

³ Añ.1.341 (AN 4.32 Saṅgaha Sutta):

"*cattārimāni, bhikkhave, saṅgahavatthūni. katamāni cattāri? dānaṃ, peyyavajjaṃ, atthacariyā, samānattatā—imāni kho, bhikkhave, cattāri saṅgahavatthūni*"*ti*.

"Bhikkhus, there are these four means of sustaining a favorable relationship. What four? Giving, endearing speech, beneficent conduct, and impartiality. These are the four means of sustaining a favorable relationship."

The Need for Proper Understanding

Therefore, we find many discourses in the Tipiṭaka on the subject of *dāna*. However, having correct and comprehensive knowledge about *dāna* is essential so that one can derive maximum benefits from the act of giving.

In the commentary on the Dakkhiṇāvibhaṅga Sutta, a key question arises: which act of giving is more beneficial—the Buddha offering something to his chief disciple Venerable Sāriputta, or Venerable Sāriputta offering to the Buddha?⁴ The answer is that the Buddha's giving is superior because only he, with his perfect and complete omniscient knowledge, truly understands the full karmic results and benefits of any act of generosity; no one else can match this deep insight. Therefore, the deeper a person's understanding of *dāna*, the greater and more fruitful their own acts of giving become. This is why we should learn as much as possible about it to gain maximum benefits from our generosity.

This is the reason Sayadaw Janakābhivaṃsa chose to explain this series of talks relating to different aspects of *dāna*, and it is also the main motivation for the compilation and publication of this book.

⁴ This is also quoted and explained in Talk no. 3: Dakkhiṇāvibhaṅga Sutta.



About This Book

The ten talks collected in this book have been edited, and sometimes expanded with further details by Sayadaw Janakābhivaṃsa, from a series of *anumodana* talks given by Sayadaw at two meditation retreats organized by Pa-Auk Meditation Centre, Singapore. The talk on Dakkhiṇāvibhaṅga Sutta is compiled from a series of three talks given at a meditation retreat held in June 2019 at Nandaka Vihāra in Bukit Mertajam, Malaysia. The remaining nine talks were given at a retreat held in March 2018 at Dhammavijaya Meditation Centre in Dengkil, Malaysia.

These short dhamma teachings were given just before lunch *dāna* each day during the retreats. As donors would come to offer food and other requisites to Sayadaw and all the meditators practising at the monastery, Sayadaw compassionately chose topics related to *dāna* as the subject of his *anumodana* (rejoicing) talks for the benefit of both the donors and the meditators.

Before exploring the individual talks, it may be helpful to understand that these teachings are not merely theoretical instructions but practical guidance rooted in the living tradition of the Buddha's teachings. Whether you are new to Buddhist practice or a long-time supporter of the *Buddhasāsana*, these talks offer valuable insights that can deepen your understanding and practice of generosity.

Overview of the Ten Talks

These ten talks cover different aspects of *dāna*:

1. **Kimḍada Sutta** — This talk serves as the best starting point because it answers the most basic question: "**What to give?**". It introduces the material categories of giving—food, clothing, vehicles, light, and dwellings—while introducing the supreme gift: the Dhamma.
2. **Qualities of Dāna** — Once the reader knows **what** can be given, they must learn about **quality** of giving. Quoting from the Chaḷaṅgadāna Sutta, this talk explains the six factors (three on each side of the receiver and the donor) that improve the quality of *dāna*. This answers the question: "**Who should give and to whom should one give?**"
3. **Dakkhiṇāvibhaṅga Sutta** — This talk enumerates **the various categories and types of receivers** providing a comprehensive classification of receivers. It further explains "**How an offering is purified**"—either by the donor, or the receiver, or neither, or both.
4. **Sappurisaḍāna: The Offerings of a Good Person** — This talk answers the question: "**How to give?**" Having understood the "What" and the "Who," the focus shifts to the **manner of giving**. Quoting from three related suttas, this talk explains how a good person



gives by showing the various ways of making proper offerings.

5. **The Timing of Donations** — This talk explains "**When to give?**" It reinforces the "timely" factor of the previous talk, emphasizing the **urgency** of doing good quickly when faith arises, illustrated by the story of Cūḷekasāṭaka.
6. **Benefits of Donation Here and Now** — This talk answers the question "**What are the presently visible benefits of *dāna*?**" It highlights the visible rewards of generosity in this life, such as being loved by many, gaining fame, and possessing confidence when approaching others.
7. **Sharing Merits after Donations** — This talk answers the question "**How to share merits after *dāna*?**" It explains the vital post-giving step of dedicating merits to departed relatives (*petas*), protector devas, and King Yama to ensure the merit reaches its full potential.
8. **Aspirations** — This talk answers the question "**What is the purpose of giving?**" by explaining the right aspirations to make after performing *dāna*. It addresses the ultimate purpose of the merit. It moves the donor's focus from worldly rewards (like beauty or wealth) toward the goal of Nibbāna and liberation from suffering.

9. **The Buddha's Advice for Regular Donors** — This talk acts as a bridge from material giving to **mental cultivation**. It encourages regular donors to further cultivate the mind and seek more sublime "joy born of seclusion" (*paviveka-pīti*) through concentration practice.
10. **The Donation of Great Benefits** — This final talk explains "**Which type of giving yields great fruits?**" and how *dāna* becomes a "**decoration and accessory of the mind**" for *Samatha* and *Vipassanā* meditation, leading to the stage of Non-returner (*Anāgāmi*).

In addition to the ten talks above, Sayadaw has included a special teaching entitled "**Opening the Hand, Opening the Heart: The Bodhisatta's Reflections on the Perfection of Generosity**" at the end of this book. At times, although we wish to give, hesitation or inner obstacles prevent us from acting – our mind is not yet strong enough. The Bodhisatta systematically used wise reflections to train his mind and overcome such obstacles to generosity. By learning and emulating these skilful reflections, readers too can **strengthen their resolve to give more readily, freely, and joyfully**.

The Occasion of Publication

These talks were transcribed and given initial editing, but there were no suitable conditions or pressing reasons for their publication until now. In conjunction with the 50th



birthday of Sayadaw, we now have the right conditions and motivation to publish these talks.

Sayadaw would typically mention in his Dhamma talks that most people celebrate birthdays by wishing each other "Happy Birthday." However, this is not quite in line with what the Buddha taught. The Buddha said, "*jātipi dukkha*"⁵ (birth is also suffering), and also "*dukkha jāti punappunam*"⁶ (to be born again and again is suffering)—so it should be "Suffering Birthday" rather than "Happy Birthday."

In view of this, instead of planning ceremonial celebrations for his 50th birthday, Sayadaw's preference is to take this occasion to share the Dhamma—the true teachings of the Buddha—for the benefit of many beings. To fulfil Sayadaw's wish to propagate the True Dhamma, two books edited from Sayadaw's Dhamma talks are being published in conjunction with Sayadaw's 50th birthday: *The 40-to of Vipassanā—Seeing Life in Many Special Ways* and this book, *The Art of Giving—A Collection of Talks on Dāna*. These are the first two Dhamma books in English by Sayadaw.

Two Books for Different Stages of Practice

The first book is intended for more advanced practitioners who are practising *Vipassanā* to contemplate the *saṅkhāra dhammā* (conditioned phenomena) as *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anatta* (impermanent, suffering, and non-self). At the other

⁵ Sam.3.369 (SN 56.11 Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta)

⁶ Khu.1.36 Dhammapade (Dhammapada Verse 153)

end of the spectrum, this current book, *The Art of Giving*, addresses the most basic form of meritorious deed and is therefore intended for a much wider audience, including those who are very much beginners on the path of practice, as well as those who are regular supporters of the *Buddhasāsana*.

Notwithstanding this, Sayadaw has explained the 40-to contemplations with easy-to-understand anecdotes so that non-advanced practitioners may also incorporate such reflections on the true nature of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* of the body into their daily practice. Similarly, in some of the talks on *dāna*, there are occasions where the Buddha taught how to use *dāna* as support to progress to higher practices—for example, to cultivate *paviveka pīti* (joy-born-of-seclusion) and to use *dāna* as an ornament for the practising mind of *Samatha* and *Vipassanā*. After accumulating merits through the act of giving, donors are also encouraged to aspire for Nibbāna. Therefore, these two books are suitable and beneficial for practitioners at various points along the wide spectrum of the path of practice.

In the 40-to book, there are a total of 40 contemplations; in this book, there are ten talks on various aspects of giving. Together, these are the 50 Dhamma gifts from Sayadaw Janakābhivaṃsa on the occasion of his 50th birthday.

Although these fifty Dhamma gifts have thus been completed, Sayadaw has chosen to include one additional teaching as a special offering. This is because the reflections of the Bodhisatta on *dāna pāramī* are especially effective in



helping practitioners overcome hesitation and strengthen the mind to give freely and joyfully. Moreover, in many traditions, including in Myanmar, it is customary to add one more beyond a given number as an expression of auspiciousness and as a support for continuity and longevity. In this spirit, this additional Dhamma gift is included as a supporting condition for the flourishing of the True Dhamma and the long endurance of the *Buddhasāsana*.

Aspirations

May Sayadaw Janakābhivaṃsa always have the right supporting conditions to teach and propagate the True Dhamma for the benefit of many beings and for the long-lasting of the *Buddhasāsana*. May all the noble aspirations of Sayadaw come to smooth and swift fruition.

May this Dhamma gift benefit all readers. May the knowledge gained through reading these two books become strong supporting conditions for the realisation of Nibbāna, the ending of saṃsāra, and the complete cessation of all future suffering—no more “Suffering Birthdays”!

Sādhu! Sādhu! Sādhu!

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We extend our heartfelt gratitude to Sayadaw U Janakābhivamsa for his endless compassion, guidance, and dedication in teaching us the True Teachings of the Buddha.

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retreats and thereby providing the conditions for Sayadaw to deliver these teachings.

Publication:

Pa-Auk Meditation Centre (Singapore) for the publication of this book.

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Feedback

We welcome any feedback or suggestions for improvement regarding this book. Please feel free to reach out to the editorial team at dhammagonyee@gmail.com (cc jjthong77@gmail.com).

Final Aspirations

May the True Dhamma endure for a long time.

May all beings develop respect for the Dhamma.

May the noble aspirations of all beings be fulfilled.

May all beings be free from suffering.



Abbreviations for Source Reference

Abhi	Abhidhamma Piṭaka
Dī	Dīgha Nikāya
Ma	Majjhima Nikāya
Sam	Samyutta Nikāya
Aṅ	Aṅguttara Nikāya
Khu	Khuddaka Nikāya
Vi	Vinaya Piṭaka
Ṭṭha	Aṭṭhakathā (Commentary)
Ṭikā	Ṭikā (Sub-commentary)

Examples of Source Reference

Abhi.Ṭṭha.1.201	Abhidhammapiṭaka-aṭṭhakathā Volume 1 page 201
Dī.2.126	Dīgha Nikāya Volume 2 page 126
Ma.3.296	Majjhima Nikāya Volume 3 page 296
Sam.3.369	Samyutta Nikāya Volume 3 page 369
Aṅ.1.341	Aṅguttara Nikāya Volume 1 page 341
Khu.1.41 Dhammapade	Khuddaka Nikāya Volume 1 (Dhammapada) page 41
Vi.3.324	Vinaya Piṭaka Volume 3 page 324
Khu.Ṭṭha.21.296	Khuddaka Nikāya-aṭṭhakathā Volume 21 page 296
Aṅ.Ṭikā.3.21	Aṅguttara Nikkaya-ṭikā Volume 3 page 21



The Art of Giving: A Collection of Talks on Dāna

1. Kiṃdada Sutta

(Edited from a Dhamma talk given at Dhammavijaya Meditation Centre on 20 March 2018)

Introduction

Today, I will give a short talk based on the Kiṃdada Sutta.⁷ “*Kiṃdada*” means “what kind of donation.” The Kiṃdada Sutta is related to *dāna*—giving—and concerning what kinds of things we can give.

Today, we will be discussing **what** we can give.

One day, a *deva* came to the Buddha and asked a series of questions:

“*Kiṃdado balado hoti?*”

— What kind of donation gives strength?

“*Kiṃdado vaṇṇado hoti?*”

— What kind of donation gives beauty?

“*Kiṃdado sukhado hoti?*”

— What kind of donation gives ease?

⁷ Saṃ.1.29 (SN 1.42 Kiṃdada Sutta)



“Kiṃdado cakkhudo hoti?”

— What kind of donation gives eyesight?

“Ko ca sabbadado hoti?”

— Who is the one that gives all these gifts?

Here, “all” refers to all the gifts mentioned — strength, beauty, ease, and sight.

The *deva* said, *“Taṃ me akkhāhi pucchito”* — “Being asked, please answer these questions for me.”

Then the Buddha replied.

The Gift of Strength (*Baladāna*)

The first question was:

“Kiṃdado balado hoti?”

— What kind of donation is the gift of strength?

The Buddha answered:

“Annado balado hoti”

— Giving food is the gift of strength.

If someone wishes to be strong, he should give food.

If we wish to have the strength to meditate for long hours—three, four, or even five hours without pain—what do we need to give? We need to give strength.

And what kind of gift gives strength? The gift of food.

We can see this through the example of Bhante Āṅgulimāla. He had tremendous strength and energy. He could chase and catch anyone he wished, even deer that ran swiftly through the forest. That was because of his power and strength.

In one of his past lives, during the time of Kassapa Buddha, he had given and distributed much milk-rice to the bhikkhus through drawing lots⁸. Because of that meritorious act, he gained great physical strength.

He had also donated a firehouse—a place for people to obtain fire to warm themselves during the cold season. He donated firewood, and even adzes and axes to prepare that firewood. Because of these wholesome actions, he accumulated much power.

Unfortunately, in that life as *Āṅgulimāla*, he used his strength wrongly.

Instead of using it for good, he tried to kill one thousand people. Killing one thousand people is not easy—it requires great strength. But strength in the hands of a foolish man becomes dangerous.

Later, after listening to the Buddha’s teaching, he ordained as a *bhikkhu*. Surely at that time, he might be able to meditate for long hours without fatigue, because he had strength and inner power from past wholesome deeds.

⁸ Khu.Ṭṭha.21.515 (Commentary to Jātaka no. 537: Mahāsutasoma Jātaka).



Once, King Pasenadi of Kosala wanted to compete with his citizens to see who could give more to the Buddha and the Saṅgha—the king or the people.

The citizens gave many things, and the king also gave many things, but even as a king, he could not outgive his people!

Then his wife, Queen Mallikā, came up with a brilliant idea—a truly incomparable donation (*Asadisadāna*).⁹

The king built a huge pavilion and invited 500 *bhikkhus* to sit inside. Next to each *bhikkhu*, he stationed an elephant holding a white parasol over the monk's head. Between every two *bhikkhus*, he placed a princess to fan them. So, 250 princesses were fanning the monks. Golden boats filled with perfume and fragrant oils were placed in the middle of the pavilion.

The citizens, seeing this, realised they could not match such a grand offering—they had no princesses, no elephants, and no white parasols!

However, while arranging the elephants, the king discovered that he was one short. The only remaining elephant was wild and untamed—dangerous to place near a monk.

Again, Queen Mallikā advised, “Place that wild elephant next to Bhante Aṅgulimāla.”

When they did so, the wild elephant immediately thrust its tail between its legs, folded its ears, closed its eyes, and stood

⁹ Khu.Ṭṭha.3.120 Dhammapade (Commentary to Dhammapāda Verse 177 – Asadisadānavatthu)

completely still—terrified in the presence of Bhante Aṅgulimāla. Such was his power!

In those days, when people heard someone shouted, “I am Aṅgulimāla!” they would flee in terror. Even the royal guards would abandon their duties to protect the king or the nobles. His strength was formidable—so much so that he could subdue wild beasts and strike fear in others.

So, we can see: strength itself comes from wholesome kamma, but whether we use that strength rightly or wrongly depends on one’s wisdom.

The cause of strength is giving food. So, if we wish to have the strength—physical strength, vitality, or endurance for meditation—we should make the offering of food.

The Gift of Beauty (*Vaṇṇadāna*)

The next question was, “What type of donation is a gift of beauty or good appearance?”

Different people have different appearances, different bodily structures. Some are good-looking, while others are not. So, what kind of donation brings about beauty or a pleasing appearance?

The Buddha said, “*Vatthado hoti vaṇṇado*” — offering clothes is offering beauty, offering good appearance.

Yesterday, I mentioned a lady named Ummānantī. *Ummānantī* means “one who causes the opposite gender to



become mad.” Whichever man saw her would become infatuated. Because of this, she was called *Ummādantī*.

So, what had she done to gain such maddening beauty? In one of her past existences, she had donated robes to a *bhikkhu* and made an aspiration to be beautiful. The robes she offered naturally had the potential to bring about beauty, and her aspiration further strengthened that wish. Therefore, both the merit of her offering and her determined aspiration combined to produce her extraordinarily beautiful appearance in that later life.

Although someone may have beautiful or handsome features, if he or she does not have proper clothing or does not dress properly, that person may not appear beautiful or respectable. The appearance would instead be regarded as shameful or unbecoming. Clothing enhances one’s appearance; whoever wears suitable garments appears graceful and dignified.

Because of this, if someone wishes to have a beautiful appearance, they should offer clothing.

The Gift of Ease (*Sukhadāna*)

The next question was, “What type of donation is the gift of ease—*sukha*?” In this context, *sukha* means ease or comfort.

To this, the Buddha answered, “*Yānado sukhado hoti*” — donating vehicles is donating ease.

Now, what kinds of vehicles are suitable for the receivers, especially if they are monks? Things such as slippers, umbrellas, chairs, beds, the making of roads, shelters, and bridges—all these are considered forms of donating vehicles. Through the use of these things, ease or comfort is produced.

For instance, if there are good roads, travel becomes easy. If there are umbrellas, one can be protected from the rain or the scorching heat of the sun. If there are shelters, there is not even a need to carry an umbrella. The receivers can thus enjoy ease and comfort.

And, as a result, the donors too will gain ease and comfort in return.

The King of devas, Sakka, was in a previous life a young man named Magha. In that lifetime, he undertook seven vows¹⁰

¹⁰ Khu.Ṭṭha.2.168 Dhammapade (Commentary to Dhammapāda Verse 30 – Maghavatthu)

“yāvajīvaṃ mātāpettibhāro assaṃ, yāvajīvaṃ kule jeṭṭhāpacāyī assaṃ, yāvajīvaṃ saṇhāvāco assaṃ, yāvajīvaṃ apisuṇavāco assaṃ, yāvajīvaṃ vigatamalamaccherena cetasā agāraṃ ajjhāvaseyyaṃ, muttacāgo payatapāṇi vosaggarato yācayogo dānaṃvibhāgarato assaṃ. yāvajīvaṃ saccavāco assaṃ, yāvajīvaṃ akkodhano assaṃ, “sacepi me kodho uppajjeyya, khippameva na paṭivineyya”ti.

“(1) For as long as I live, may I support my parents.

(2) For as long as I live, may I honour the elders in my clan.

(3) For as long as I live, may I be gentle in speech.

(4) For as long as I live, may I refrain from divisive speech.

(5) For as long as I live, may I dwell at home with a mind cleansed of the stain of stinginess, freely generous, open-handed, delighting in renunciation, responsive to requests, rejoicing in giving and sharing.

(6) For as long as I live, may I speak the truth.

(7) For as long as I live, may I be without anger, and even if anger should arise in me, may I quickly dispel it.”



and devoted himself to countless acts of generosity and service. Together with thirty-two companions, Magha worked for the welfare of others. They levelled roads so that travellers could journey with ease, and they built a hall at a busy crossroads where weary wanderers might find rest and comfort.

They even arranged an elephant to welcome each visitor into the hall, ensuring that guests received care and hospitality. There, travellers could have their feet washed, their backs rubbed, and be offered water, food, and bedding for the night.

Near this hall, Magha planted a koviḷāra tree and spread a large stone slab beneath it—a quiet resting place shaded by its fragrant blossoms. Among his wives, three of them each contributed with devotion: Sudhammā offered the finial, the central ornament that crowned the hall's roof; Nandā gifted a pond for drinking and bathing; and Cittā created a flower garden, radiant with colour and fragrance.

Through the power of these meritorious deeds, Magha and his companions were reborn in the Tāvatiṃsa realm—the Heaven of the Thirty-Three. Magha himself became Sakka, the king of devas.

Because of his generosity in offering the hall, a resplendent Vejayanta Palace, adorned with seven precious gems, arose for him in that celestial realm. From his planting of the koviḷāra tree appeared the majestic Pāricchattaka tree, radiant and vast. From the stone slab he laid came the

Paṇḍukambala stone, his royal throne—the very seat upon which the Buddha later expounded the Abhidhamma teachings.

A delightful assembly hall named Sudhammā manifested for his wife Sudhammā, where celestial beings gather to listen to Dhamma discourses. For Nandā, there appeared a shimmering lotus pond named Nandā, and for Cittā, a grove of flowering vines called Cittalatāvana.

Thus, each of them received the fruits of their wholesome actions, enjoying divine splendour and bliss. The comfort and hospitality they once provided to travellers while in the human birth blossomed into celestial ease and delight in the deva realm.

The Gift of Sight (*Cakkhudāna*)

Another question is, “What type of donation is the gift of sight?” If you have poor eyesight, you need to know the answer to this question.

The Buddha said, “*Dīpado cakkhudo hoti*” — donating light is donating eyesight.

Although you have eyes, if it is dark, you cannot see. For the eyes to function properly, you need light. Without light — whether it is sunlight, electric light, or candlelight — even though we have eyes, we cannot see anything. Because of this, if you truly want others to see something with their eyes,



you must support them with light. In doing so, it is as if you are offering them eyes, or offering eyesight itself.

In some places where there is no electricity, people cannot see anything at night. They must go to bed early simply because there is no light. If you offer them light, it is as though you are giving them eyesight in the darkness. As a result, you may gain good eyesight in return.

This offering is not only for the physical eyes. It can also bring the mental eye — the *dibba-cakkhu*, the divine eye. Whether the object is far or near, small or large, one can see it with the divine eye, like the Venerable Anuruddha. Bhante Anuruddha was foremost among those with the divine eye. And what was the reason? It was because he had offered lights in many past lives.

In one life, after Kassapa Buddha had entered *Parinibbāna*, he built a great shrine and offered countless lights in golden cups filled with butter oil, all around the shrine. He even carried a large golden bowl with a thousand lights on his head and circumambulated the shrine throughout the night. Because of that offering, in his final life, he developed very strong supernatural power of the divine eye.

The donation of light also supports the arising of the knowledge eye — the eye of wisdom. Although an object may be right before us, if we lack the knowledge eye, we cannot see its true nature. Even though cause and effect operate continually in reality, we cannot perceive them directly if the wisdom eye has not opened. Mentality and materiality are

functioning within this body, yet we cannot see these realities because we are covered by delusion.

The mind, by nature, is pure and bright. Darkness is not natural. If ignorance or delusion is removed, the mind becomes luminous and can see clearly. Through the practice of meditation, when the mind becomes pure, delusion can be temporarily suppressed — and then light appears. Some meditators experience inner brightness; the purer the mind, the more steadily that light remains and illuminates the object. Especially for noble persons, whose minds are not covered by delusion, they can see realities beyond what the naked eye can perceive.

Therefore, if you help others see what they could not see before, you are in effect offering them eyesight — both physical and mental.

Some may think that to give the gift of sight, one must donate actual eyes. But if you donate your eyes, perhaps only two people can benefit — one eye for one person, the other for another person. You cannot help more than two. Yet if you donate light, countless people can benefit from it. Although they already have eyes, without light they can see only in the daytime. At night, they are as if blind.

Because of this, donating light is truly the gift of eyesight.



The Gift of All (*Sabbadāna*)

The next question is: “How does one make an *all-in-one* donation?”

The Buddha answered,

“*Yo ca sabbadado hoti, so dadāti upassayaṃ*”

— “The one who gives all gifts gives a dwelling place.”

So, donating a dwelling place — whether it is a meditation hall or a small *kuṭi* — is considered the gift of all the above-mentioned offerings.

Why is that so?

If you sit outdoors, what will happen? You will be exposed to the sun, the strong wind, and the rain. These will harm the body. When the body is weakened, energy and strength will decline. But if you have the chance to sit under the shelter of a dwelling place, your body gains comfort and vitality. Therefore, offering a dwelling place is the offering of strength and energy — *baladāna*.

In the same way, even though you may be naturally beautiful, with fair and clear skin, if you stay outside under the hot sun for a long time, your complexion will darken, and your appearance may lose its freshness. But if you stay indoors — in a good monastery, in a clean and well-built *kuṭi* — the body is protected from the weather, and beauty is preserved.

If most people at a certain place appear beautiful or handsome, you can reflect, “Ah, this place must have good

weather, good food, and good dwellings.” So, the offering of a dwelling place is also the offering of beauty — *vaṇṇadāna*.

Next, the offering of a dwelling place is also the offering of ease and happiness — *sukhadāna*. Why? When you chant or meditate outdoors and the weather is harsh — too hot, too cold, or windy — the mind cannot develop *pīti*, joy, or happiness. But when you stay in a proper dwelling place, like this hall, you can meditate with ease. The mind becomes peaceful and concentrated. A good dwelling supports good concentration. If the dwelling is uncomfortable, concentration and happiness are difficult to attain. Hence, the offering of a dwelling place is also the offering of ease and happiness.

Similarly, the offering of a dwelling place is the offering of sight — *cakkhudāna*. When you stay outside without shelter, the sunlight, heat, and wind may harm your eyes. Prolonged exposure to glare or hot wind weakens the vision. When you step from bright sunlight into a shaded hall, at first you cannot see clearly — your eyes need time to adjust. This is because the materialities in the eye have been disturbed or slightly damaged by the harsh conditions. But when you stay in a suitable dwelling, your eyes recover gradually. Vision becomes clear again. Thus, offering a dwelling place is also the offering of good eyesight.

So, the offering of a dwelling place is truly an *all-in-one* offering. It encompasses the offering of strength, beauty, ease, happiness, and vision.



When we offer a dwelling place, we give all these blessings together — a *sabbadāna*, the complete gift.

The Gift of Deathlessness (*Amatadāna*)

Even though the deva did not ask a further question, the Buddha continued by declaring:

“Amataṃ dado ca so hoti, yo Dhammam anusāsati” —

“One who teaches the Dhamma, one who gives righteous admonishment, gives the gift of the Deathless.”

So, if you wish to offer deathlessness to others, you should offer Dhamma. Offering Dhamma is offering deathlessness — *Amatadāna*, the supreme gift.

Without the Dhamma, what can we create? We can only create this body.

If we have some wisdom, we may create a better body — perhaps a human body, a deva body, or even that of a *brahmā*. But sometimes, without right understanding, in our search for happiness, we may commit *akusala kamma* — unwholesome deeds like killing or stealing. Because of these wrong actions, we may end up creating bodies that suffer — animal bodies or even bodies in hell and the lower realms.

So you see, whether noble or inferior, bright or dark, these bodies are our own creations — all the results of our *kamma*.

By doing bad *kamma*, we create inferior bodies — perhaps with tails, horns, claws, or fangs.

By doing good *kamma* — like giving and keeping precepts — we create human or deva bodies.

By developing *jhāna*, we create brahmā bodies.

But all these — human, deva, or brahmā — are still bodies made of the five aggregates. They all share the same fate: ageing, sickness, and death.

As long as we keep creating new bodies, even beautiful and refined ones, we remain bound to suffering.

So how can we stop creating bodies altogether? How can we be free from all these forms of existence that always end in death? How can we experience the Deathless?

To achieve this, the Buddha taught *Vipassanā* practice — the way of insight into the true nature of phenomena. Through this practice, the causes for new birth are gradually removed. This is the Dhamma that leads to the Deathless.

Therefore, when someone shares such a Dhamma — the teaching that leads to Nibbāna — that person gives the gift of deathlessness.

Just like Bhante Assaji — with only one stanza — he gave the deathlessness to two persons: Upatissa and Kolita, who later became Bhante Sāriputta and Bhante Mahāmoggallāna.

That is the power of Dhamma. That is the power of the Deathless.

So, what is “offering Dhamma”?



It includes answering Dhamma questions, discussing Dhamma, giving Dhamma talks, and even listening to Dhamma. Because without listeners, there can be no Dhamma talk. So, Dhamma listeners are also Dhamma donors.

In the commentary to this Kiṃdada Sutta, there is a beautiful and famous phrase from Dhammapada verse 354 — one you may have seen in Sayadawgyi's books or many Dhamma publications:

*“Sabba dānaṃ Dhamma dānaṃ jināti”*¹¹ —
“The gift of Dhamma surpasses all gifts.”

In the Dhammapada commentary, it is explained that both the Dhamma speaker and the Dhamma listener are donors of Dhamma. Both are offering the gift of deathlessness.

Why does Dhamma donation surpass all other donations?
The Dhammapada commentary gives two reasons.

First, all other donations are made possible only because of the Dhamma. Without listening to the Dhamma, one would not know the value of generosity.

In some countries, there are people who never give donations — not because they are stingy, but because they do not understand how donation works or what its benefits are. Only after hearing the Dhamma do people gain faith, understanding, and the wish to give.

¹¹ Khu.1.64 Dhammapade (Dhammapada verse 354)

So, every act of generosity originates from the Dhamma donation. Therefore, Dhamma donation surpasses all gifts.

The second reason is even deeper.

Except for the Buddhas and *Pacceka Buddhas*, no one can attain enlightenment without first hearing the Dhamma. Even Bhante Sāriputta — so wise and intelligent — could not become enlightened by himself.

He had to listen, at least to one stanza, from Bhante Assaji. Without hearing Dhamma, no attainment is possible.

Let me share with you the story of Samānadevaputta.¹²

During the Buddha's time, there was a *bhikkhu* who practised *Vipassanā* very diligently. He was so devoted to meditation that he neglected sleep and food.

One day, due to excessive effort, he was overcome by a wind ailment and passed away while sitting in a meditation posture. Because of his accumulated merits, he was reborn in the deva realm.

In fact, rebirth in the deva realm happens spontaneously — like going to sleep in one place and waking up suddenly somewhere else.

Most newly born devas are delighted, finding themselves radiant and blissful in their new existence.

¹² Saṃ.Ṭṭha.1.81 (Commentary to SN 1.46 Accharā Sutta).



But this *bhikkhu* — now reborn as Samānadevaputta — did not even realise that he had died. Still seated in the same posture, he continued to meditate.

Some female devas who had been waiting for him at the deva mansion approached him with songs and music to welcome him.

Thinking that he was still in the monastery, he mistook them for female lay devotees!

Feeling embarrassed, he quickly covered his shoulder with his double robe and continued meditating, ignoring them.

Finally, the devas brought a mirror and showed him his reflection. Only then did he realise: “Ah! I am no longer a *bhikkhu* — I have been reborn as a deva!”

And seeing the female devas around him, he thought to himself, “These are not devas — these are demons!”

Even for such a diligent practitioner, now reborn as an ordinary worldling (*puthujjana*), it was impossible to attain enlightenment on his own.

So he went to see the Buddha and requested guidance to escape this “garden of delusion” (*mohana-vana*).

After listening to a short Dhamma talk from the Buddha, he attained *Sotāpatti* Path and Fruition — the first stage of enlightenment.

This shows that even the most diligent meditators cannot gain realisation without hearing the Dhamma. They need, at least once, to listen to the teaching of a Noble One. That is

why Dhamma donation is so vital for the attainment of the Path and Fruition.

Because of these two reasons, Dhamma donation surpasses all donations.

“Sabba dānaṃ Dhamma dānaṃ jināti” —

“The gift of Dhamma surpasses all gifts.”

In this Kiṃdada Sutta, the Buddha taught that if you wish to give the Deathless, you should give Dhamma.

Dhamma donation includes not only teaching but also listening, discussing, asking questions, and even doing supportive work for the Buddha’s Dispensation (*Buddhasāsana*).

According to this sutta, the results of giving depend on what you give.

So, what kind of person would you like to be?

A strong person? A beautiful person? A happy and comfortable person? Or a wise person who has seen the Deathless?

Based on the result you wish to obtain, you can choose your donations accordingly.

May you gain the noble benefits from listening to this Kiṃdada Sutta.

Sādhū! Sādhū! Sādhū!



2. Qualities of Dāna

(Edited from a Dhamma talk given at Dhammavijaya Meditation Centre on 17 March 2018)

Today, I would like to share a short talk about *dāna* — the practice of giving or generosity. The name of the sutta I will refer to is the Chaḷaṇḍadāna Sutta,¹³ or “The Donation with Six Factors.” This discourse taught by the Buddha can be found in the Aṅguttara Nikāya.

There was once a lady living in a city called Veḷukaṇḍakī. At that time, the Buddha was residing in Sāvatthī. Using his divine eye, the Buddha saw that this lady was offering *dāna* to the Saṅgha headed by Venerable Sāriputta and Venerable Mahāmoggallāna.

The Buddha then gathered the *bhikkhus* and expounded on the donation endowed with six factors.

So, what is this type of *dāna* that possesses six factors? And what are those six factors?

There are three factors on the side of the receivers and three on the side of the donors. Together, they make six.

¹³ Añ.2.295 (AN 6.37 Chaḷaṇḍadāna Sutta)



The Three Factors on the Receiver's Side

1. *Vītarāgā vā honti, rāgavinayāya vā paṭipannā.*

The receivers are either those who have completely removed lust or those who are practising to remove lust.

2. *Vītadosā vā honti, dosavinayāya vā paṭipannā.*

They are either those who have removed anger or those who are practising to remove anger.

3. *Vītamohā vā honti, mohavinayāya vā paṭipannā.*

They are either those who have removed delusion or those who are practising to remove delusion.

These are the three factors on the part of the receivers.

According to the commentary, even *sāmaṇeras* (novices) who have just been ordained are considered to be practising to remove lust, anger, and delusion. Therefore, if you have the opportunity to offer to someone who has already removed these three defilements, that is excellent.

However, if you cannot find such noble receivers, you can instead offer to those who are sincerely practising to remove lust, anger, and delusion. All of you here, practising meditation during this retreat, are working to overcome these same defilements. In this way, you also fulfil these three factors on the receiver's side.

Offering to the Buddha

If you wish to find the highest possible receivers, you can make offerings to the Buddha, the Dhamma, and the Saṅgha.

Of course, the Buddha is no longer physically present in this world, so we can only offer to him mentally. But during the Buddha's lifetime, he said that if one makes offerings to *paribhoga cetiyas*, *dhātu cetiyas*, *dhamma cetiyas*, or *uddissa cetiyas*, it is equivalent to offering directly to the Buddha.

- ***Paribhoga cetiyas*** include the personal belongings of the Buddha — such as his water filter, walking stick, robes, or alms bowl — as well as pagodas where these items are enshrined, and even the Bodhi tree under which the Buddha attained enlightenment. These are considered objects used by the Buddha.
- ***Dhātu cetiyas*** refer to the Buddha's relics and the stupas or shrines where these relics are enshrined.
- ***Dhamma cetiyas*** include manuscripts, palm leaves, or golden plates on which the Buddha's teachings are recorded, the Dhamma books and the stupas or edifices where these are kept.
- ***Uddissa cetiyas*** refer to images or statues of the Buddha made as representations of him, to which we pay respect.

When you offer to any of these *cetiyas* with the same mind and devotion as if you were offering directly to the Buddha,



the results will be the same. Therefore, this is the most meritorious way of giving.

Offering to the Dhamma

The Buddha also said that offering to the Dhamma brings the highest result. He taught, “One who sees the Dhamma sees me; one who sees me sees the Dhamma.”¹⁴ This means that the Dhamma and the Buddha are inseparable.

Another point is that when the Buddha was near his *Parinibbāna*, Venerable Ānanda became worried. But the Buddha told Venerable Ānanda, “*Mayā dhammo ca vinayo ca desito paññatto, so vo mamaccayena satthā.*”¹⁵ “I have taught the Dhamma. I have laid down the Vinaya. These will be your teachers after the Buddha passes away.” In this way, following exactly what the Buddha taught, we can pay respect to the Dhamma.

So, what is the Dhamma? The Dhamma comprises the nine types of supramundane Dhamma — the four Paths, the four Fruitions, and *Nibbāna* — as well as the Dhamma that is the Buddha’s Teaching compiled in the *Tipiṭaka*.

¹⁴ Saṃ.2.98 (SN 22.87 Vakkali Sutta)

yo kho, vakkali, dhammaṃ passati so maṃ passati; yo maṃ passati so dhammaṃ passati. dhammañhi, vakkali, passanto maṃ passati; maṃ passanto dhammaṃ passati

“One who sees the Dhamma sees me; one who sees me sees the Dhamma. For in seeing the Dhamma, Vakkali, one sees me; and in seeing me, one sees the Dhamma.”

¹⁵ Dī.2.126-127 (DN 16 Mahāparinnibāna Sutta)

When someone practises *Vipassanā* systematically and diligently, when his insight knowledge matures, he will attain Path and Fruition (*magga-phala*) and realise Nibbāna. By listening to and practising according to the Buddha's Teaching, one will eventually see Nibbāna. When the mind has attained *magga-phala*, one has seen the Dhamma, seen Nibbāna, and seen the true essence of the Buddha's Teaching.

For those who have attained *magga-phala*, they understand that there is a Buddha who teaches the way to realise Nibbāna. They also understand that there is the Saṅgha who improve themselves in the Dhamma by practising according to the Teaching. Because of this, they have no doubts about the Buddha, the Dhamma, and the Saṅgha, as they have personally realised *magga-phala* and Nibbāna by practising *sīla*, *samādhi*, and *paññā* (morality, concentration, and wisdom). In the Buddha's Teachings, seeing the Dhamma means seeing Nibbāna and seeing the Buddha's teachings (*sīla*, *samādhi*, and *paññā*). In this way, we may offer *dāna* with the Dhamma in mind.

Relating to the Dhamma, you have come here today to offer. Here, there are different kinds of people: Bhikkhus, Sayalays, and lay people. But if, when you are making an offering, you contemplate that they are practising the Buddha's Dhamma, then it becomes an offering to the Dhamma. By offering to the Dhamma, you gain one of the highest possible fields of merit.



Offering to the Saṅgha

Another of the highest receivers is the Saṅgha. The Saṅgha refers to a community that lives together in harmony, adhering to the same Rules and sharing the same Right View. What are the Rules observed by all members of the Saṅgha? They are the 227 Bhikkhu *Pāṭimokkha* Rules. Many people know about the 227 Bhikkhu Rules. These are the Rules that all monks observe when they are ordained. Every bhikkhu practises according to this same set of Rules.

Another common factor to all members of the Saṅgha is that they share the same Right View: the correct understanding of the Four Noble Truths. They do not hold any contradictory views. Likewise, they share the same understanding of the 37 Bodhipakkhiyā Dhammas, the factors of enlightenment. They do not differ in these views. Noble bhikkhus (*ariya-bhikkhu*) do not intentionally break any Rules, so they remain unchanging with respect to the Vinaya. They also do not change their views regarding the Four Noble Truths. Therefore, the Noble Saṅgha always keeps the same Rules and holds the same Right View.

It is this Saṅgha of the Noble Ones that is referred to when one takes refuge in the Saṅgha by reciting “*Saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi.*” (“I go for refuge to the Saṅgha”).

However, ordinary bhikkhus are also trying to follow these Rules. If they break any Rule, they confess, make amends, and become pure again with respect to the Vinaya. Even though they are not yet well-established in the Dhamma,

they are still included in the general Saṅgha. Strictly speaking, they are not the Saṅgha referred to in “*Saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi*” but in a broader sense, they are still considered the Saṅgha in that refuge formula.

The Saṅgha is a refuge. As a refuge, it means the Saṅgha cannot be wrong; it must always be right. All members follow the same Rules and uphold the same Right View. Because of this, it is easy to reflect on the qualities of the Saṅgha. The ordinary Saṅgha represents the Saṅgha in general, so the Buddha also allowed us to pay respect to the ordinary Saṅgha.

Once, the Buddha’s aunt, Mahāpajāpati Gotamī, came to the Buddha and tried to offer robes to Him. At that time, the Buddha encouraged Gotamī¹⁶: “*Saṅghe, Gotamī, dehi.*” “Aunt Gotamī, please offer them to the Saṅgha.” “*Saṅghe te dinne ahañceva pūjito bhavissāmi saṅgho ca.*” “If you make an offering to the Saṅgha, it is an offering to me and to the Saṅgha at the same time.”

So, offering to the Saṅgha brings great benefit. Why is this so?

Because when Aunt Gotamī came to make the offering, she already had the *cetanā* (volition) to offer to the Buddha. With the opportunity to offer to the Saṅgha, she would generate an additional wholesome *cetanā*. This is one reason why it becomes more beneficial.

¹⁶ Ma.3.296 (MN 142 Dakkhināvivhaṅga Sutta) – Please also refer to Talk 3. Dakkhināvivhaṅga Sutta.



Another reason is that if someone offers to the Saṅgha, they are offering to both the Saṅgha and the Buddha at the same time. How is this so? The Buddha lived only 45 years after His Enlightenment. After that, the Saṅgha undertook the responsibility of preserving and propagating the Buddha's Teaching. The Buddha appeared in the world for the sake of teaching the Dhamma, and the Saṅgha continues to teach the Buddha's Dhamma after the Buddha's *Parinibbāna*. In this way, the Saṅgha is carrying out the Buddha's duties and responsibilities. Therefore, offering to the Saṅgha is also an offering to the Buddha. Because of these reasons, the Buddha encouraged Aunt Gotamī to make her offerings to the Saṅgha.

As receivers of offerings, both the Buddha and the Saṅgha are noble. We cannot compare who is better, because it is not possible to compare a group with an individual. We should compare individuals with individuals, and groups with groups. As an individual, the Buddha is the noblest. As a group, the Saṅgha is the noblest.

There is another reason. If the Buddha did not encourage people to offer to the Saṅgha, after His passing away, the Buddha's Teaching would not last long. Without support, the Saṅgha might be unable to fulfil their responsibility of teaching the Dhamma, and the Buddha's Teaching could disappear quickly. Therefore, the Buddha encouraged Aunt Gotamī to offer to the Saṅgha to ensure the longevity of the Buddha's Teaching and to support future teachers.

So how should you offer? Even though the bhikkhus you see may be ordinary bhikkhus, if you offer to them while reflecting on the qualities of the Saṅgha such as “*suppaṭipanno bhagavato sāvakaśaṅgho...*” it yields the same benefit as offering to the Noble Saṅgha. By doing so, you generate more powerful wholesome merits that bring great benefits and strong results.

The Donor’s Three Factors

So, what about the three factors on the donor’s side?

1. **Before donating**, you should be joyful and motivated by wholesome intention.
2. **While donating**, you should maintain a happy and calm mind.
3. **After donating**, you should recollect the act of giving with joy, reflecting, “I have done wholesome actions. I have done something for my benefit, and it will also benefit the Saṅgha for a long time.”

In the future, whenever you reflect on this *dāna* and feel joy, wholesome states will arise in you again. The wholesome result from this offering will arise within you for a longer time. If you can maintain a wholesome mind for a long period, you can receive higher results and develop strong, high-quality wholesomeness. By reflecting again and again, more wholesome kamma is accumulated.



Immeasurable Benefits

If you can make an offering with these six factors accomplished — three on the receiver’s side and three on the donor’s side — how great will the benefits be? We cannot measure how much happiness in the human realm you will experience. We also cannot measure how much happiness in the deva realm you will experience. It cannot be quantified. The only way to express it is: *“asaṅkhyeyyo appameyyo mahāpuñṇakkhandho tveva,”* which means, “There is a great heap of merit that is uncountable and immeasurable.”

To explain this, the Buddha gave a simile using the immeasurable amount of water in the ocean. If someone were to ask, “How much water is there in the sea?” We cannot say how much water there is. We can only say, *“asaṅkhyeyyo appameyyo mahāudakakkhandho tveva,”* which means, “In the sea, there is a great mass of water that is uncountable and immeasurable.”¹⁷

¹⁷ Añ.1.366 (AN 4.51 Paṭhamapuñṇābhisanda Sutta):

“seyyathāpi, bhikkhave, mahāsamudde na sukaraṃ udakassa pamāṇaṃ gahetuṃ — ‘ettakāni udakāḷhakānīti vā, ettakāni udakāḷhakasatānīti vā, ettakāni udakāḷhakasahassānīti vā, ettakāni udakāḷhakasatasahassānīti vā’, atha kho asaṅkhyeyyo appameyyo mahāudakakkhandhotveva saṅkhyāṃ gacchatī; ...”

“Bhikkhus, just as it is not easy to measure the water in the great ocean thus: ‘There are so many gallons of water,’ or ‘There are so many hundreds of gallons of water,’ or ‘There are so many thousands of gallons of water,’ or ‘There are so many hundreds of thousands of gallons of water,’ but rather it is reckoned simply as an incalculable, immeasurable, great mass of water; ...”

*mahodadhiṃ aparimitaṃ mahāsaraṃ,
bahubheravaṃ ratanavarānamālayaṃ.*

Conclusion

So now, you have the precious opportunity to offer to the Buddha, the Dhamma, the Saṅgha, and the practitioners who are sincerely training in this path. As you are cultivating and improving your qualities, you should reflect with happiness that you have done much wholesomeness which will bring greater benefits for a long time in the future.

By doing so, your *dāna* will bring abundant benefits, supporting both your present happiness and your future progress on the path.

Sādhu! Sādhu! Sādhu!

*najjo yathā naragaṇasaṅghasevitā,
puthū savantī upayanti sāgaram.*

Just as the many rivers used by the hosts of people,
flowing downstream, reach the ocean,
the great mass of water, the boundless sea,
the fearsome receptacle of heaps of gems;
*evaṃ naraṃ annadapānavatthadaṃ,
seyyānisajjattharaṇassa dāyakam.*
*puñṇassa dhārā upayanti paṇḍitaṃ,
najjo yathā vārivahāva sāgaram.*

So the streams of merit reach the wise man
Who is a giver of food, drink, and cloth;
[they reach] the donor of beds, seats, and covers
like rivers carrying their waters to the sea.



3. Dakkhiṇāvibhaṅga Sutta

(Edited from Dhamma talks given at Nandaka Vihāra on 23–25 June 2019)

Today I will give a short talk related to donations. The name of the sutta is the Dakkhiṇā-vibhaṅga Sutta.¹⁸ *Dakkhiṇā-vibhaṅga* means the classification or analysis of donations.

Who Is the More Superior Donor—The Buddha or Venerable Sāriputta?

In the commentary to this sutta, there is a question raised: Which is more superior—an offering by the Perfectly Enlightened Buddha to the Chief Disciple Venerable Sāriputta, or an offering by Venerable Sāriputta to the Perfectly Enlightened Buddha? Which offering is more beneficial? What do you think?

The answer is that the offering by the Buddha to his chief disciple is more superior. What is the reason? Apart from the Perfectly Enlightened Buddha, there is no one else who can fully know the fruits of *dāna*.¹⁹ Only the Buddha, with his

¹⁸ Ma.3.295 (MN 142 Dakkhiṇāvibhaṅga Sutta)

¹⁹ Ma.Ṭṭha.4.227 (Commentary to MN 142 Dakkhiṇāvibhaṅga Sutta):

*kiṃ pana sammāsambuddhena sāriputtattherassa dinnaṃ mahapphalaṃ,
udāhu sāriputtattherena sammāsambuddhassa dinnanti.
sammāsambuddhena sāriputtattherassa dinnaṃ mahapphalanti vadanti.
sammāsambuddhañhi ṭhapetvā añño dānassa vipākaṃ jānituṃ samattho
nāma natthi.*



omniscient knowledge, has a complete understanding of the distinction of karmic results of giving. Because of this superior purity in knowledge regarding donation, the Buddha's offering is more superior.

From this, we can conclude that the more thoroughly one understands *dāna*, the more superior and more fruitful his offering will be. Therefore, we should try to understand as much as possible about the various aspects of *dāna* in order to reap the maximum benefit from an act of giving. This is also why I am giving this talk on the Dakkhiṇā-vibhaṅga Sutta, so that you may gain more knowledge about *dāna*.

Mahāpajāpati Gotamī's Offering

The Dakkhiṇā-vibhaṅga Sutta is quite long. We may not have enough time to explain everything, but I will highlight the important points.

The *sutta* begins with the Buddha's aunt, Mahāpajāpati Gotamī. She wished to offer a pair of clothes that she had made herself to the Buddha.

"Gotamī" is the name of her clan.

Moreover, when she was born, on the day she was given her name, brahmins who could read bodily marks examined her. They made this prediction:

"In the future, if she gives birth to a daughter, the daughter will become the chief queen of a Cakkavatti king (a universal monarch). If she gives birth to a son, the son will become a

Cakkavatti king. In either case, there will be many great (*mahatī*) descendants (*pajā*).”

Because of this prediction, she was named “Mahāpajāpati”, which means “great wife”²⁰.

In the Pāḷi texts, her relationship with the Buddha is often described using the word *mātucchā*. This word means “mother’s sister”, or simply “aunt”. In Myanmar translations, this word is sometimes rendered also as “*mithway*”, meaning “father’s second wife” or “stepmother”.

It is acceptable to call her either the Buddha’s aunt or stepmother, because she was both: she was the sister of the Bodhisatta’s mother, and also the second wife of his father. However, the more accurate meaning of *mātucchā* is “aunt”. The translation as “stepmother” came from an unclear understanding in early Myanmar usage.

One day, Aunt Gotamī approached the Buddha to offer a new pair of clothes. She said: “Bhante, this new pair of clothes was spun by me and woven by me, especially for the Blessed One. Bhante, let the Blessed One accept it from me out of compassion.”

However, the Buddha encouraged her to offer the clothes to the *Saṅgha* instead:

²⁰ Abhidhānappadīpikaṭikā, 2. Bhūkaṇḍa, 3. Naravaggavaṇṇanā (Page 171 paragraph 237):

Pajāṃ puttāṃ pāletīti pajāpati – one who protects offsprings, sons (and daughters), is called *pajāpati* (wife).



“Saṅghe, Gotami, dehi. Saṅghe te dinne ahañceva pūjito bhavissāmi saṅgho cā.”

“Give it to the *Saṅgha*, Gotamī. When you give it to the Saṅgha, both I and the Saṅgha will be honoured.”

Offering to the Saṅgha Instead of the Buddha

Why did the Buddha encourage his aunt to offer the clothes to the Saṅgha instead? The commentary gives two reasons.

The first reason was out of compassion for his aunt, so that she could gain more wholesomeness. When she first decided to offer the robes to the Buddha, that was one set of wholesome deeds involving three volitions: the prior volition (*pubba-cetanā*), the releasing volition (*muñca-cetanā*), and the subsequent volition (*apara-cetanā*). When she was encouraged to offer the robes to the Saṅgha instead, a new set of these three volitions—now directed to the Saṅgha—would arise. These combined six volitions would yield greater merit for her welfare and happiness for a long time.

The second reason was to inspire future generations to show respect to the Saṅgha, and by supporting the Saṅgha with the four requisites, help ensure the longevity of the Buddha’s Dispensation. The Buddha considered, “I will not remain long, but my Dispensation will be established in the *bhikkhusaṅgha*. Let future generations develop reverence for the Saṅgha.”

The Buddha taught for only 45 years. After his *parinibbāna*, the Saṅgha would be responsible for spreading the Dhamma and maintaining the Dispensation.

When future generations remember, “Even something offered to the Buddha himself, the Teacher directed to be offered to the Saṅgha, for the Saṅgha is truly worthy of offerings,” they will develop reverence and support the Saṅgha.

Free from concerns about the four requisites, the Saṅgha can learn and preserve the Buddha’s teachings, fulfil the monastic practices, thereby sustaining and leading to the long-lasting of the Buddha’s Dispensation.

Because of this, when someone offers to the Saṅgha, it is an offering to the Saṅgha and also to the Buddha.

For these two reasons, the Buddha said to his aunt,

“saṅghe, gotamī, dehi. saṅghe te dinne ahañceva pūjito bhavissāmi saṅgho cā”ti –

“Give it to the *Saṅgha*, Gotamī. When you give it to the *Saṅgha*, both I and the *Saṅgha* will be honoured”.

From this example, we can see that the Buddha wants his disciples to regard the Saṅgha in the same light as the Buddha.



The Dhamma as the Buddha

The Buddha wants his disciples to regard not only the Saṅgha, but also the Dhamma, in the same light as the Buddha himself. Just before his *parinibbāna*, the Buddha told Bhante Ānanda:

“Yo vo, Ānanda, mayā dhammo ca vinayo ca desito paññatto, so vo mamaccaṃyena satthā.”²¹

“Ānanda, I have expounded the Dhamma and laid down the Vinaya for you; the Dhamma and Vinaya will be your teacher when the Buddha passes away”.

On an earlier occasion, the Buddha told Bhante Vakkali:

“yo kho, vakkali, dhammaṃ passati so maṃ passati; yo maṃ passati so dhammaṃ passati. dhammañhi, vakkali, passanto maṃ passati; maṃ passanto dhammaṃ passati”²². –

“Vakkali, whoever sees the Dhamma sees me; whoever sees me sees the Dhamma. For the one seeing the Dhamma sees me, and the one seeing me sees the Dhamma”.

Thus, the Buddha advises his disciples to regard the Dhamma as the Buddha.

²¹ Dī.2.16-127 (DN16 Mahāparinibbāna Sutta)

²² Saṃ.2.98 (SN 22.87 Vakkali Sutta)

The Buddha, the Dhamma, and the Saṅgha together constitute the Three Refuges. They cannot be separated. Some may claim to believe only in the Buddha but not in the Dhamma or the Saṅgha. Some may claim to believe in the Dhamma but not the Saṅgha. But with a correct understanding of the Buddha's teaching, one will see that they are inseparable.

Therefore, we should try to know the Dhamma well. When we know the Dhamma, we will understand the Buddha and the Saṅgha better.

For example, now you are practising *sīla* (morality). When you practise *sīla*, you gain its benefits. As you experience these benefits, you understand for yourself that the practice of *sīla* can lead to peace. You will also understand that there are members of the Saṅgha and lay practitioners whose minds become peaceful through the practice of *sīla*.

Similarly, if you practise *samatha* (concentration), you may improve your concentration and even attain *jhāna*. Through this, you will directly understand the Buddha better, because who can teach the way to attain *jhāna*? It is the Buddha. You will also understand that there are members of the Saṅgha and other practitioners who attain *jhāna* by following the Buddha's methods.

In the same way, if you make progress in *vipassanā*, eventually you will directly see Nibbāna. Then you will have profound understanding of the Dhamma. You will know directly that the supramundane Dhamma—Nibbāna—really



exists. You will also understand that the three trainings of morality, concentration, and wisdom really lead to Nibbāna. You will know that there is a Buddha who taught this path; that there are disciples who practise and realise Nibbāna; and that there is the Noble Saṅgha who has seen Nibbāna.

You will know these things without doubt because you experience them directly. You will understand with certainty who the Buddha is, what the Dhamma is, and that the well-practised Saṅgha truly exists.

One kind of wrong view is the belief that there are no practitioners who can progress in the Dhamma. They do not believe in spontaneously born beings or in good and bad actions.²³ If we practise the Dhamma well, we can remove these wrong views. Then we will believe, and have more faith in the Buddha, the Dhamma, and the Saṅgha.

²³ Di.1.51 (DN 2 Sāmaññaphala Sutta) and others:

‘natthi dinnam, natthi yiṭṭham, natthi hutam, natthi sukatadukkaṭānaṃ kammānaṃ phalaṃ vipāko, natthi ayaṃ loko, natthi paro loko, natthi mātā, natthi pitā, natthi sattā opapātikā, natthi loke samaṇabrāhmaṇā sammaggaṭā sammāpaṭipannā, ye imaṃ lokaṃ paraṃ lokaṃ sayamaṃ abhiññā sacchikatvā pavedenti.’

There is nothing given, nothing offered, nothing sacrificed; no fruit or result of good and bad actions; no this world, no other world; no mother, no father; no beings who are reborn spontaneously; no good and virtuous recluses and brahmins in the world who have themselves realised by direct knowledge and declare this world and the other world.

“The Buddha Is Concealed by the Statues”

There is a saying by a senior Sayadaw in Myanmar: “The real Buddha is concealed by the statues.”

People make many kinds of Buddha statues—some with a swastika sign on the chest, some holding medicines. They make statues according to their own ideas.

For those who have not learned the Dhamma well, they may become confused by the different forms of Buddha statues and may not know who the real Buddha is. Therefore, the Sayadaw said, “the real Buddha is concealed by the statues.”

So whenever you see a Buddha statue, whatever its form, you should not think of it only as a statue. You should reflect on who it represents—the real Buddha; his qualities of morality, concentration, and wisdom; and what he accomplished. You should reflect upon the real historical Buddha and his qualities.

“The Dhamma Is Concealed by Dhamma Speakers”

There is another saying: “The real Dhamma is concealed by Dhamma speakers.”

Some speakers like to tell interesting stories or jokes, and the listeners may become confused about what the real Dhamma is.



In Myanmar, Dhamma speakers rely on a fixed set of reference books—the *Tipiṭaka*. Teachings must come from these texts. Many senior Sayadaws understand these books in the original Pāli, and they can discuss what is correct or not according to them. Therefore, Dhamma speakers should teach only according to the *Tipiṭaka*, so that the real Dhamma is not concealed.

Learning the Dhamma is different from worldly education. In worldly education, you first learn the existing information and then create new knowledge based on it. Research and development work in this way, sometimes even proving previous ideas wrong.

But the Buddha’s teaching is already correct. There is no need to change or add anything. We simply try to understand, memorise, and practise it—without adding our own ideas, especially without creating new doctrines.

Worldly knowledge keeps changing because it is ordinary human knowledge—it cannot be perfectly correct. Generations upon generations keep trying to refine and correct it, and this process has no end.

But the Buddha’s teaching is already definite and certain. There is no need to search for another approach. And there is an end to the Buddha’s education—becoming an Arahant, free from all suffering. Through Dhamma practice, if one becomes an Arahant, that is the end point of Dhamma learning. There is no need to work anymore. In the suttas, it is commonly described as “*kataṃ karaṇīyaṃ*” – “what had to

be done has been done.” This is a standard declaration by one who has attained Arahantship.²⁴

“The Saṅgha Is Concealed by Ordinary Bhikkhus”

Another saying by the Sayadaw is: “The Saṅgha is concealed by ordinary bhikkhus.”

Ordinary bhikkhus are those who have not seen Nibbāna and are therefore not part of the Noble Saṅgha. When defilements arise in them, they may make mistakes or act improperly. Those who do not understand the Dhamma well may become confused, wondering whether these *bhikkhus* represent the real Saṅgha. That is why the Sayadaw said that “the real *Saṅgha* is concealed by ordinary bhikkhus.”

We need to learn the qualities of the real Saṅgha—their morality, concentration, and wisdom. Just as a Buddha statue

²⁴ Dī.1.166 (DN 8 Mahāsīhanāda Sutta) and others:

*acirūpasampanno kho paṇāyasmā kassapo eko vūpakaṭṭho appamatto ātāpī pahitatto viharanto na cirasseva — yassatthāya kulaputtā sammadeva agāasmā anagāriyaṃ pabbajanti, tadanuttaraṃ — brahmacariyapariyosānaṃ diṭṭheva dhamme sayam abhiññā sacchikatvā upasampajja vihāsi. ‘khīṇā jāti, vusitaṃ brahmacariyaṃ, **kataṃ karaṇīyaṃ**, nāparaṃ itthattāyā’ti — abbhaññāsi. aññataro kho paṇāyasmā kassapo arahataṃ ahoṣīti.*

And soon, not long after his full admission, dwelling along, withdrawn, diligent, ardent, and resolute, the Venerable Kassapa, by realising for himself with direct knowledge, here and now entered upon and abided in that supreme goal of the holy life for the sake of which clansmen rightly go forth from the home life into homelessness. He directly knew: “Birth is destroyed, the holy life has been lived, **what had to be done has been done**, there is no more coming to any state of being.” And the Venerable Kassapa became one of the arahants.



represents the Buddha, an ordinary *bhikkhu* represents the Saṅgha. An ordinary *bhikkhu* wears the same robes as the Noble Saṅgha and follows a similar monastic discipline. The Noble Saṅgha does not eat after noon; an ordinary *bhikkhu* should likewise observe this rule. At times, however, an ordinary *bhikkhu* may break precepts. When that happens, he no longer represents the Noble Saṅgha.

You need to see deeply to understand the real Buddha. For example, during the Buddha's time, a demon chased a lady, wanting to eat her baby. She ran to the monastery to seek the Buddha's protection. The Buddha saved her baby, and the demon even became a *sotāpanna* after listening to the Buddha's teaching²⁵. But if you are being chased by a demon today and you run to the statue in front of us, it is not certain that you will be safe, because the statue is not the real Buddha. Still, the statue is beneficial because it helps you reflect on the Buddha's true qualities; it helps you remember the real Buddha.

In the same way, an ordinary *bhikkhu* is quite similar to the Noble Saṅgha. He wears the same robes as the Noble Saṅgha. He trains to have the same morality, develops the same view about the Four Noble Truths, and cultivates the same perception of suffering, impermanence, non-self, and

²⁵ Dhp.Ṭṭha.1.30 Dhammapade (Commentary to Dhammapada Verse 5, Kāḷayakkhinīvatthu)

Dhammapada verse 5:

na hi verena verāṇi, sammantīdha kudācanaṃ;

averena ca sammanti, esa dhammo sanantano.

Hatred is never appeased by hatred in this world.

By non-hatred alone is hatred appeased. This is a law eternal.

foulness. Although his morality may not be perfectly pure and he may not always have Right View, he is trying to develop these qualities. Therefore, an ordinary *bhikkhu* can still be a good source of inspiration. He is the representation of the Noble Saṅgha to help you reflect on the true qualities of the real Saṅgha and to have a better understanding of the real Saṅgha.

These are some understandings about the Three Refuges—the Buddha, the Dhamma, and the Saṅgha.

Different Categories of Receivers

I will continue with the Dakkhiṇā-vibhaṅga Sutta. In this *sutta*, the Buddha explains the different categories of receivers and ranks them according to their fruitfulness as recipients. Depending on the receiver, your offering can produce different benefits—some more superior, some less superior.

According to the type of receiver, offerings can be broadly classified into two categories:

1. **Offering to individual receivers** (*pāṭi-puggalika dakkhiṇā*)
2. **Offering to the Saṅgha as a group** (*saṅgha-gata dakkhiṇā*)



Fourteen Types of Individual Offerings

The Buddha first explains that there are fourteen types of offerings to individual receivers. Each of them yields different degrees of benefit. We will start with the one that gives the lowest benefit.²⁶

1.

The first type of individual offering is giving a gift to an animal (*tiracchāna-gate dānaṃ deti*) with the expectation of receiving future benefit from this giving. This type of offering may be expected to repay a hundredfold in the five aspects of life span, beauty, happiness, strength, and intelligence. This means that you can obtain long life, beauty, happiness, strength, and intelligence across one hundred lives. An animal is considered the lowest category of receiver.

2.

The second type of offering is giving a gift to an immoral ordinary person (*puthujjana-dussīle dānaṃ deti*)—someone who breaks the five precepts and engages in wrong livelihood, such as a fisherman or a hunter. Such a person may commit killing, take what is not given, engage in sexual misconduct, tell lies, and consume intoxicants such as

²⁶ In the *Dakkhiṇāvibhaṅga Sutta*, the Buddha first lists the receivers of gifts from the highest to the lowest. He then explains the benefits of giving, beginning with the smallest and ending with the greatest. In this section, since we are combining both receivers and benefits, we follow the order of benefits as explained in the *Sutta*.

alcohol. He has no morality or very poor morality. An offering to such a person may be expected to repay a thousandfold. This can be understood in the same way as the earlier example of giving to an animal, except that this is ten times more beneficial.

3.

The third type of offering is giving a gift to a virtuous ordinary person (*puthujjana-sīlavante dānaṃ deti*)—someone who practises the cow-rituals, is honest, free from deceit, does not oppress others, and earns a living righteously and justly through farming or trading²⁷. This offering may be expected to repay a hundred-thousandfold (100,000 times), which is one hundred times more than the previous offering.

4.

The fourth type of offering is giving a gift to one outside the Buddha's Dispensation who is free from lust for sensual pleasures (*bāhirake kāmesu vītarāge dānaṃ deti*). This refers to someone endowed with the eight attainments and the five mundane supernatural powers. He has *jhāna* absorptions but is not a disciple of the Buddha. He does not understand or take refuge in the Buddha, the Dhamma, or the Saṅgha. A gift

²⁷ Ma.Ṭṭha.4.223 (Commentary to MN142 Dakkhiṇāvibhaṅga Sutta):

puthujjanasīlavanteti puthujjanasīlavā nāma gosīladhātuko hoti, asaṭṭho amāyāvī paramaṃ apīletvā dhammena samena kasiyā vā vaṇijjāya vā jīvikam kappetā.



to such a person may be expected to repay a trillion-fold (*koṭi-sata-sahassa-guṇa* – 10^{12} times).

5.

The fifth type of offering is giving a gift to one who has entered upon the way to the realisation of the fruit of stream-entry (*sotāpatti-phala-sacchikiriya* *paṭipanne dānaṃ deti*). The commentary explains that this includes even a lay person who has taken the Three Refuges (*tisaraṇaṃ gato upāsako*). A gift given to such a person may be expected to repay incalculably and immeasurably (*asaṅkheyya appameyya*).

The merit becomes progressively greater for²⁸:

- one established in the five precepts (*pañcasīle patiṭṭhitassa*),
- one established in the ten precepts (*dasasīle patiṭṭhitassa*),
- a novice who has gone forth that very day (*tadahu-pabbajitassa sāmaṇerassa*),

²⁸ Ma.Ṭṭha.4.223 (Commentary to MN142 Dakkhināvivhaṅga Sutta):

sotāpattiphalasacchikiriya paṭipanneti ettha heṭṭhimakoṭiyā tisaraṇaṃ gato upāsakopi sotāpattiphalasacchikiriya paṭipanno nāma, tasmim dinnadānampi asaṅkheyyaṃ appameyyaṃ. pañcasīle patiṭṭhitassa tato uttari mahapphalaṃ, dasasīle patiṭṭhitassa tato uttari, tadahupabbajitassa sāmaṇerassa tato uttari, upasampannabhikkhuno tato uttari, upasampannasseva vattasampannassa tato uttari, vipassakassa tato uttari, āradhavi-passakassa tato uttari, uttamakoṭiyā pana maggasaṃgā sotāpattiphalasacchikiriya paṭipanno nāma. etassa dinnadānaṃ tato uttari mahapphalameva.

- a fully ordained bhikkhu (*upasampanna-bhikkhuno*),
- a fully ordained bhikkhu who is accomplished in his observances and duties (*upasampannasseva vatta-sampannassa*),
- one practising tender insight (*vipassaka*),
- one practising deeper insight (*āradḍha-vipassaka*), and
- at the highest point, one endowed with the Path (*magga-samaṅgī*).

So this fifth category covers a very wide range—from a lay follower who has taken the Three Refuges all the way to the Noble person endowed with the stream-entry Path.

The sub-commentary explains why this wide range of people are included²⁹:

²⁹ Ma.Ṭikā.2.410 (Sub-commentary to MN142 Dakkhiṇāvibhaṅga Sutta):

Sāsanāvataranaṃ nāma yāvadeva vaṭṭadukkhanittharaṇatthaṃ, tañca maggapaṭivedhanaṃ, tasmā nibbedhabhāgiyasaraṇagamaṇaṃ sikkhāpadasamādānaṃ pabbajjā upasampadā sīlaparipūraṇaṃ adhiccittasikkhānuyogo vipassanābhāvanāti sabbāpesā sotāpatti phalasacchikiriyaṃ paṭipatti eva hotīti āha – “tisaraṇaṃ gato upāsakopi” ’tiādi. Tattha yathā nibbedhabhāgiyo samādhī tāva nāma paramparāya ariyamaggādhigamassa paccayabhāvato upanissayo; tathā nibbedhabhāgiyaṃ sīlaparipūraṇaṃ upasampadā pabbajjā upāsakassa dasasu pañcasu sīlesu paṭiṭṭhānaṃ antamaso saraṇādigamanampi nibbedhabhāgiyaṃ ariyamaggādhigamassa upanissayo hotiyevāti, “sabbāpesā sotāpatti phalasacchikiriyaṃ paṭipatti” ’ti vuttā.

The entry into the Buddha’s Dispensation is solely for the purpose of transcending the suffering of the round of existence, and that transcendence comes through the penetration of the Path. Therefore,



The whole purpose of entering the Buddha's Dispensation is to escape the suffering of the round of existence. This escape happens by attaining the Path.

Therefore, all the following steps that lead toward this goal count as practice for achieving the Stream-Entry Path and are included as one who has entered upon the way to the realisation of the fruit of stream-entry:

- Taking the three refuges (in the Buddha, the Dhamma, and the Saṅgha)
- Keeping the training rules
- Going forth and taking higher ordination
- Fulfilling moral conduct
- Practicing concentration meditation
- Developing insight wisdom

This is why even a lay person who has simply taken the three refuges is included.

going for refuge that is conducive to penetration, undertaking the training rules, going forth, higher ordination, fulfilment of virtue, the pursuit of higher mind training (concentration training), and the development of insight—all these are considered the practice for the realisation of the fruit of stream-entry. Therefore, it is said that even a lay follower who has gone for the three refuges and so forth are included.

Therein, just as concentration that is conducive to penetration indeed becomes a decisive support condition for the successive attainments of the Noble Path, so too the fulfilment of virtue that is conducive to penetration, higher ordination, going forth, a lay follower's establishment in the ten or five precepts, or even the mere going for refuge and so forth that is conducive to penetration—all of these are indeed decisive support conditions for the attainment of the Noble Path. Thus it is said: "All of this is the practice for the realisation of the fruit of stream-entry."

Just as deep concentration is a decisive support condition for the successive attainments of the Noble Path, so too are all these other practices—even something as fundamental as taking refuge in the Three Refuges—essential foundations for reaching the Noble Path. Each one serves as a decisive support condition.

The Power of Taking the Three Refuges

Here I would like to highlight an important point. Giving to one who has merely taken the Three Refuges—even without undertaking any precepts—is far more beneficial than giving to one outside of the Buddha’s Dispensation who is virtuous or even possesses concentration attainments. This shows the great power of taking the Three Refuges.

As Buddhists, you understand the true meaning of taking refuge and the qualities of the Triple Gem. You may also understand morality, even though sometimes you may break the precepts. But because you know what the Buddha, the Dhamma, and the Saṅgha truly are, it is possible for you to eventually gain attainments. Therefore, taking the Three Refuges is superior to merely practising morality or concentration outside the Buddha’s Dispensation³⁰.

³⁰ The sub-commentary further elaborates:
Ma.Ṭikā.2.410 (Sub-commentary to MN142 Dakkhiṇāvibhaṅga Sutta):



During the Buddha's time, Aṅgulimāla and the demon Ālavaka did not observe morality in the beginning. But later, because of the Buddha, they took the Three Refuges and followed his teaching. Eventually, both became Noble ones. This shows how powerful taking refuge is—it opens the door to realisation.

This is also why giving to someone who has taken the Three Refuges is more fruitful than giving to someone with only morality but without the Three Refuges.

Tattha anaññasādhāraṇa-vijjācaraṇādi-asaṅkhyeyyāparimeyya-guṇa-samudayapūrite bhagavati saddhamme ariyaśaṅghe uḷāratarabahumānagāravatam gato. "Sammāsambuddho bhagavā, svākhāto dhammo, suppaṭipanno saṅgho'ti tapparāyaṇatādiākārappatto ñāṇaparisoḍhito pasādo saraṇagamananti tena vatthugatena pasādena paribhāvite santāne kataṃ puññakkhettsampattiyā mahapphalaṃ mahānisaṃsameva hotīti āha – "tasmim dinnadānampi asaṅkhyeyyaṃ appameyyaṃ 'ti.

Therein, [one who has] gone with supreme reverence and respect toward the Blessed One who is endowed with an accumulation of innumerable and immeasurable qualities such as knowledge and conduct that are not shared with others, toward the true Dhamma, and toward the noble Sangha; [one whose] confidence has been purified by knowledge, having attained the aspect of having them as refuge [thinking] 'The Blessed One is perfectly enlightened, the Dhamma is well-proclaimed, the Sangha practices well'—this is going for refuge. Therefore, he says: 'Even a gift given in that [state], with one's mental continuum imbued with the confidence based on those objects, is of great fruit and great benefit through the accomplishment of a field of merit—it is incalculable and immeasurable.'

6.

The sixth type of offering is giving a gift to a stream-enterer (*sotāpanne dānaṃ deti*), one who has attained the stream-entry fruition. If we talk about the eight individual noble persons, this is the second one. If we refer to the four pairs, then the one endowed with the stream-entry Path, together with the stream-enterer, forms the first pair. Offering to a stream-enterer also yields incalculable and immeasurable benefits, greater than the previous type.

From one who has entered upon the way to the realisation of the fruit of stream-entry onwards, all receivers are superior. All these offerings yield incalculable and immeasurable fruits, but each successive category of receiver is an even more fertile field of merit compared to the preceding one.

The commentary gives a few examples to illustrate this³¹. The incalculability of the reward for a gift given to one practising for the fruit of stream-entry is like the water in a well—it is immeasurable, but limited. The incalculability of the reward for a gift given to a stream-enterer and higher is like the water in great rivers, and progressively, up to the water in the great ocean. Although all are considered incalculable, the difference in the amount of water is obvious. Another

³¹ Ma. Tṭha. 4.224 (Commentary to MN142 Dakkhiṇāvibhaṅga Sutta):

tattha soṇḍiyaṃ udakassa viya sotāpattiphalasacchikiriyaṃ paṭipanne dinnadānassa asaṅkheyyatā veditabbā. tāsu tāsu mahānadīsu mahāsamudde ca udakassa viya sotāpannādīsu dinnadānassa uttaritaravasena asaṅkheyyatā veditabbā. pathaviyā khayamaṇḍalamatte padese paṃsum ādiṃ katvā yāva mahāpathaviyā paṃsuno appameyyatāyapi ayamatto dīpetabbo.



example is the incalculability of the dust in a small area of the earth, progressively up to the dust in the entire earth.

7.

The seventh type of offering is giving a gift to one who has entered upon the way to the realisation of the fruit of once-returner (*sakadāgāmi-phala-sacchikiriyāya paṭipanne dānaṃ deti*). When a stream-enterer continues practising *vipassanā*, and his insight matures, a higher Path knowledge arises, taking Nibbāna as its object. During that one mind moment, he is called one who has entered upon the way to once-returner fruition (*sakadāgāmi-magga-samaṅgī*). In the next moment, once-returner fruition arises and he becomes a once-returner (*sakadāgāmi*).

8.

The eighth type of offering is giving a gift to a once-returner (*sakadāgāmissa dānaṃ deti*).

9.

The ninth type of offering is giving a gift to one who has entered upon the way to the realisation of the fruit of non-returner (*anāgāmi-phala-sacchikiriyāya paṭipanne dānaṃ deti*), one endowed with the non-returner Path (*anāgāmi-magga-samaṅgī*).

10.

The tenth type of offering is giving a gift to a non-returner (*anāgāmissa dānaṃ deti*).

11.

The eleventh type of offering is giving a gift to one who has entered upon the way to the realisation of arahantship (*arahatta-phala-sacchikiriya paṭipanne dānaṃ deti*), or to one endowed with the Arahant Path (*arahatta-magga-samaṅgī*).

Offering to One Possessed of the Path

Regarding the four types of Noble Persons who are endowed with one of the four Noble Paths (*magga-samaṅgī*), this happens only within a single mind moment—much shorter than a second. A question arises: how can anyone offer to such a person when the Path lasts for such a short time?

The commentary gives a few examples of how this is possible³²:

³² Ma. Tṭha. 4.224 (Commentary to MN142 Dakkhiṇāvibhaṅga Sutta):

āraddhavipassako hi pattacīvaramādāya gāmaṃ piṇḍāya pavisati, tassa gehadvāre tṭhassa hatthato pattaṃ gahetvā khādanīyabhojanīyaṃ pakkhipanti. tasmim̐ khāṇe bhikkhuno maggavuṭṭhānaṃ hoti, idaṃ dānaṃ maggasamaṅgino dinnaṃ nāma hoti. atha vā panesa āsanāsālāya nisinno hoti, manussā gantvā patte khādanīyabhojanīyaṃ tṭhappenti, tasmim̐ khāṇe tassa maggavuṭṭhānaṃ hoti, idampi dānaṃ maggasamaṅgino dinnaṃ nāma. atha vā panassa vihāre vā āsanāsālāya



- A bhikkhu practising *vipassanā* goes on an alms-round. When he stands at the door of a house, a householder puts food into his bowl. If, at that very moment, the Noble Path arises in the bhikkhu, that offering is made to one possessed of the Path.
- Alternatively, a bhikkhu practising *vipassanā* is sitting in a hall, and donors place food in his bowl. If the Path arises in him at that moment, this is also an offering to one possessed of the Path.
- In another example, a bhikkhu is sitting in the monastery or a hall, and lay followers take his bowl, go to their house, and put food into it. If the Path arises in him at that moment, this too is an offering to one possessed of the Path.

For advanced *vipassanā* practitioners, their minds and insight knowledge can become very sharp. They may have a strong conviction that they will attain Path and Fruition that very day or the next. With this confidence, they continue to practice earnestly, even during meal times. Because their insight is sharp, they can easily discern mentality and materiality, cause and effect, and contemplate these as impermanence, suffering, and non-self.

*vā nisinnassa upāsakā pattam ādāya attano gharam gantvā
khādaniyabhojanīyam pakkhipanti, tasmim̐ khaṇe tassa maggavutṭhānaṃ
hoti, idampi dānaṃ maggasamaṅgino dinnaṃ nāma.*

Therefore, it is entirely possible for the Path consciousness—lasting only one mind moment—to arise while they are receiving food.

12.

The twelfth type of offering is giving a gift to an arahant disciple of the Tathāgata (*tathāgata-sāvake arahante dānaṃ deti*).

13.

The thirteenth type of offering is giving a gift to a *Pacceka Buddha* (*pacceka-sambuddhe dānaṃ deti*).

14.

The fourteenth and highest type of individual offering is giving a gift to the Tathāgata, accomplished and perfectly self-enlightened (*tathāgate arahante sammā-sambuddhe dānaṃ deti*).

The Supreme Offering

This offering to the perfectly self-enlightened Buddha is the most supreme and foremost. Its benefit cannot be measured. The gift to a *Pacceka Buddha* or to an arahant is also supreme because they, like the Buddha, have completely eradicated all defilements such as lust.



As stated in *Dhammapada* verse 356:

*Tiṇadosāni khattāni, rāgadosā ayaṃ pajā.
Tasmā hi vītarāgesu, dinnam hoti mahapphalaṃ.*

Fields are ruined by weeds; mankind is ruined by lust.
Therefore, what is offered to those free of lust
yields abundant fruit.

However, among all, the gift to the Tathāgata is the most supreme. There is no one equal to the perfectly self-enlightened Buddha, who has completely cut off all defilements together with their habitual tendencies, whose knowledge and conduct are unobstructed, and who possesses infinite and immeasurable qualities³³.

These are the individual receivers, from the lowest to the highest.

Offerings to the Saṅgha

Next, the Buddha explained the seven types of offerings made to the Saṅgha as a group. These are group offerings, as opposed to individual offerings discussed earlier. The seven kinds of Saṅgha offerings, listed from the highest to the lowest, are as follows:

³³ Ma.Ṭīkā.2.408 (Sub-commentary to MN142 *Dakkhiṇāvibhaṅga Sutta*):

*Yasmā pana savāsanam sabbaso samucchinna-kilesehi tato eva sabbaso
appaṭihataññācārehi anantāparimeyyaguṇagaṇādhārehi sammā-
sambuddhehi sadiso sadevake loke koci dakkhiṇeyyo natthi.*

1. One gives a gift to a Saṅgha of both *bhikkhus* and *bhikkhunīs* headed by the Buddha (*buddha-ppamukhe ubhato-saṅghe dānaṃ deti*).
2. One gives a gift to a Saṅgha of both *bhikkhus* and *bhikkhunīs* after the Tathāgata has attained final Parinibbāna (*tathāgate parinibbute ubhato-saṅghe dānaṃ deti*).
3. One gives a gift to the Saṅgha of *bhikkhus* (*bhikkhu-saṅghe dānaṃ deti*).
4. One gives a gift to the Saṅgha of *bhikkhunīs* (*bhikkhuni-saṅghe dānaṃ deti*).
5. One gives a gift, saying: “Appoint for me this number of *bhikkhus* and *bhikkhunīs* from the Saṅgha” (*‘ettakā me bhikkhū ca bhikkhuniyo ca saṅghato uddissathā’ti dānaṃ deti*).
6. One gives a gift, saying: “Appoint for me this number of *bhikkhus* from the Saṅgha” (*‘ettakā me bhikkhū saṅghato uddissathā’ti dānaṃ deti*).
7. One gives a gift, saying: “Appoint for me this number of *bhikkhunīs* from the Saṅgha” (*‘ettakā me bhikkhuniyo saṅghato uddissathā’ti dānaṃ deti*).

The Buddha further stated that in the future there would arise members of the monastic clan who are “yellow-necks”—immoral, of bad character, monks merely in name only. They would walk around with a piece of yellow cloth tied around their necks or arms, and maintain their families



by engaging in trade, agriculture, and other worldly occupations.

People may offer gifts to these immoral persons, dedicating the offering to the Saṅgha. The Buddha says that even such offerings to the Saṅgha remain *incalculable* and *immeasurable* in merit because they are intended not for these “yellow-necks” as individuals but for the Saṅgha as a collective whole.

The Saṅgha here includes all virtuous bhikkhus of the past, even those long passed into *parinibbāna*, beginning with the two chief disciples, Bhante Sāriputta and Bhante Mahāmoggallāna, and the eighty great disciples.

Reflecting on the Qualities of the Saṅgha

Thus, regardless of the recipient’s personal morality, if a donor offers with proper reflection on the noble qualities of the Saṅgha and fixes the mind on the Saṅgha, he obtains the great benefit of offering to the real, virtuous Saṅgha.

In fact, the sub-commentary states that there is *no* Saṅgha that is not virtuous³⁴. Therefore, the Buddha teaches that no individual gift can ever surpass the fruitfulness of an offering made to the Saṅgha. In addition, the commentary states that

³⁴ Ma.Ṭikā.2.411 (Sub-commentary to MN142 Dakkhiṇāvibhaṅga Sutta):

Diṭṭhisīlasāmaññiṇeṇa saṃhato samaṇagaṇo saṅgho, tasmā saṅgho dussīlo nāma natthi.

The community of recluses, united by commonality of view and virtue, is called the Saṅgha. Therefore, there is no such thing as an immoral Saṅgha.

a gift offered to an immoral bhikkhu, when he is taken as representing the entire Saṅgha, is more fruitful than a personal gift to an *Arahant*. However, for the gift to count as an offering to the Saṅgha, the donor must take no account of the recipient's personal qualities and must perceive him solely as a representative of the entire Saṅgha.

Similarly, although we cannot meet the real Buddha now, we have statues representing him. When one offers to a Buddha statue while mindfully perceiving it as the real Buddha, the offering is equivalent in merit to offering directly to the Buddha, not merely to a stone statue.

In many countries, statues and monuments are erected to honour national heroes. People pay respects before these monuments, not because they honour stone or metal, but because the statues symbolise the courage, sacrifice, and respectable qualities of these heroes—the monuments serve as reminders. In the same way, Buddha statues serve as reminders of the supreme qualities of the real Buddha.

Likewise, some future recipients may be ordinary bhikkhus who simply wear the same robes as the Noble Saṅgha. They may be imperfect in morality and lacking in many true noble qualities. Nevertheless, they represent the Noble Saṅgha and serve as living reminders of its qualities and wisdom.



Faith in the Receivers

This *sutta* focuses primarily on the qualities of the recipients. When we make an offering, we should understand which types of recipients generate greater results and the differences between them. We should donate wisely based on this understanding.

However, there are also other factors to consider.

For example, if someone asks, “To whom should I give?” a *bhikkhu* should reply, “Give to the person in whom you have faith.”

Why not encourage them to choose a ‘better’ recipient?

Because even if the recipient is excellent, if the donor feels no joy due to a lack of faith, the result of the offering will be affected by the donor’s mental state. Conversely, even if the recipient is not particularly high in virtue, a donor may gain greater merit if he gives joyfully with strong faith and repeatedly reflects upon and rejoices in his act of giving. In such cases, the efficacy of the offering is measured primarily from the standpoint of the donor’s qualities rather than the recipient’s.

What we have learned so far in the *Dakkhiṇā-vibhaṅga Sutta* focuses on the qualities of the recipients. Yet in many other *suttas*, as well as in the concluding part of this one, the Buddha explains additional factors that determine the efficacy of an offering.

Higher Receivers in the Buddha's Dispensation

In the Puppha Sutta of the Saṃyutta Nikāya³⁵, the Buddha states that he does not disagree with other religious teachers on everything. There are certain principles—both good and bad—that are commonly accepted across different religions. For example, killing is universally regarded as unwholesome conduct.

Most religions agree that generosity is good.

However, when comparing the Buddha with other teachers, even followers of other traditions acknowledge that the Buddha surpasses all others in his ability to refrain from unwholesome deeds and to perform wholesome actions. Thus, the Buddha rightly receives praise for his superior morality. The same applies when comparing the disciples of the Buddha to the disciples of other teachers: the Buddha's disciples are generally more capable of avoiding evil and performing good.

³⁵ Saṃ.2.113 (SN 22.94 Puppha Sutta):

“nāhaṃ, bhikkhave, lokaṇa vivadāmi, lokova mayā vivadati. na, bhikkhave, dhammavādī kenaci lokasmiṃ vivadati. yaṃ, bhikkhave, natthisammatam loke paṇḍitānaṃ, ahampi taṃ ‘natthī’ti vadāmi. yaṃ, bhikkhave, atthisammatam loke paṇḍitānaṃ, ahampi taṃ ‘atthī’ti vadāmi”.

“Bhikkhus, I do not dispute with the world; rather, it is the world that disputes with me. A proponent of the Dhamma does not dispute with anyone in the world. Of that which the wise in the world agree upon as not existing, I too say that it does not exist. And of that which the wise in the world agree upon as existing, I too say that it exists.”



Therefore, even in areas of shared moral understanding, the Buddha and his disciples hold a much higher moral standard—not to mention their cultivation of concentration and wisdom.

It is for this reason that higher receivers are found within the Buddha's Dispensation. They possess morality, and often concentration and wisdom that exceed those found elsewhere; thus, they are superior fields of merit.

Through such higher receivers as fertile fields, we have the opportunity to establish wholesome kamma within the Buddha's Dispensation. This accumulation of good kamma is one of the causes leading to happiness.

***Kammassakatā* Knowledge**

Everyone seeks happiness. To attain true happiness, one must understand kamma and its results—the knowledge of ownership of one's kamma (*kammassakatā-ñāṇa*)—the understanding that we are the inheritors of our actions.

In worldly education, we learn about cause and effect, but typically these concern causes and results within a single life, where the connection is direct and observable. But some causal relationships span across lives. Good deeds performed now may bear fruit only in future existences. Ordinary people cannot see such distant cause-and-effect connections. Only a fully enlightened Buddha, endowed with omniscient knowledge, can accurately trace these remote cause-and-effect relationships and teach them to his disciples.

Thus, in the Jātaka stories we see that when the Bodhisatta served as a teacher in past lives, he taught not only arts and skills but also the correct understanding of kamma and its results, morality, and mental cultivation. He taught what should be done and what should not be done.

In today’s talk, we too are learning from this *sutta* about the different types of recipients and how offerings to them differ in fruitfulness. This is a form of knowledge regarding kamma and its results—an aspect of *kammassakatā* knowledge. Having gained such important understanding, we are able to plant the right causes that lead to happiness.

Up to this point, the Dakkhiṇā-vibhaṅga Sutta has been focusing on the qualities of the receivers. Towards the end of the sutta, the Buddha introduces other important factors, in addition to the receivers, that can purify an offering. Here, “purification of offering” means making the offering greatly fruitful. The Buddha summarises the different kinds of purification of offerings in five verses at the end of the sutta.



**Offering that is Purified by the Giver, not by the Receiver
(*dakkhiṇā dāyakato visujjhati no paṭiggāhakato*)**

*yo sīlavā dussīlesu dadāti dānaṃ,
dhammena laddhaṃ supasannacitto.
abhisaddahaṃ kammaphalaṃ uḷāraṃ,
sā dakkhiṇā dāyakato visujjhati³⁶.*

When a virtuous person to an immoral person gives
With trusting heart a gift righteously obtained,
Placing faith that the fruit of action is great,
The giver's virtue purifies the offering.

The first type of purification is by the giver. This happens when the donor is a person of high qualities. He has pure morality, a clear mind, and faith in the fruitfulness of kamma.

If someone has faith in the results of giving, he will usually have a clear and joyful mind when giving because he understands that such giving is beneficial both to the receiver and to himself. Because of this understanding, those who have faith in kamma and its results, and who believe in giving, are able to give repeatedly, again and again, happily and with a clear mind.

On the other hand, some people give not out of faith, but out of a sense of responsibility. Such giving is usually limited. They may not wish to give again and again. And if they are forced to give repeatedly, they may not be able to maintain a clear mind.

³⁶ Ma.3.300 (MN142 Dakkhiṇāvibhaṅga Sutta)

However, for those who have faith in giving and in the results of giving, they will happily give again and again. They can also give courageously, just like the Bodhisattas who could offer even their own lives. They have clear minds and strong confidence that giving is beneficial.

In his last human birth among his past lives, when the Bodhisatta was King Vessantara³⁷, he announced to the world that he would give away anything that anyone asked of him. He would even give away his heart and his life. Because he had a deep understanding of giving, he dared to make such a bold statement, and he was courageous enough to give whatever was asked of him.

Once, a brahmin went to King Vessantara and asked for the royal elephant, which was extremely important and beneficial for the country. When the Bodhisatta heard this, he thought, “You are only asking for external things. I was hoping that you would ask for my life.” How brave he was!

The Bodhisatta had profound *pāramī*. He dared to give and was very brave in doing so.

When we read such inspiring stories and develop faith in them, we too can become brave.

Some Buddhists are very courageous; they are willing to donate everything they own because of their understanding and faith in kamma and its results. Because of such understanding, they have faith in the act of giving, and their

³⁷ Khu.Ṭṭha.23.241 (Commentary to Jātaka no. 547: Vessantara Jātaka).



minds are very clear that their offering, besides benefiting others, also brings great benefit to themselves. Their knowledge of kamma and its results supports them to give with a clear and happy mind.

Some may still be attached to the results of giving; their giving may be motivated by some level of desire for good results. Nevertheless, their understanding will support them to continue giving and giving bravely.

This concerns the quality of the donor—having morality, a clear and trusting mind when giving, and faith in the fruitfulness of giving.

Another factor to consider is the quality of the gift; the gift should be obtained righteously, without harming others.

In this first scenario, the donor is virtuous, with a clear mind and faith in the fruit of giving, and the property given is righteously obtained. But the recipient is immoral. This is like the case when King Vessantara gave the royal elephant to the bad brahmin, and later offered his children to another bad brahmin, Jūjaka.

In such cases, the receiver is not of good quality, but the donor has very high qualities—morality, understanding, and faith. Such offerings can be pure because of the donor's qualities, not because of the receiver's. This giving is purified by the donor.

When King Vessantara gave away his children, the great earth shook, as if rejoicing and crying out loudly, "*Sādhū! Sādhū! Sādhū!*" Even lifeless nature—the great earth itself—seemed

to rejoice in the Bodhisatta's merits. This shows how great and powerful the merits of his giving were.

Here, the purification of the offering is due to the donor's qualities, not the receiver's.

The commentary gives a simile³⁸. For a skilful farmer, even if the field is poor and infertile, if he ploughs the field at the right season, removes weeds, plants good seeds, and guards it diligently, he may still reap more grains than someone with a fertile field.

In the same way, a virtuous donor, even when giving to an immoral receiver, can obtain great results. We can understand the other forms of purification in a similar way.

Offering that is Purified by the Receiver, not by the Giver (*dakkhiṇā paṭiggāhakato visujjhati no dāyakato*)

*yo dussīlo sīlavantesu dadāti dānaṃ,
adhammena laddhaṃ appasannacitto.
anabhisaddahaṃ kammaphalaṃ uḷāraṃ,
sā dakkhiṇā paṭiggāhakato visujjhati.*

When an immoral person to a virtuous person gives
With untrusting heart a gift unrighteously obtained,
Nor places faith that the fruit of action is great,
The receiver's virtue purifies the offering.

³⁸ Ma.Ṭṭha.4.227 (Commentary to MN 142 Dakkhiṇāvibhaṅga Sutta)



The second type of purification of offering is by the receiver, not by the giver.

In this case, the giver has no morality, no clear mind, and no faith in the fruitfulness of kamma. The gift is also unrighteously obtained.

Those who are not virtuous are usually also without faith. It is precisely because they lack faith in kamma and its results that they break morality. If someone strongly believes in kamma and its results, he will not want to break his morality.

So here, the giver is immoral, but he gives to a virtuous receiver. In this case, the offering is purified by the receiver. It can be beneficial and bring good results because of the qualities of the receiver.

The commentary gives the example of a fisherman who lived at the mouth of the Kalyāṇī River. He had spent his whole life catching and killing many fish.

Near the end of his life, he offered alms-food three times to the Elder Dīghasoma, who was an *Arahant*. While lying on his deathbed, he hoped that his offering to the Elder Dīghasoma would save him from falling into the woeful realms.

When the destination sign of deva realm appeared to him, he told the people nearby that the Arahant Dīghasoma had saved him. This is an offering purified by the receiver.

Offering that is Purified Neither by the Giver nor the Receiver (*dakkhiṇā neva dāyakato visujjhati no paṭiggāhakato*)

*yo dussīlo dussīlesu dadāti dānaṃ,
adhammena laddhaṃ appasannacitto.
anabhisaddahaṃ kammaphalaṃ ulāraṃ,
na taṃ dānaṃ vipulapphalanti brūmi.*

When an immoral person to an immoral person gives
With untrusting heart a gift unrighteously obtained,
Nor places faith that the fruit of action is great,
That gift, I say, will not come to abundant fruition.

In this third type of offering, neither the giver nor the receiver has the qualities to purify the offering. Both are immoral; they have no faith, and the gift is not righteously obtained. Such giving is not beneficial and brings little or no result.

There is a story of a hunter who lived in Vaḍḍhamāna city. Wanting to make an offering and dedicate the merits to his departed relative who had become a hungry ghost (*peta*), he offered alms three times to an immoral monk. Because both the giver and receiver—the hunter and the immoral monk—were not virtuous, the *peta* could not receive any benefit from those offerings. This is a case where the offering is purified neither by the giver nor by the receiver, and therefore brings no result.

Eventually, after the third attempt, the *peta* exclaimed: “An immoral non-human, who is neither layperson nor monk, is robbing me of the opportunity to gain merit!”



Knowing this, the hunter then offered to a virtuous monk instead, and at the very moment he dedicated the merit, desirable results reached the *peta*.

**Offering that is Purified Both by the Giver and the Receiver
(*dakkhiṇā dāyakato ceva visujjhati paṭiggāhakato ca*)**

*yo sīlavā sīlavantesu dadāti dānaṃ,
dhammena laddhaṃ supasannacitto.
abhisaddahaṃ kammaphalaṃ uḷāraṃ,
taṃ ve dānaṃ vipulapphalanti brūmi.*

When a virtuous person to a virtuous person gives
With trusting heart a gift righteously obtained,
Placing faith that the fruit of action is great,
That gift, I say, will come to abundant fruition.

The fourth type of giving is where the offering is purified by both the giver and the receiver. The donor has morality, a clear mind, and faith in the result of kamma; the gift is righteously obtained; and the receiver is also virtuous. Among the four types, this is the best. Being purified by both giver and receiver, it will bring abundant results.

The commentary gives the example of the incomparable offering (*asadisadāna*) given by King Kosala to the Saṅgha, with the Buddha at its head. The giver had extremely noble intentions, and the receivers were exceedingly superior. This kind of offering brings very great results.

**Offering by One Free from Lust to Another Free from Lust
(vītarāgo vītarāgesu dadāti dānaṃ)**

*yo vītarāgo vītarāgesu dadāti dānaṃ,
dhammena laddhaṃ supasannacitto.
abhisaddahaṃ kammaphalaṃ uḷāraṃ,
taṃ ve dānaṃ āmisadānānamaggaṃ.*

When a passionless person to a passionless person gives
With trusting heart a gift righteously obtained,
Placing faith that the fruit of action is great,
That gift, I say, is the best of worldly gifts.

This fifth stanza is a special case within the fourth type. Not only are both giver and receiver virtuous, but they are also free from lust.

The commentary explains that while an *Anāgāmi* is free from lust, it is an *Arahant* who is completely free from it. So here, both the giver and receiver are *Arahants* who have destroyed all defilements.

A gift given by an *Arahant* to another *Arahant* is the highest because they have no attachment to this existence, and no desire for future existence. Their act of giving is free from desire and attachment, and thus is neither wholesome nor unwholesome; it is merely functional.

Action by itself cannot generate kamma. Only actions accompanied by ignorance and attachment can produce good or bad kamma.



Arahants have perfected their *vipassanā* practice, fully penetrated the suffering nature of existence, and completely eradicated ignorance. Without ignorance, there is no attachment. Even though they perform good deeds, these deeds do not function as kamma and, therefore, will not produce future results. There will be no future births and no further suffering.

Therefore, this kind of giving—without any attachment to present or future existence—is the most supreme; it is the highest among all material gifts.

Conclusion

Today, all of us here are practising morality; we are practising the Dhamma. Some of us may be receivers, and some may be donors. When we practise morality, it is not only for our own benefit; it also brings benefits to the donors who support our practice.

So if you come here to offer to the participants of the retreat, you are offering to those who are observing morality. You yourself are also practising morality. As a result, your act of giving can bring very great results and many benefits.

Through performing such beneficial offerings, may you reap great benefits and eventually attain the highest fruit in the Buddha's Dispensation.

Sādhū! Sādhū! Sādhū!

4. Sappurisdāna: The Offerings of a Good Person

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Today, I would like to share some teachings as an *anumodāna* talk to rejoice in your offering. The suttas we will look into revolve around the theme of **Sappurisdāna** - the offerings of a good and noble person.

We can find two *suttas* titled Sappurisdāna Sutta in the Aṅguttara Nikāya—one in the Chapter of Fives (Pañcakanipāta)³⁹ and one in the Chapter of Eights (Aṭṭhakanipāta)⁴⁰. There is also a related *sutta* called the Asappurisdāna Sutta⁴¹. This last one describes the wrong offerings of an unworthy person, and also highlights the proper offerings of a good person.

Drawing from all three *suttas*, we will learn the correct way to make offerings.

We've previously discussed⁴² how the results of giving vary based on the **qualities of the receiver** and the **qualities of the donor**. Even if two gifts are similar, their results can be vastly different depending on who receives the gift and with what

³⁹ Añ.2.152 (AN 5.148 Sappurisdāna Sutta)

⁴⁰ Añ.3.74 (AN 8.37 Sappurisdāna Sutta)

⁴¹ Añ.2.151-152 (AN 5.147 Asappurisdāna Sutta)

⁴² Talk no. 2: Qualities of Dāna.



mind the donor gives. Today, we shift our focus to **how one should give**.

The term *sappurisa* refers to a good and noble person, and *sappurisdāna* means the offering made by such a person. If we wish to give in a way that is noble, powerful, and fruitful, we must understand **how a good person gives**.

The Five Proper Ways of Giving

In the first Sappurisdāna Sutta in the Pañcaka-nipāta,⁴³ the Buddha explains **five proper ways of making offerings**.

1. *Saddhāya dānaṃ deti* (Giving with Faith)

The first quality is *saddhāya dānaṃ deti* - to give with faith. But faith in what? It is faith in *kamma* and the results of *kamma* - faith in the act of giving and the fruit it will bring.

When someone donates without this faith, they still perform an act of generosity, but their mind is not clear and happy. By contrast, the *sappurisa*, the good person, gives with faith in *kamma* and its results, believing firmly in the law of cause and effect.

So what is the difference in results between giving with faith and giving without faith?

⁴³ Añ.2.152 (AN 5.148 Sappurisdāna Sutta)

Every act of generosity produces the result of wealth: becoming rich and having many properties and resources. But when one donates with faith, an additional result ripens: beauty. Such a donor becomes attractive, graceful, pleasing to look at, and is endowed with the supreme beauty of complexion (*abhirūpo ca hoti dassanīyo pāsādiko paramāya vaṇṇa-pokkharatāya samannāgato*).

Many in this world are wealthy but not pleasing in appearance. Thus, if one wants to be not only rich but also beautiful or handsome, one should give with faith. Why? Because faith purifies and brightens the mind.

In the Abhidhamma, faith is likened to a special ruby⁴⁴ held by a universal monarch (*cakkavatti-rāja*). When this jewel is dropped into muddy water, the water instantly becomes clear and clean. Likewise, when faith is present, the mind becomes clear, pure, and peaceful.

Even though it seems like we are “losing money” when making an offering, our mind remains joyful. Why? Because we believe this act is beneficial and is accumulating wholesome kamma for our future welfare and happiness.

Therefore, the one who gives with faith not only gains wealth but also becomes beautiful and pleasing to look at as a future result.

⁴⁴ Abhi.Ṭṭha.1.163 (Dhammasaṅgaṇī-aṭṭhakathā, Cittuppadakaṇḍo, Kāmāvacarakusalapadabhājanīyaṃ, Dhammuddesavāro, Indriyārāsivaṇṇanā) - *rañño cakkavattissa udakappasādako maṇi*



2. *Sakkaccaṃ dānaṃ deti* (Giving Respectfully)

The second quality is *sakkaccaṃ dānaṃ deti* - to give respectfully.

This means offering a gift with care, mindfulness, and reverence. Some people donate casually or even reluctantly. Maybe they feel forced or do not want to give to the person they meet. In such cases, the giving lacks respect.

But the *sappurisa*, the good person, gives only after carefully making sure that the gift is well-prepared: clean, wholesome, fresh, and suitable. This is a giving with respect.

All giving brings wealth. The extra benefit of giving with respect is that in the future, your spouse, children, servants, and workers will be obedient and attentive. They will listen to your words. They will pay attention and apply their minds to understand what you say.

We may have seen households where children respect one parent but not the other. Though they share the same home and family, the degree of respect is different. One reason for this may lie in past habits of giving. When we give respectfully, the karmic result is that others treat us with respect.

Consider the renowned lay devotee Visākhā, who offered the Pubbārāma Monastery in Sāvatthī to the Buddha. Her fame lasts through the ages. But how many remember her husband's name? Though they belonged to the same

household, the degree of respect and honour given to each is not the same.

Likewise, everyone knows Anāthapiṇḍika, the great donor of Jetavana Monastery. But few recall the name of his wife.

Even within the same family, the difference in reputation is vast. Understanding that the manner of giving shapes future results, the good person gives with respect.

3. *Kālena dānaṃ deti* (Giving Timely Gifts)

The third quality is *kālena dānaṃ deti* - to give at the right time.

This means offering a gift when the person truly needs it, not just when we feel like being generous. It's easy to give when we feel inspired, but harder to give exactly when someone requires support. Sometimes another person is in great need, but at that moment, faith does not arise in us. Timely giving is the practice of giving when the person is truly in need.

In the Kāladāna Sutta⁴⁵, the Buddha describes five kinds of timely offering.

⁴⁵ Añ.2.35 (AN 5.36 Kāladāna Sutta):

āgantukassa dānaṃ deti; gamikassa dānaṃ deti; gilānassa dānaṃ deti; dubbhikkhe dānaṃ deti; yāni tāni navasassāni navaphalāni tāni paṭhamam sīlavantesu paṭiṭṭhāpeti. imāni kho, bhikkhave, pañca kāladānāni”ti

(1) One gives a gift to a visitor. (2) One gives a gift to one setting out on a journey. (3) One gives a gift to a patient. (4) One gives a gift during a famine. (5) One first presents the newly harvested crops and fruits to the virtuous ones. These are the five timely gifts.”



1. **To a visitor (*āgantuka*).** Visitors often arrive tired and needing things.
2. **To a traveller who is going on a journey (*gamika*).** Those preparing to travel may need supplies or support.
3. **To the sick (*gilāna*).** Someone who is sick can be quite helpless. Assistance at such times provides immediate relief.
4. **During famine (*dubbhikkhe*).** When food is scarce and suffering is widespread, offering nourishment and other needed items becomes very important.
5. **Offering the first harvest of seasonal crops and fruits to the virtuous.** Whenever crops or fruits ripen, the very first portion of the harvest is offered to virtuous individuals before taking any for oneself.

These five are timely gifts according to the sutta. Some Sayadaws further explain that timely giving also means offering according to the occasion, such as food at mealtime or robes during the Kaṭhina season.

I would like to share the verses at the end of the Kāladāna Sutta:

*kāle dadanti sappaññā, vadaññū vītamaccharā;
kālena dinnam ariyesu, ujubhūtesu tādisu.*

Those who are wise, knower-of-speech (*vadaññū*)⁴⁶, and free from stinginess give at the proper time, offering timely gifts⁴⁷ to the Noble Ones who are upright, unwavering, and ever-such (*tādi*)⁴⁸.

*vippasannamanā tassa, vipulā hoti dakkhiṇā;
ye tattha anumodanti, veyyāvaccam karonti vā;
na tena dakkhiṇā ūnā, tepi puññassa bhāgino.*

Serene and joyful is the giver's mind; his offering yields abundant fruit. Those who rejoice in that gift from afar⁴⁹,

⁴⁶ In the Kāladāna Sutta commentary (Añ.Ṭṭha.3.21), *vadaññū* is defined as one who understands what is said (*bhāsitaññū*). The sub-commentary (Añ.Ṭīkā.3.17) further explains that *bhāsitaññū* includes one who understands what is implied even when nothing is spoken. This is illustrated through an example: when bhikkhus stand at the door of a householder, even though they remain silent, in essence they are saying, "Please give almsfood." For standing silently is the noble and proper way for bhikkhus to request for almsfood.

⁴⁷ Commentary (Añ.Ṭṭha.3.21): *kālena dinnanti yuttappattakālena dinnam* - a gift given at the right and fitting moment.

Sub-commentary (Añ.Ṭīkā.3.17): *Yuttappattakāleti dātum yuttappattakāle* - at the suitable and fitting time to give.

⁴⁸ *Tādī* (lit. "such-like," "thus," "even-such"): one whose mind remains perfectly steady and unaltered by any circumstance. Such mind is very stable; it is not shaken by the nature of the object. It can take disagreeable objects in the same way as it takes agreeable objects.

As the sub-commentary to MN 86 Aṅgulimāla Sutta (Ma.Ṭīkā.2.158) states:

yādisova aniṭṭhe, tādisova iṭṭheti iṭṭhāniṭṭhe nibbikārena tādi.

Just as toward the disagreeable, so too toward the agreeable — unchanged in both.

⁴⁹ Commentary (Añ.Ṭṭha.3.21): *anumodantīti ekamante ṭhitā anumodanti* - they stand to one side and rejoice.



or who render voluntary service⁵⁰, are not deprived of its merit — they too share in the wholesome fruit.

*tasmā dade appaṭivānacitto,
yattha dinnaṃ mahapphalaṃ;
puññāni paralokasmiṃ, paṭiṭṭhā honti pāṇinaṃ.*

Therefore, give with a heart that never wavers or turns back⁵¹, to fields where a gift bears great reward. For meritorious deeds become, in the next world, the firm support of every living being.

What additional benefit arises from timely giving? All acts of generosity produce wealth. Timely giving yields wealth *right when it is needed*.

Some people get rich only in old age, when their bodies can no longer enjoy food, clothing, or worldly comfort. They have a lot but cannot use it. Others are born into wealth and can enjoy prosperity from the start of their lives.

This difference comes partly from whether one's past generosity was timely. If you want to enjoy wealth when you are young and at the prime of life, you must learn to give timely and at the right moment.

⁵⁰ Commentary (Añ.Ṭṭha.3.21): **veyyāvaccanti** kāyena veyyāvaṭṭikakammaṃ karonti – performing helpful actions through the body (to assist the act of giving).

⁵¹ A mind that does not retreat, waver, or turn back; a strong and unwavering resolve in giving.

Sub-commentary (Añ.Ṭikā.3.17): **appaṭivānacittoti** anivattanacitto – with a mind that does not reverse.

4. *Attānañca parañca anupahacca dānaṃ deti* (Giving without harming oneself or others)

The fourth quality is *attānañca parañca anupahacca dānaṃ deti* - to give in a way that harms neither oneself nor others.

The commentary explains this as *gune amakkhetvā* - not undermining or destroying the wholesome qualities of oneself or others through the act of donation.

Some people donate in ways that harm themselves. They think, “Only I can give; only I am capable of such generosity.” This feeds pride and conceit, which erode one’s wholesome qualities even while giving.

Others donate in ways that harm others. They belittle those who cannot give as much, or they praise their own generosity while putting down others.

A *sappurisa* gives without harming either side. The gift uplifts, purifies, and inspires rather than causes harm.

What special benefit arises from such giving? All forms of generosity produce wealth. But when you give without harming yourself or others, your future wealth will be secure. Your property will not be destroyed by the five enemies: fire, flood, rulers (taxation or seizure), thieves, or ungrateful heirs. You gain wealth that is both abundant and safe, without trouble or hostility chasing after it.

Some wealthy people live in constant fear of loss. Others are rich but have no enemies, no anxiety, and no threats to their



property. This safety is the result of giving that harms neither oneself nor others.

5. *Anaggahita-citto dānaṃ deti* (Giving without attachment)

The fifth quality is *anaggahita-citto dānaṃ deti* - to give freely and unreservedly, without stinginess or clinging to the gift.

You should offer with the intention of supporting the recipient and extending kindness. Your mind remains open-handed, not tightly clenched around the object like a fist that does not want to let go.

Some people give, but their generosity is gripped by attachment. They do not truly wish to part with the gift, but because they understand the benefits of giving, they force themselves to donate while their minds remain tight and stingy.

Others give not to help the recipient, but to impress them or to establish influence or control. The offering becomes a way to display superiority.

Such motives do not align with the giving of a *sappurisa*. A good person gives to uplift, support, and assist, and does so without clinging to the gift or to the identity of “the giver.”

What are the special benefits of such giving, beyond material wealth?

Some people are rich, but they cannot enjoy their wealth. They have plenty of property but choose poor food, inferior homes or refuse to use what they own. Their minds are still bound by stinginess. Their attachment persists even in enjoyment. The mind that was tight during giving becomes tight when enjoying.

By contrast, the one who gives freely without stinginess or attachment will later enjoy wealth freely. When prosperity ripens, his mind naturally inclines to the enjoyment of refined sensual pleasures, just as he once inclined to open-handed generosity.

Asappurisdāna Sutta

There is another sutta called the Asappurisdāna Sutta⁵², which explains *the donation of a bad person*.

⁵² Añ.2.151-152 (AN 5.147 Asappurisdāna Sutta):

“pañcimāni, bhikkhave, asappurisdānāni. katamāni pañca? asakkaccaṃ deti, acittikatvā deti, asahatthā deti, apaviddhaṃ deti, anāgamanadiṭṭhiko deti. imāni kho, bhikkhave, pañca asappurisdānāni.

“pañcimāni, bhikkhave, sappurisdānāni. katamāni pañca? sakkaccaṃ deti, cittikatvā deti, sahatthā deti, anapaviddhaṃ deti, āgamanadiṭṭhiko deti. imāni kho, bhikkhave, pañca sappurisdānāni”ti.

“Bhikkhus, there are these five gifts of a bad person. What five? He gives casually; he gives without reverence; he does not give with his own hand; he gives what would be discarded; he gives without a view about the returns of giving. These are the five gifts of a bad person.

“Bhikkhus, there are these five gifts of a good person. What five? He gives respectfully; he gives with reverence; he gives with his own hand; he gives what would not be discarded; he gives with a view about the returns of giving. [commentary: he gives with faith in kamma and its result.] These are the five gifts of a good person.”



It lists the five wrong ways of giving (*asappurisdāna*) and their exact opposites, the five correct ways of giving (*sappurisdāna*).

Here are the five pairs, side-by-side:

1. *Asakkaccaṃ deti* vs. *Sakkaccaṃ deti* (Giving without respect vs. giving respectfully)

- **Wrong way: *Asakkaccaṃ deti***—giving **without respect**. This means giving casually, carelessly, or without respect. When one gives with a negligent mind, the offering will show this lack of respect. The sub-commentary explains that this results in deficient or inferior offerings: items that are incomplete, impure, or still have defects⁵³. For example, rice that still has husks, broken grains, or uncooked portions.
- **Right Way: *Sakkaccaṃ deti***—giving **respectfully**. This is the opposite: to prepare the offering attentively, ensuring it is wholesome, pure, clean, and suitable. One removes impurities such as broken rice grains before giving. This is offering respectfully.

⁵³ Añ.Ṭīkā.3.50 (sub-commentary to AN 5.147 Asappurisdāna Sutta):

Deyyadhammassa asakkaccakaraṇaṃ nāma asampannaṃ karotīti āha “na sakkaritvā suciṃ katvā detī” ’ti, uttaṇḍulādidosavirahitaṃ suci-sampannaṃ katvā na detīti attho.

2. *Acittikatvā deti* vs. *Cittikatvā deti* (Giving without reverence vs. giving with reverence)

- **Wrong Way: *Acittikatvā deti***—giving **without reverence**. One offers with a disrespectful attitude. The mind doesn't value the gift nor the recipient. The sub-commentary ⁵⁴ explains *acittikatvā* as not wholeheartedly, not giving full attention, or not honouring the offering. Examples include making the recipient sit in an unclean place or offering food in improper containers.
- **Right Way: *Cittikatvā deti***—giving **with reverence**. This means showing respect in two ways⁵⁵:
 - **Respect for the gift:** Preparing offerings that are excellent, wholesome, nutritious, and suitable, rather than giving low-quality items.
 - **Respect for the recipient:** Choosing a worthy person and treating them honourably. The

⁵⁴ Añ.Ṭṭha.3.53 (commentary to AN 5.147 Asappurisdāna Sutta):

acittikatvā detīti acittikārena agāravavasena deti.

Añ.Ṭikā.3.50 (sub-commentary to AN 5.147 Asappurisdāna Sutta):

Acittikatvāti na citte katvā, na pūjetvāti attho. Pūjento hi pūjetabbavatthum citte ṭhapeti, na tato bahi karoti. Cittaṃ vā acchariyaṃ katvā paṭipattivikaraṇaṃ sambhāvanakiriyā, tappaṭikkhepato acittikaraṇaṃ asambhāvanakiriyā. Agāravana detīti puggale agaruṃ karonto nisidanaṭṭhāne asammajjitvā yattha vā tattha vā nisidāpetvā yaṃ vā taṃ vā ādhāraṃ ṭhapetvā dānaṃ deti.

⁵⁵ Añ.Ṭṭha.3.53 (commentary to AN 5.147 Asappurisdāna Sutta):

cittikatvā detīti deyyadhamme ca dakkhiṇeyyesu ca cittikāraṃ upaṭṭhapetvā deti. tattha deyyadhammaṃ paṇitaṃ ojavantaṃ katvā dento deyyadhamme cittikāraṃ upaṭṭhapeti nāma. puggalaṃ vicinitvā dento dakkhiṇeyyesu cittikāraṃ upaṭṭhapeti nāma.



commentary explains that giving with reverence means holding the act of giving in regard as “wonderful and excellent.” Such offering uplifts the mind and supports wholesome practices.

- Examples of giving **with reverence** include: cleaning the place, providing proper seats, arranging dignified vessels and cutlery, and offering with sincerity and attentiveness.

3. *Asahatthā deti* vs. *Sahatthā deti* (Not giving with one’s own hand vs. giving with one’s own hand)

- **Wrong Way: *Asahatthā deti*—not giving with one’s own hand.** This refers to giving through intermediaries, such as servants or workers, instead of offering directly⁵⁶.
- **Right Way: *Sahatthā deti*—giving personally, with one’s own hands.** One doesn’t just instruct others to donate, but personally performs the act of giving.
 - The sub-commentary encourages us to reflect before giving: “Throughout the beginningless cycle of *Samsāra*, I have been reborn countless times in [woeful] states without gaining the use of hands and feet. Now that I am fortunate to

⁵⁶ Añ.Ṭīkā.3.50 (sub-commentary to AN 5.147 Asappurisadāna Sutta):
Asahatthāti na attano hatthena deti, dāsakammakarodīhi dāpeti.

possess functioning limbs, I should not waste this opportunity. I will offer with my own hands to attain liberation from the cycle of rebirths and escape from the state of repeated becoming/existence.”⁵⁷

The Story of Pāyāsi

The story of the chieftain Pāyāsi shows the importance of giving personally.⁵⁸

During the Buddha’s time, there lived a chieftain named Pāyāsi in the city of Setabyā. Initially, he held the nihilistic doctrine of non-existence (*natthika-vāda*):

“There is no next world, no spontaneously arisen beings, and no fruits or results of good and bad actions.”⁵⁹

Once, in the presence of Venerable Kumārakassapa, Pāyāsi attempted to defend this view. He argued that he had many unvirtuous friends and relatives who committed the ten kinds of unwholesome actions (killing, stealing, sexual misconduct, lying, etc. and holding wrong views). When they lay on their

⁵⁷ Añ.Ṭṭha.3.53 (commentary to AN 5.147 Asappurisaḍāṇa Sutta):

sahatthā detīti āṇattiyā parahatthena adatvā “anamatagge saṃsāre vicarantena me hatthapāḍāṇaṃ aladdhakālassa pamāṇaṃ nāma natthi, vaṭṭamokkhaṃ bhavanissaraṇaṃ karissāmī”ti sahattheneva deti.

⁵⁸ Dī.2.253 (DN 23 Pāyāsi Sutta)

⁵⁹ Dī.2.253 (DN 23 Pāyāsi Sutta):

“itipi natthi paro loko, natthi sattā opapātikā, natthi sukatadukkaṭāṇaṃ kammānaṃ phalaṃ vipāko”ti.



deathbeds, and he was certain they would not recover, he instructed them:

“If the teachings of ascetics and brahmins are true, and people like you are reborn in hell after death, then come back (or send a messenger) and tell me that the next world, spontaneous rebirth, and the results of kamma really exist.”

They agreed, but after their deaths none ever returned or sent word. From this, Pāyāsi concluded: “There is no afterlife, no spontaneous rebirth, and no moral consequences of good or bad deeds.”

Venerable Kumārakassapa refuted him with a sharp analogy: Suppose a thief captured for execution pleaded with the executioners, “Let me go just long enough to inform my friends and relatives in the next town, and I will return to be beheaded.” Would they permit it? Certainly not. They would execute him immediately, even as he pleaded.

He then applied the analogy:

Just as a human criminal cannot persuade human guards to release him, how could Pāyāsi’s unwholesome friends, destined for hell due to their conduct, persuade the fierce guardians of hell to let them return to the human world merely to satisfy Pāyāsi’s curiosity? Their failure to return is not evidence that hell does not exist. Rather, it is exactly what would be expected if the realms of rebirth and karmic results are real.

Pāyāsi then reversed the test:

He also had virtuous friends and relatives who observed the ten wholesome actions and held right views. When they were dying, he told them:

“If ascetics and brahmins speak truthfully, and virtuous people like you are reborn in heaven, then after your death please return (or send a messenger) to confirm that the next world, spontaneous rebirth, and kamma really exist.”

They agreed to do so, but likewise none returned.

Thus, Pāyāsi again concluded that there is no afterlife, no spontaneous rebirth, and no moral consequence of action.

Venerable Kumārakassapa replied with the famous man-in-the-cesspool simile:

Imagine a man fully submerged head-first in a filthy cesspool. You have him pulled out, scraped clean with bamboo scrapers, washed repeatedly with yellow clay, anointed with oil, powdered, groomed, clothed in fine garments, adorned with garlands, and finally installed in the upper chamber of a luxurious palace surrounded by sensual pleasures.

After being cleansed, perfumed, and enjoying comfort, would that man ever willingly dive back into the cesspool? Of course not. The filth would now be utterly repulsive.

He then drew the parallel:

Human bodies, being coarse, impure, and foul-smelling, are repulsive to the devas. The stench of a human can disgust a deva even from a long distance away. A virtuous person reborn in a blissful deva realm, radiant and refined, would not



even think of returning to the human world, just as the cleansed man would not return to the cesspool.

So the absence of their return is not evidence against rebirth in heaven. On the contrary, it is exactly what would be expected if rebirth in heavenly realms truly occurs.

Although Pāyāsi continued to present many arguments supporting his wrong views, Venerable Kumarakassapa refuted each of them with compelling reasoning, supported by clear similes.

Eventually, Pāyāsi abandoned his wrong view and took refuge in the Triple Gem.

Pāyāsi's Mistaken Offering

After his conversion, Pāyāsi established charitable distributions for ascetics, brahmins, travellers, beggars, and the destitute. However, he donated carelessly. He delegated the giving to servants and offered inferior items: broken rice with sour gruel, coarse cloth with tangled fringes, and goods he himself would not use. This corresponds to *apaviddham deti*, giving discarded or low-quality items, which is a wrong way of giving that we will be discussing next.

His steward, a young man named Uttara, however, offered the items **with his own hands**, respectfully, and with a wholesome aspiration:

“Through this offering, may I be associated with Pāyāsi only in this life. May there be no association with him in the next life.”⁶⁰

When questioned, Uttara explained that Pāyāsi’s offerings were so inferior that even Pāyāsi himself would not touch them with his feet.

Only then did Pāyāsi begin offering the same food and clothing that he would personally use.

Still, because Pāyāsi set up the donations carelessly—*asakkaccaṃ* (without respect), *asahatthā* (not with his own hands), *acittikataṃ* (without reverence), and *apaviddhaṃ* (as though discarded)—he was reborn as Pāyāsi *devaputta* in the lower Cātumahārājika deva realm in an empty, secluded mansion.

Uttara, by contrast, having offered properly—*sakkaccaṃ* (respectfully), *sahatthā* (with his own hands), *cittikataṃ* (with reverence), and *anapaviddhaṃ* (without discarding)—was reborn in the higher Tāvātimsa deva realm.

As Pāyāsi *devaputta*’s celestial mansion was empty and secluded, it provided ideal conditions for meditation. Venerable Gavampati frequently went up to that mansion for his daytime abiding.

When Pāyāsi *devaputta* saw him, he explained how he had been reborn in a lower deva realm than the servant who had

⁶⁰ Dī.2.280 (DN 23 Pāyāsi Sutta):

imināhaṃ dānena pāyāsiṃ rājaññameva imasmiṃ loke samāgacchīm, mā parasmin.



distributed his gifts on his behalf. He requested Venerable Gavampati to return to the human world and encourage people to give respectfully, with their own hands, with reverence, and without discarding the offering carelessly, using his own rebirth as a lesson.

4. *Apaviddhaṃ deti* vs. *anapaviddhaṃ deti* (Giving as if discarding vs. giving without discarding)

- **Wrong Way: *Apaviddhaṃ deti***—giving as if discarding. This has two meanings⁶¹:
 - He gives intermittently or irregularly. He does not give continuously.
 - He gives as if discarding leftovers, intending to throw away unwanted things.
- **Right Way: *Anapaviddhaṃ deti***—giving without discarding. One should give regularly without interruption; he should offer superior items with a respectful mind.

⁶¹ Añ.Ṭṭha.3.53 (commentary to AN 5.147 Asappurisaḍāna Sutta):

apaviddhaṃ detīti na nirantaraṃ deti, atha vā chaḍḍetukāmo viya deti.

Añ.Ṭṭkā.3.50 (sub-commentary to AN 5.147 Asappurisaḍāna Sutta):

Apaviddhaṃ detīti antarā apaviddhaṃ vicchedaṃ katvā deti. Tenāha “na nirantaraṃ detī” ’ti. Atha vā apaviddhaṃ detīti ucchiṭṭhādi-chaḍḍanīyadhammaṃ viya avakkhittakaṃ katvā deti. Tenāha “chaḍḍetukāmo viya detī” ’ti.

**5. *Anāgamana-diṭṭhiko deti* vs. *āgamana-diṭṭhiko deti*
(Giving without belief in its result vs. giving with belief in its result)**

- **Wrong Way: *Anāgamana-diṭṭhiko deti***—giving without believing in its result. The giver doubts whether results will come from giving. He does not have the view that beings are owners of their deeds (*kammassakatā-diṭṭhi*). He is suspicious of the result of giving: "Will anything really come from this offering?"⁶²
- **Right Way: *Āgamana-diṭṭhiko deti***—giving believing in its results. He gives believing, "This will be a condition for future existences." He has faith in kamma and kamma's result. He reflects with confidence: "Surely, the result of this gift will come". Such a giver is endowed with the right view that beings inherit the fruits of their own kamma (*kammassakatā sammādiṭṭhi*).⁶³ He gives with faith, knowing that generosity leads to happiness and contributes eventually to liberation.

⁶² Añ.Ṭṭha.3.53 (commentary to AN 5.147 Asappurisaḍāna Sutta):

anāgamanadiṭṭhiko detīti katassa nāma phalaṃ āgamissatīti na evaṃ āgamanadiṭṭhiṃ na uppādetvā deti.

⁶³ Añ.Ṭṭkā.3.50 (sub-commentary to AN 5.147 Asappurisaḍāna Sutta):

“Addhā imassa dānassa phalameva āgacchatīti evaṃ yassa kammassakatādiṭṭhi atthi, so āgamanadiṭṭhiko, ayaṃ pana na tādisoti anāgamanadiṭṭhiko. Tenāha “katassa nāma phalaṃ āgamissatī” tiādi.



Conclusion

These five pairs from the **Asappurisdāna Sutta** show the difference between the offering of a bad person and that of a good person:

Wrong Way	Right Way
<i>Asakkaccaṃ deti</i> giving without respect	<i>Sakkaccaṃ deti</i> giving respectfully
<i>Acittīkatvā deti</i> giving without reverence	<i>Cittīkatvā deti</i> giving with reverence
<i>Asahatthā deti</i> giving not with one's own hand	<i>Sahatthā deti</i> giving personally
<i>Apaviddhaṃ deti</i> giving as if discarding	<i>Anapaviddhaṃ deti</i> giving without discarding
<i>Anāgamana-diṭṭhiko deti</i> giving without belief in results	<i>Āgamana-diṭṭhiko deti</i> giving believing in results

Another Sappurisdāna Sutta (AN 8.37)

The Sappurisdāna Sutta⁶⁴ in the Aṭṭhakanipāta lists eight qualities of gifts made by a good person:

1. ***Sucim deti*** – He gives what is pure. This means a gift that is purified and beautiful⁶⁵, such as food that is well-prepared, nicely arranged, and pleasing in appearance. For example, some donors make the extra effort to cut fruits neatly or arrange dishes attractively before offering.
2. ***Paṇītaṃ deti*** – He gives what is excellent. This means offering what has good taste—delicious and wholesome food⁶⁶.
3. ***Kālena deti*** – He gives a timely gift. This is a gift given at a suitable time⁶⁷, when it's truly needed, such as food at mealtime, medicine when someone is ill, and allowable juices at the appropriate hours. Earlier, we discussed the various forms of timely giving.

⁶⁴ Añ.3.74 (AN 8.37 Sappurisdāna Sutta)

⁶⁵ Añ.Ṭṭha.3.231 (Commentary to AN 8.37 Sappurisdāna Sutta):
sucinti parisuddhaṃ vaṇṇasampannaṃ deti.

⁶⁶ Añ.Ṭṭha.3.231 (Commentary to AN 8.37 Sappurisdāna Sutta):
paṇītaṃ rasūpapannaṃ.

⁶⁷ Añ.Ṭṭha.3.231 (Commentary to AN 8.37 Sappurisdāna Sutta):
kālenāti yuttapattakālena.



4. **Kappiyaṃ deti** – He gives what is allowable⁶⁸. This means understanding what is permissible for monks (*bhikkhus*) according to their rules (*Vinaya*) and offering it in the correct, allowable way.
5. **Viceyya deti** – He gives after investigation. He investigates and examines: “This gift will bear great fruit; this gift will not bear great fruit,” and then gives after seeking out recipients⁶⁹. This involves two kinds of investigation⁷⁰:
 - **Investigation of the recipient**: choosing those who are virtuous and have gone forth in the Buddha’s Dispensation rather than those outside the Teaching who are corrupt in virtue.
 - **Investigation of the gift**: choosing refined and excellent items, avoiding very inferior ones. Such well-chosen gifts yield great fruit.

⁶⁸ Añ.Ṭṭha.3.231 (Commentary to AN 8.37 Sappurisdāna Sutta):

kappiyanti yaṃ kappiyaṃ, taṃ deti.

⁶⁹ Añ.Ṭṭha.3.231 (Commentary to AN 8.37 Sappurisdāna Sutta):

viceyya detīti “imassa dinnaṃ mahapphalaṃ bhavissati, imassa na mahapphalan”ti evaṃ paṭiggāhakapariyesanavasena dānaṃ vā pañidhāvasena dānaṃ vā vicinitvā deti.

⁷⁰ Añ.Ṭṭkā.3.239 (Sub-commentary to AN 8.37 Sappurisdāna Sutta):

viceyya detīti ettha dve vicinanāni dakkhiṇeyyavicinanāṃ, dakkhiṇāvicinanañca. Tesu vipannasīle ito bahiddhā pañcanavuti pāsaṇḍabhedo ca dakkhiṇeyye pahāya sīlādiguṇasampannānaṃ sāsane pabbajitānaṃ dānaṃ **dakkhiṇeyyavicinanāṃ** nāma. Lāmakalāmake paccaye apānetvā pañitapaṇīte vicinitvā tesāṃ dānaṃ **dakkhiṇāvicinanāṃ** nāma. Tenāha “**imassa dinnaṃ mahapphalaṃ bhavissatī**”’tiādi.

- However, in the case of a Bodhisatta, he may not choose his recipients, because his purpose in giving is to fulfil his *pāramī*, reduce attachment, and benefit all who are in need.
6. ***Abhiṇhaṃ deti*** – He gives often. This need not be a large offering. It can even be simple regular offerings such as flowers or water to the Buddha. This should be done daily. Giving only occasionally shows less faith and respect. One should strive to give frequently and consistently.
 7. ***Dadaṃ cittaṃ pasādeti*** – While giving, he settles his mind in confidence.
 8. ***Datvā attamano hoti*** – Having given, he is elated. He reflects on his offering with happiness.⁷¹

Conclusion

In today's talk, we have explored the proper ways to make offerings according to the few suttas on the theme of ***sappurisdāna***—the giving of a good person.

I would like to conclude with a few stanzas from the Sappurisdāna Sutta in the Aṭṭhakanipāta:

*“Suciṃ paṇītaṃ kālena, kappiyaṃ pānabhojanaṃ.
Abhiṇhaṃ dadāti dānaṃ, sukhettesu brahmacārisu.*

⁷¹ These last two qualities have been discussed in an earlier talk in connection with the Chaṇḍadāna Sutta (Talk 1: Qualities of Dāna).



Neva vippaṭṭisārissa, cājivā āmisaṃ bahuṃ.

Evaṃ dinnāni dānāni, vaṇṇayanti vipassino.

Evaṃ yajitvā medhāvī, saddho muttena cetasā.

Abyābajjhaṃ sukhaṃ lokaṃ, paṇḍito upapajjati.”

He gives what is pure and excellent,
Allowable drinks and food, at the proper time.
He gives gifts frequently to the fertile fields of merit,
To those who live the spiritual life.

He does not feel regret,
Having given away many material things.
Those with deep insight praise
Gifts given in this way.

Having thus practised generosity
With a freely generous mind,
One who is intelligent, wise, and rich in faith
Is reborn in a pleasant, unafflicted world.

May you gain a good understanding of the right way to give.

May this teaching inspire you to donate like a noble and good person, and thereby derive abundant benefit from your offerings.

Sādhū! Sādhū! Sādhū!

5. The Timing of Donations

(Edited from a Dhamma talk given at Dhammavijaya Meditation Centre on 21 March 2018)

Today, I will give a short talk related to *dāna*, donation. Since it is close to lunchtime, and there are many lunch donors here today, it is most suitable to speak on the topic of giving.

This talk is based on one of the stories from the Dhammapada, known as the Cūleka-sāṭaka-brāhmaṇavatthu.⁷² The word *eka* means “one,” and *sāṭaka* means “cloth” or “robe.” So *eka-sāṭaka* literally means “one piece of cloth.” But in this context, it refers to “one who has only a single piece of cloth.”

This story is connected with the **timing of donation**.

When we have the intention to give, should we offer our donation immediately, or should we delay and donate later? Which way brings greater benefit? That is the question the Buddha addressed in this story.

⁷² Khu.Ṭṭha.3.1 Dhammapade (Commentary to Dhammapāda Verse 116 – cūlekasāṭakabrāhmaṇavatthu)



The First and the Last Disciples of the Buddha

During the Gotama Buddha's time, there were two disciples who attained enlightenment—one as the **first**, and the other as the **last**. Let us start with the one who was first to enlighten.

Do you know who was the very first disciple to attain enlightenment? He was Bhante Koṇḍañña. If you recite the first discourse, the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta, you may recall the line: "*Aññāsi Koṇḍañño*"—"Koṇḍañña has understood."⁷³ After listening to the Buddha's teaching, he was the first among all to realise the Dhamma. He attained before everyone else. He was number one.

Then, there was another disciple—the very last one. This was the last person who came to see the Buddha when the Buddha was near his *Parinibbāna*. He had heard about the Buddha from his teachers, "The Fully-enlightened Buddha rarely arises in the world." Because of this, when he knew the Buddha was close to passing away, he came, thinking it was his final chance to clear his doubt.

He thought, "Only the Buddha can remove this doubt of mine." So, he went to Upavattana, the Mallas' sāla grove near Kusinārā. At that time, the Buddha was very sick and very tired.

When this man arrived, he first had to seek permission from Venerable Ānanda, the Buddha's attendant. He said to

⁷³ Ma.3.371 (SN 56.11 Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta)

Venerable Ānanda, “I have a doubt. I wish to dispel it by listening to the Buddha’s teaching.”

Venerable Ānanda hesitated for a while. The man’s name was Subhadda—Subhadda Paribbājjaka, a wandering ascetic from another religion. Ānanda thought, “This person follows another doctrine. It will be very difficult for him to abandon his views. If he starts asking questions, it might only trouble the Buddha, who is already so weak.” So, at first, he didn’t allow Subhadda to approach.

But Subhadda asked again and again—he requested three times. Finally, the Buddha heard his voice and told Ānanda, “Allow Subhadda to come.”

Then, the Buddha taught him the Dhamma. And after that, Subhadda went forth and eventually gained realisation and became the **last disciple** to attain enlightenment.

Now, do not confuse this Subhadda with another Subhadda—the one who, after the Buddha’s passing, told the other *bhikkhus*, “Now we are free! The Buddha used to restrain us, saying what we should and should not do. But now, the Buddha has passed away—we can do whatever we like!” That was a different Subhadda.

The one who attained enlightenment near the Buddha’s death was the noble Subhadda, the *last disciple*.

Which type of person do you want to be – the first or the last to attain realisation? Did the *nimitta* appear to you at the start of this retreat or only toward the end? It may be related to the timing of donation.



The One Who Had Only One Piece of Cloth – Cūḷekasāṭaka

Earlier, we spoke about the timing of making donations. When we wish to give, should we act immediately or delay? To illustrate this, let us now come back to the story from the Dhammapada—the story of **Cūḷekasāṭaka**, “the one who had only one piece of cloth.”

A Poor Couple with Great Faith

Once, there lived a poor brahmin and his wife. Between them, they had two lower garments but shared only one upper cloth. One day, an announcer went around the town declaring that the Buddha would be giving a Dhamma talk.

Both the husband and wife wished to listen, but they faced a simple yet difficult problem—they had only one upper cloth. Whoever went out had to wear it, leaving the other to stay home. After some discussion, they agreed: the wife would attend the Buddha’s talk during the day, and when she returned, the husband would take the cloth and go to the monastery that night to listen for himself.

The Brahmin’s Struggle Between Stinginess and Generosity

That night, the brahmin—known as Cūḷekasāṭaka—listened to the Buddha’s teaching. The night was divided into three parts: the first watch, the second watch, and the last watch.

During the **first watch**, as he listened, he was deeply moved by Dhamma joy (*pīti*). His heart overflowed with devotion, and he wished to make an offering to the Buddha. But he looked around and realised he had nothing to give—only the upper cloth he was wearing. “How can I offer my only cloth?” he thought. His mind wavered. He tried to suppress his *cetanā*—his wholesome volition to give—and his stinginess prevailed.

During the **second watch**, after hearing more of the Buddha’s words, the wish to give arose again. “I really want to donate,” he thought, “but what will happen to my wife and to myself?” Again, hesitation took hold, and he restrained his mind once more.

Then came the **third watch**—the last part of the night. As he reflected, he thought: “Throughout this long *saṃsāra*, I have been bound again and again by stinginess. Because I could not overcome it, I have suffered and fallen into woeful realms countless times. Now, I shall make a donation!”

And with great determination, he removed his only upper cloth and offered it to the Buddha.

At that moment, he exclaimed joyfully, “*Jitaṃ me! Jitaṃ me!*”—“I have won! I have won!” He said this because there had been a great battle in his heart—a fierce struggle between stinginess and generosity. At last, generosity had triumphed.



The King's Curiosity and Reward

The king, who happened to hear someone shouting, “I have won! I have won!” wondered, “Who is this, claiming victory? Only a king should win!”

So he sent for the man and asked, “What have you won?”

Cūḷekasāṭaka replied respectfully, “Your Majesty, I have been fighting all night—a battle between stinginess and generosity. At last, generosity has won. I have given my only cloth to the Buddha.”

The king was pleased and said, “If that is so, I shall reward you.” He offered the brahmin **two pieces of cloth**. The brahmin, in turn, offered both to the Buddha.

Seeing his pure heart, the king gave him **four pieces of cloth**, and again, the brahmin offered them to the Buddha. Next, the king gave him **eight**, and then **sixteen**, and each time the brahmin offered all to the Buddha. Finally, the king gave him **thirty-two pieces of cloth**.

This time, the brahmin reflected: “People may think I am giving only because I wish to keep receiving more. I should not let others doubt my sincerity.” So he kept just two pieces—one for himself and one for his wife—and offered the remaining thirty to the Buddha.

Faith Rewarded with the Gift of Fours

When the king heard how the brahmin continued to offer everything, he was deeply impressed. He sent from his palace two fine woollen blankets—extremely expensive—and offered them to the brahmin.

The brahmin used one as a canopy above the Buddha’s bed, and the other as a canopy over the seats where he offered meals to the *bhikkhus*.

Later, when the king visited the monastery, he saw that even these blankets had been offered to the Buddha. Filled with joy, he thought, “Ah, this brahmin’s faith is as true as mine. He believes in what I believe in.”

Out of admiration, the king bestowed upon Cūḷekasāṭaka the ***Sabba-catukka Gift***—“the gift of everything in fours”: four elephants, four horses, four thousand coins, four women, four female slaves, four men, and four excellent villages.

Thus, from the offering of a single piece of cloth, born of pure generosity, came immense blessings and honour.

The Elder and the Younger Ekasāṭaka

In the commentary, it is mentioned that long ago, during the time of Vipassī Buddha, there was another person known as ***Mahā-ekasāṭaka***—“the elder eka-sāṭaka - the elder one with a single cloth.” This is a different person from the brahmin at the time of our Gotama Buddha who was named



Cūḷekasāṭaka—literally, “the younger Eka-sāṭaka.” The term *cūḷa* means “smaller” or “younger,” showing that this was the later counterpart of the elder one from Vipassī Buddha’s time.

Mahā-ekasāṭaka, too, made an offering of his only cloth. But unlike Cūḷekasāṭaka, who offered at the **last watch of the night**, Mahā-ekasāṭaka made his donation **during the first watch**. Because his generosity arose earlier—without hesitation—its result was even greater.

The Merit of Early Giving

When Mahā-ekasāṭaka made his offering, the power of his *cetanā*, his intention, was strong and prompt. Because of this timely and decisive generosity, the fruit of his merit ripened in abundance. When he received successively doubled rewards, he did not stop offering until he had obtained **sixty-four pieces of cloth**. Only then did he keep two—one for himself and one for his wife.

In contrast, Cūḷekasāṭaka, who gave only at the **last watch**, received blessings up to **thirty-two pieces of cloth** before he, too, kept two and offered the rest.

The difference lay not in the quantity of their offerings, but in the **timing of their giving**—and therefore, in the strength of their volition.

Because Mahā-ekasāṭaka acted quickly, his generosity bore fruit more richly. Because Cūḷekasāṭaka delayed, his merit was correspondingly less abundant.

Thus, even though both made the same kind of offering, the **timing** made the difference.

The Law of Timeliness in Merit

Sometime later, the Buddha explained to the community of monks that if Cūḷekasāṭaka had made his offering at the **first watch**, he would have received the **gift of sixteen sets**—sixteen elephants, sixteen horses, sixteen slaves, sixteen villages, and so on.

If he had given at the **second watch**, his fruit would have been **eight of each**.

But because he gave only at the **last watch**, his result was the **set of four**—four elephants, four horses, four slaves, four villages, and so on.

The Buddha thus revealed that even when the offering itself is the same, the **timing** of the act changes its karmic magnitude. The sooner one performs a wholesome deed, the greater and more radiant its result.



The Dhammapada Teaching: Do Good Without Delay

After telling this story, the Buddha recited Dhammapada Verse 116:

*Abhittharetha kalyāṇe, pāpā cittaṃ nivāraye.
Dandhañhi karoto puññaṃ, pāpasmim ramatī mano.*

Hasten to do good; restrain your mind from evil.
He who is slow in doing good—his mind delights in evil.

The Buddha’s message is clear:

Do good quickly. Don’t delay. Don’t wait for the perfect moment, because hesitation opens the door for unwholesome thoughts to creep in. When we are slow to act, the mind begins to delight in excuses, distractions, and worldly comfort.

Everyday Reflection: The Timing of Practice

This teaching applies not only to generosity but to all good actions—including meditation.

When you come to the meditation hall, are you the first to arrive, or the last? When you wake up in the early morning, do you rise promptly or linger under your blanket, thinking, “Just five more minutes”?

“Do Good Quickly” – The Commentary’s Explanation

The Buddha said, “*Abhittharetha kalyāṇe*”—do good deeds quickly.

The commentator explained that this should be done with the attitude:

“Ahaṃ pure, ahaṃ pure” — “I am first, I am first.”

When performing wholesome deeds such as offering donations, one should think, “Let me be the first! Let me be number one!”

If you are serving your preceptor, your teacher, or performing duties for the Saṅgha, you should approach it with this same enthusiasm and readiness. Not with pride, but with eagerness born of faith. This is the true meaning of “*Abhittharetha kalyāṇe*”—be quick in doing good.

Guarding the Mind from Evil

The next phrase is “*Pāpā cittaṃ nivāraye*.”

This means: restrain your mind from evil, protect it from bodily misconduct, verbal misconduct, and mental misconduct. We should not allow unwholesome mind to arise - not allowing it to slip into craving, anger, or delusion. The mind must be guarded carefully. When we do not guard the mind, the defilements—greed, hatred, and delusion—will quickly arise and pull it away from goodness.



The Danger of Delay

The final line of the verse reads:

“Dandhañhi karoto puññaṃ, pāpasmim ramatī mano.”

“He who is slow in doing good—his mind delights in evil.”

This means that when we hesitate to do good deeds, when we procrastinate or delay, the mind easily turns toward unwholesome thoughts.

Isn't it similar in meditation?

When your mind drifts away from the meditation object, what should you do? You must bring it back **quickly**. If you allow it to wander here and there for too long, the mind begins to take pleasure in distraction and unwholesome objects.

So too with generosity. If a person's wish to give arises but is overcome by stinginess or doubt, that generosity becomes weak. The mind delights in the unwholesome instead of the wholesome. The hesitation itself is a form of defilement—an opening through which greed or fear can enter.

Therefore, the Buddha urged us:

Abhittharetha kalyāṇe, pāpā cittaṃ nivāraye.

Dandhañhi karoto puññaṃ, pāpasmim ramatī mano.

Hasten to do good; restrain your mind from evil.

He who is slow in doing good—his mind delights in evil.

The Essence of the Teaching

When a wholesome intention arises—whether to give, to help, to meditate, or to forgive—act upon it **immediately**. Do not wait for “a better time.” Each moment of hesitation weakens the goodness and strengthens the defilements.

Just as the Brahmin Cūḷekasāṭaka won his battle only in the last watch of the night, we too are constantly fighting an inner battle—between generosity and greed, diligence and sloth, wisdom and delusion.

Victory comes to the one who acts swiftly for the good.

So remember the commentary’s joyful call:

“Ahaṃ pure, ahaṃ pure!”

“Let me be the first to do good!”

The Brothers and the Field of Faith

Let us continue with the story of the two disciples — the one who attained first and the one who attained last during the Buddha’s time.

These two were brothers in one of their earlier lives, long ago during the time of Vipassī Buddha. The elder brother was called **Mahākāla**, the elder Kāla; the younger brother was **Cūḷakāla**, the younger Kāla.

They shared one piece of land, a single paddy field for farming. When the crop began to grow, and the ears of paddy started to fill, the grains were still tender, still soft, not yet



mature. At that time, the elder brother, Mahākāla,⁷⁴ had a thought of faith:

“I want to make an offering to the Buddha.”

He wanted to take the tender paddy, extract the soft grains, and cook them into milk-rice to offer to the Buddha.

However, his younger brother, Cūlakāla, disagreed.

He said, “Brother, if you harvest now, the crops will be damaged. We will lose the yield. This will not bring any benefit.”

As they could not come to an agreement, the elder brother divided the land into two portions — one for himself and one for his younger brother. Each took responsibility for his own half of the field.

The First Offering — Milk Rice from the Tender Grain

Then Mahākāla took the tender grain from his portion. He mixed it with pure milk, unmixed with water, and had it cooked. He added *catumadhu* — the four sweet ingredients of honey, ghee, molasses/sugar, and sesame oil — and

⁷⁴ In the Aṅguttara Nikāya commentary (Aṅ.Ṭṭha.1.111) and in the Great Chronicle of Buddhas by Mingun Sayadaw (on the story of Koṇḍañña Mahāthera), it is stated that it was the elder brother, Mahākāla, who wanted to make the offering to the Buddha and would become the future Venerable Koṇḍañña. However, in the Dhammapada-commentary (Khu.Ṭṭha.2.62 sārīputtattheravatthu), it was the younger brother, Cūlakāla, who wanted to make the offering and became the future Venerable Koṇḍañña. The Aṅguttara-Nikāya explanation is adopted here.

offered this milk-rice as the first food to the Saṅgha headed by the Buddha.

And something wonderful happened. The ears of paddy from which he had taken the grain filled up again — just as before! The grains returned, full and plump.

This was due to two great causes: the purity of his **cetanā**, his intention to offer, and the **superior quality of the recipients**, the Buddha and the Saṅgha. Because of these, even though he gave, his store of merit did not decrease; rather, it multiplied.

The Nine Offerings — *Agga Dāna*, the Gift of the First Portion

Mahākāla continued to perform these first donations step by step through each stage of the paddy's growth and harvest:

1. **The first tender grain**, extracted before the crop matured.
2. **The first portion of the developing grain**, slightly hardened and is pounded to be used for making rice-cakes with milk and sugar.
3. **The first portion of the fully ripened grain.**
4. **The first portion of the harvested paddy.**
5. **The first portion of the tied sheaves.**



6. **The first portion from the first heap of paddy drying under the sun.**
7. **The first portion of paddy threshed by cows walking over the stalks.**
8. **The first portion of paddy winnowed and cleaned.**
9. **The first portion of paddy stored in the granary.**

Nine times, he offered the *first portion* — *aggadāna* — each time with deep faith and unwavering generosity.

And each time, the same miracle occurred: his harvest did not diminish. It became fuller, richer, and greater than before. His wealth was not reduced through giving — it multiplied through merit.

The Law of the First Fruit

This story teaches us about timing — not just *when* to give, but *how readily* to give. When the heart is moved by faith, that is the time to give. When the wholesome intention arises, that is the time to act.

Mahākāla, by giving the first portion again and again, planted the seeds for his future as one who would penetrate the Dhamma first. His younger brother, who delayed and hesitated, would later become the one who attained last.

Giving early, giving promptly, giving from the first — that is the essence of *aggadāna*, the gift of the first fruit.

The Fruits of Timely Giving

All those wholesome deeds that Mahākāla performed — the nine *aggadānas*, the offerings of the first portions — were not mere acts of generosity. They were the fulfilment of a **great aspiration** he had made in the distant past:

“May I, in the future, be the first disciple of a Buddha to gain attainment.”

Through that life of abundant and timely giving, his aspiration bore fruit. In the time of our Buddha Gotama, that same being was reborn as Bhante Koṇḍañña, who became the **first disciple** to gain attainment after hearing the Dhammacakkapavattana Sutta at Isipatana.

The Buddha declared him to be “*rattaññū etadagga*” — foremost among the bhikkhus who are the most senior by ordination. His *promptness* in giving, his *zeal* in doing good, and his *faithful timing* ripened into spiritual precedence — the first to penetrate the Dhamma.

The Lesson of Delay

As for his younger brother, Cūḷakāla, he too offered to the Buddha — but only after everything was completed, when the paddy had been harvested, threshed, winnowed, and stored neatly in the granary. He gave, but he gave **last**.

Because of this delay, his karmic result was also delayed. In the time of the Buddha Gotama, he became the **last disciple** to attain arahantship.



So this story is not only about the merit of giving, but also about **timing** — when to give, when to act, when to do good.

Hasten to Do Good

In the *Dhammapada*, the Buddha exhorts us:

“Abhittharetha kalyāṇe, pāpā cittaṃ nivāraye.”

Hasten to do good; restrain your mind from evil.

When a wholesome thought arises, don’t wait for a better day or a more convenient hour. The window of purity is brief. Act while the heart is bright and faith is strong.

Some people may say, “I have practised for a long time, but I have not yet seen results.” There can be many reasons. But if it concerns giving, we can draw lessons from the stories above—perhaps the giving was **too late**, delayed until faith had cooled or opportunity had passed.

If you wish to be among the first to gain the fruits of merit, then be among the first to act — quick in generosity, quick in virtue, quick in cultivating the Dhamma.

May you, too, gain the fruits of your wholesome deeds swiftly, and may your aspirations ripen beautifully and without delay.

Sādhū! Sādhū! Sādhū!

6. Benefits of Donation Here and Now

(Edited from a Dhamma talk given at Dhammavijaya Meditation Centre on 24 March 2018)

Today I will give a short Dhamma talk on the Sīha-senāpati Sutta,⁷⁵ which is found in the Aṅguttara Nikāya.

Sīha was the name of a person. *Senāpati* means “commander of the army” — *senā* means “army,” and *pati* means “leader.” So *Sīha Senāpati* was the general, the commander of the army.

He went to the Buddha and asked,

“Venerable Sir, can you explain the benefits of donation that are visible here and now?”

He wanted to know what benefits can be seen in this very life from practising *dāna*.

The Nature of Giving

Do you know any benefits of giving that can already be seen in the present life?

Once, I saw a T-shirt that said, “If you give me a piece of chocolate, I will be nicer to you.”

⁷⁵ Aṅ.2.33 (AN 5.34 Sīhasenāpati Sutta) and Aṅ.2.457 (AN 7.57 Sīhasenāpati Sutta)



That's one kind of benefit that is visible here and now! If you give chocolates, people may treat you with more kindness.
(laughs)

But what did the Buddha say about the benefits of giving that are visible here and now?

1. Being Loved by Many People

The first benefit the Buddha mentioned is **being loved by many** (*bahuno janassa piyo hoti manāpo*).

When you give, people naturally love and appreciate you. You become dear and agreeable to others.

Even in daily life, one of the ways to maintain good relationships is through giving gifts.⁷⁶ If you want to maintain harmony with your friends, family, or colleagues, you can offer small gifts with a sincere heart. Giving strengthens relationships, and people will feel closer to you.

This is one visible benefit of *dāna*.

⁷⁶ Añ.1.341 (AN 4.32 Saṅgha Sutta):

cattārimāni, bhikkhave, saṅghavatthūni. katamāni cattāri? dānaṃ, peyyavajjaṃ, atthacariyā, samānattatā — imāni kho, bhikkhave, cattāri saṅghavatthūni.

Bhikkhus, there are these four means of sustaining a favourable relationship. What four? Giving, endearing speech, beneficent conduct, and impartiality. These are the four means of sustaining a favourable relationship.

2. Being Approached by Noble Persons

The next benefit is **being approached by noble persons**—those who are virtuous and worthy of offerings (*santo sappurisā bhajanti*).

When you have faith in giving, noble persons may come to you.

In the Buddha's time, there were *bhikkhus* who attained *nirodha-samāpatti*—the attainment of cessation. After emerging from that special attainment, if someone had the opportunity to offer *dāna* to such *bhikkhus*, they would gain great merit even in that present life.

Noble ones, seeing through their knowledge those with faith, will naturally be drawn to approach such faithful people. However, if someone lacks faith, they may not only fail to give but even criticise or berate noble ones. Such actions bring heavy unwholesome results. Therefore, noble persons may not wish to associate with them.

So if you have faith in *dāna*, noble persons may approach you. That is another benefit that can be seen here and now.



3. Gaining Fame and Followers

The next benefit is **having fame and many followers** (*kalyāṇo kittisaddo abbhuggacchati*).

If you have the habit of giving generously, you will gain a good reputation and many followers.

For example, the donor who offers today's lunch may also be given the privilege to be the first to offer to the Bhantes during the meal-offering later. That, too, is a form of honour or fame resulting from generosity.

When you consistently give, more and more people will know and appreciate you. If we look around, we can see that many successful and respected people are also those who frequently give and help others. It is often their generosity that makes them more admired than others. That is another benefit that can be seen here and now.

4. Having Confidence and Courage

Another benefit is **courage and confidence** when approaching an audience (*yaṃ yadeva paṇisaṃ upasaṅkamati — yadi khattiyapaṇisaṃ yadi brāhmaṇa-paṇisaṃ yadi gahapatipaṇisaṃ yadi samaṇapaṇisaṃ — visārado upasaṅkamati amaṅkubhūto* – whatever assembly one approaches – whether of khattiyas, brahmins, householders, or ascetics – one approaches it confidently and composed.).

Stingy people are often shy or withdrawn; they may fear facing others. But generous people have confidence. Their hearts are open, and they can mix easily with people.

When one has *dāna cetanā*—a wholesome intention to give—one feels unafraid and uplifted in the presence of others. Thus, generosity brings inner strength and confidence. That is another benefit that can be seen here and now.

These are the benefits that can be seen in the present life.

5. Benefits Beyond This Life

Although *Sīha* did not ask about future results, the Buddha went on to explain further:

After a generous person passes away, they are reborn in a happy destination—among humans or devas.

This is a benefit not visible here and now, but experienced after death.

Upon hearing this, *Sīha Senāpati* said:

“Venerable Sir, I can accept the benefits that are visible here and now, for these I know from my own experience. But as for the benefit after death, I cannot know it from personal experience—yet, having faith in the Blessed One, I accept it as true.”



Conclusion

These, then, are the benefits of *dāna*—the blessings of giving that can be experienced both here and now, and in future existences:

1. You are loved by many.
2. You are approached by noble persons.
3. You gain fame and followers.
4. You develop confidence and courage.
5. And after death, you are reborn in a happy realm.

Another Sīha-senāpati Sutta

There is another Sīhasenāpati Sutta in the Aṅguttara Nikāya, chapter of the sevens.⁷⁷ The commander-in-chief, Sīha, similarly asked the Buddha to explain the benefits of donation that are visible here and now.

In that sutta, the Buddha gave an expanded answer of seven benefits for one endowed with faith, a munificent giver who delights in charity (*puriso saddho dānapati anuppadānato*):

⁷⁷ Añ.2.457 (AN 7.57 Sīhasenāpati Sutta)

1. The arahants would first show compassion to him (*taṃyeva arahanto paṭhamam anukampantā anukampeyyum*).
2. The arahants would first approach him (*taṃyeva arahanto paṭhamam upasaṅkamantā upasaṅkameyyum*).
3. The arahants would first receive alms from him (*tasseva arahanto paṭhamam paṭiggaṇhantā paṭiggaṇheyyum*).
4. The arahants would first teach the Dhamma to him (*tasseva arahanto paṭhamam dhammam desentā deseyyum*).
5. He would acquire a good reputation (*tasseva kalyāṇo kittisaddo abbhuggaccheyya*).
6. He would approach any assembly—whether of khattiyas, brahmins, householders, or ascetics—confidently and composed (*so yaṃyadeva parisam upasaṅkameyya, yadi khattiya-parisam yadi brāhmaṇa-parisam yadi gahapati-parisam yadi samaṇa-parisam visārado upasaṅkameyya amaṅkubhūto*).
7. He would be reborn in a good destination, in a heavenly world, with the breakup of the body, after death (*so kāyassa bhedaṃ paramaṃ maraṇā sugatim saggam lokam upapajjeyya*).



By understanding this, may you be inspired to practise generosity with joy and mindfulness, and may you come to experience the present and future fruits of *dāna*.

Sādhu! Sādhu! Sādhu!

7. Sharing Merits after Donations

(Edited from a Dhamma talk given at Dhammavijaya Meditation Centre on 23 March 2018)

The Story of the Peta of the Doll

Today, I will give a short talk from the Petavatthu. The name of the story is Piṭṭha-dhīṭalika-peta-vatthu.⁷⁸ *Piṭṭha-dhīṭalikā* means a figurine or a doll made from rice powder.

If you pound rice into fine powder and mix it with water, you will get a sticky, cement-like paste. You can then use this paste to make a figurine. That is *piṭṭha-dhīṭalikā* — a doll made from rice powder.

There was an event during the Buddha’s time that took place in the house of Anāthapiṇḍika.

Anāthapiṇḍika had a granddaughter, a young girl who was perhaps seven, eight, or ten years old. Her nanny gave her a figurine — a doll made from rice powder — to play with.

Her nanny told her, “Young girl, this is your ‘daughter,’ so you must take care of her.”

The girl often played with that doll.

⁷⁸ Khu.Ṭṭha.9.15 (Petavatthu-aṭṭhakathā, Piṭṭhadhīṭalikapetavatthuvannaṇā)



One day, she accidentally dropped it, and the doll broke. At that moment, she began to cry because, in her mind, her “daughter” had died.

No one could console her. Because of this, the people in Anāthapiṇḍika’s household brought the granddaughter to him.

At that time, Anāthapiṇḍika was offering service to the Buddha and some monks.

He placed the little girl on his lap and said,

“Alright, if your ‘daughter’ has passed away, then tomorrow we will make a donation and share merits with her.”

Anāthapiṇḍika then invited the Buddha and the Buddha’s disciples, saying,

“Please accept my invitation to tomorrow’s meal offering. After that, we will share merits with the *peta* of that doll — the *piṭṭha-dhītalikā*.”

Upon hearing this, the child stopped crying.

The Buddha’s Advice

The next day, the Buddha and his disciples came to Anāthapiṇḍika’s house. After the meal, the Buddha gave a Dhamma talk and uttered the following verse:

*“yaṃ kiñcārammaṇaṃ katvā, dajjā dānaṃ amaccharī;
pubbapete ca ārabbha, atha vā vatthudevatā.”*

Those who are free from stinginess should give donations for whatever reason — dedicating to departed *petas*, and to the *vatthu-devatā*, the guardian devas of the place.⁷⁹

In this stanza, the Buddha taught the proper way to perform *dāna*:

Those without stinginess should give on any occasion and for any wholesome reason. They should make donations, dedicating the merits either to *petas* or to the protector devas.

⁷⁹ This is the first stanza in the Piṭṭhadhītalikapetavatthu (Khu.2.128 Petavatthu). The remaining three stanzas are:

*cattāro ca mahārāje, lokapāle yasassine.
kuveraṃ dhataratṭhañca, virūpakkhaṃ virūlhakaṃ.
te ceva pūjitā honti, dāyakā ca anipphalā.*

And the Four Great Kings, renowned guardians of the world, namely Kuvera, Dhataratṭha, Virūpakkha, and Virūlhaka; they themselves are also honoured [by this act of dedication]. And the donors are not without fruit [for they themselves indeed gain the benefit of their own generosity].

*na hi ruṇṇaṃ vā soko vā, yā caññā paridevanā.
na taṃ petassa atthāya, evaṃ tiṭṭhanti ñātayo.*

For weeping, sorrow, and any other lamentation do not benefit the departed; [even though] their [ignorant] relatives remain persisting thus.

*ayañca kho dakkhiṇā dinnā, saṅghamhi suppatiṭṭhitā.
dīgharattaṃ hitāyassa, ṭhānaso upakappati.*

And this offering, indeed, when given and well-established in the Saṅgha, will serve, with immediate effect, for their long-term benefit.



Dedicating Merits to the Protector Devas

Who are the protector devas?

In the stanza following that, the Buddha mentioned the four great kings — *Cattāro Mahārājā*. The Cātumahārājika deva realm is the celestial plane where these four great kings reside. They are: **Dhataratṭha**, **Virūlhaka**, **Virūpakkha**, and **Kuvera**.

*puratthimena dhataratṭho, dakkhiṇena virūlhako,
pacchimena virūpakkho, kuvero uttaraṃ disaṃ.*⁸⁰

Puratthimena Dhataratṭho — On the eastern side of Mount Meru resides the deva Dhataratṭha, who faces west. Dhataratṭha is the leader of the *gandhabba* devas — a kind of celestial beings who dwell in fragrant trees and live on the fragrance of those trees. They protect such fragrance. They are also known as the singing or dancing devas. Dhataratṭha is their leader.

Dakkhiṇena Virūlhako — On the southern side of Mount Meru lives the great king Virūlhaka, facing north. He is the leader of the *kumbhaṇḍa* devas, a type of deva who may be somewhat fierce and sometimes disturb people. That is the southern side.

Pacchimena Virūpakkho — On the western side lives the great king Virūpakkha, facing east. Virūpakkha is the leader of the *nāgas* — serpent beings or poisonous creatures.

⁸⁰ Āṭānāṭiya-paritta.

Here in this meditation retreat, we recite the Khandha Sutta every day, sending *mettā* to the deva Virūpakka so that we will not be troubled by poisonous creatures in the retreat centre. He is the protector of all *nāgas*. *Nāgas* are animals, but their leader is a deva. They have their leader and they live by their own rules.

Kuvera Uttaram — On the northern side, facing south, lives the great king Kuvera. He is the leader who controls the *yakkhas* — beings often referred to as demons. All the *yakkhas* are ruled by him.

These four deva kings — the guardians of the east, south, west, and north — are called *lokapālā*, protectors of the world. They are the protector devas who safeguard the world.

Their followers live near houses or monasteries, or on trees nearby. They are also considered protector devas. They may choose to protect you as they wish.⁸¹ They observe situations

⁸¹ Vi.3.324 (Mahāvagga, Bhesajjakkhandhako, Sunidhavassakāravatthu); Dī.2.75 (DN 16 Mahāparinibbāna Sutta, pāṭaliputtanagaramāpanaṃ); Khu.1.187 Udāne (Ud 76 Pāṭaligāmiyasuttaṃ):

“yasmim padese kappeti, vāsaṃ paṇḍitajātiyo.

sīlavantettha bhojetvā, saññate brahmacārayo.

In whatever place a wise man makes his home,

There, having fed the virtuous and restrained practitioners of the holy life,

“yā tattha devatā āsum, tāsaṃ dakkhiṇāmādisē.

tā pūjitā pūjayanti, mānitā mānayanti naṃ.

One should dedicate the merit of the offering

to whatever devas dwell there.

Worshipped thus, the devas worship in return;

honoured, they honour him.



and watch what you are doing — most of the time, they know.

So, you do not have complete privacy to do evil things!

One of the qualities of the Buddha is *a-raham* — “one without secrets.” The Buddha is completely pure, with nothing to conceal. *A-raham* means that nothing remains hidden, for someone will always know. In the same way, when you do something unwholesome or harbour harmful intentions, these devas will know — unless they are uninterested, distracted, or wandering elsewhere. Normally, they know what people are doing.

These are the protector devas.

Dedicating Merits to the *Petas*

You should make donations dedicating to the protector devas, and you should also make donations dedicating to the *petas*.

Although you dedicate your merits to devas and *petas*, your own merits are not reduced — they remain the same.

What, then, are the benefits of sharing merits with the *petas*?

“tato naṃ anukampanti, mātā puttamva orasaṃ.

devatānukampito poso, sadā bhadraṇi passatī”ti.

Thereupon they show compassion for him,
like a mother for her own beloved son.

A person favoured by the compassion of devas
always beholds auspicious things.

Some types of *petas* depend on the merits of others for their welfare. It is very possible to be reborn as a *peta* if, at the moment of death, the mind clings with strong attachment to something. Even among your departed relatives, some may have been reborn as *petas*.

These *petas* often remain near their relatives, longing for the sharing of merits gained through acts of *dāna*. When you give donations and dedicate them to these departed ones, they can receive those merits and feel happiness.

If they rejoice in the merits shared with them, they may be released from the *peta* realm — freed from the suffering of *peta* existence. They can experience immediate results from the merits you dedicate to them.

This is different from beings in other realms, where the results of wholesome *kamma* do not appear immediately. For *petas*, however, they may enjoy spontaneous benefits as soon as you dedicate the merits to them after your act of *dāna*.

Assurance of a Receiver with Morality

However, for the sharing of merits to be truly effective, the donation must involve a receiver with good morality, or a donor who possesses wholesome qualities such as morality. If both the receiver and the donor lack morality, the *petas* will not be able to gain any merit.



There is a story about making a donation three times.⁸²

Once, there was a hunter who wished to make an offering and dedicate the merits to a departed relative. The receiver of his donation was a so-called monk who had no morality. The hunter offered donations to this so-called monk three times, each time dedicating the merits to his departed relative who had become a *peta*. But the *peta* did not benefit at all from those offerings.

On the third occasion, the *peta* appeared and said to him,

“Oh, your merit is incomplete. The one who is neither a layperson nor a true monk has robbed and destroyed me!”

This is what is meant by “your merit is incomplete.” Because of this, when making donations, either the receiver or the donor should have morality — at least one side should possess it. If both have morality, it is even better.

⁸² Ma.Ṭṭha.4.227 (Commentary to MN 142 Dakkhiṇāvibhaṅgasutta):

neva dāyakatoti ettha vaḍḍhamānavāsīluddako kathetabbo. so kira petadakkhiṇāṃ dento ekassa dussīlasseva tayo vāre adāsi, tatiyavāre “amanusso dussīlo maṃ vilumpatī”ti viravi, ekassa sīlavantabhikkhuno datvā pāpitakāleyevassa pāpuṇi.

Here, in connection with “neither from the donor [nor from the recipient],” the story of the hunter who lives in Vaḍḍhamāna should be told. It is said that while giving offerings dedicating merits to the departed, he gave to only one immoral monk three times. At the third time, [the *peta*] cried out, “An immoral non-human is robbing me!” Having given to a virtuous bhikkhu, the merit reached him even at the very moment of giving.

To ensure that your merits are effective, when you donate to monks, you should do so with the Buddha, the Dhamma, and the Saṅgha in mind — especially by recollecting the noble qualities of the Saṅgha. If you do so, the receiver represents the Saṅgha, and it is assured that the Saṅgha possesses good morality. You should make your offering in this way and then share the merits.

If you make donations to others outside the Saṅgha, or if you give to an immoral monk while recollecting the noble qualities of the Saṅgha, you may still generate wholesome kamma. But the *petas* are often observant — especially toward monks. They may know the conduct of the monks. If they see behaviour that is improper or unworthy, they may lose faith and respect. When their minds are clouded and unsettled, they may not rejoice in the merits offered to them.

Therefore, only when the receiver is of high morality and worthy of their respect can the *petas*’ minds become clear, allowing them to rejoice and partake in the shared merits.

In the Ākankheyya Sutta,⁸³ the Buddha gave this advice:

“Bhikkhus, if a bhikkhu should wish: ‘When my kinsmen and relatives who have passed away and died remember me with confidence in their minds, may that bring them great fruit and great benefit,’ let him perfect his virtue,

⁸³ Ma.1.40 (MN 6 Ākankheyya Sutta):

“ākaṅkheyya ce, bhikkhave, bhikkhu — ‘ye maṃ ñātī sālohitā petā kālaṅkatā pasannacittā anussaranti tesaṃ taṃ mahapphalaṃ assa mahānisaṃsaṇ’ti, sīlesvevassa paripūrakārī ajjhataṃ cetosamathamānuyutto anirākatajjhāno vipassanāya samannāgato brūhetā suññāgārānaṃ.”



be devoted to internal serenity of mind, maintain unbroken *jhāna*, be possessed of insight, and cultivate empty dwellings.”⁸⁴

⁸⁴ The commentary to MN 6 Ākankheyya Sutta (Ma.Ṭṭha.1.164) elaborates:

yassa hi bhikkhuno kālaṅkato pitā vā mātā vā “amhākaṃ ñātako thero sīlavā kalyāṇadhammo”ti pasannacitto hutvā taṃ bhikkhuṃ anussarati, tassa so cittappasādupi taṃ anussaraṇamattampi mahapphalaṃ mahānisaṃsameva hoti, anekāni kappasatasahassāni duggatito vāretuṃ ante ca amataṃ pāpetuṃ samatthameva hoti.

When a bhikkhu’s father or mother has passed away, and with a serene and confident mind they think, ‘Our relative, the elder, is virtuous and of good conduct,’ and they recollect that bhikkhu—then even with that serene confidence in mind, that mere act of recollection, yields great fruit and great benefit. It is powerful enough to shield them from the lower realms for hundreds of thousands of aeons and, eventually to lead them to the Deathless.

vuttañhetaṃ bhagavatā “ye te, bhikkhave, bhikkhū sīlasampannā samādhisampannā paññā, vimutti, vimuttiñāṇadassanasampannā, dassanaṃpāhaṃ, bhikkhave, tesāṃ bhikkhūnaṃ bahukāraṃ vadāmi. savanaṃ, anussatiṃ, anupabbajjaṃ, upasaṅkamaṃ, payirupāsanaṃpāhaṃ, bhikkhave, tesāṃ bhikkhūnaṃ bahukāraṃ vadāmi”ti (Khu.1.267 - itivu. 104 Sīlasampanna Sutta).

The Blessed One has said, ‘Bhikkhus, those bhikkhus who are accomplished in virtue, accomplished in concentration, accomplished in wisdom, accomplished in liberation, and accomplished in the knowledge and vision of liberation – I say that seeing such bhikkhus is of great benefit. Hearing them, recalling them, going forth under them, approaching them, and attending upon—I say that all these are of great benefit.’ (Itivu 104 Sīlasampanna Sutta)

tasmā ñātisālohitānaṃ attani cittappasādassa anussatiyā ca mahapphalaṃ icchantenāpi sīlādiguṇayutteneva, bhavitabbanti dasseti. Therefore, one desiring great benefit for departed relatives—through their serene confidence in oneself and recollection of oneself—should be endowed with virtue and other qualities.

Benefits of Sharing Merits

There was once a *bhikkhu* whose mother had passed away and was reborn as a *peta*. When she saw her son practising well, her mind became joyful, and immediately she was freed from the *peta* existence.

Petas experience the results of *kusala* spontaneously — when they rejoice in the merits shared with them, they can receive immediate benefits. This is the only way to truly help them. Crying, calling out to them, or speaking to them will not relieve their suffering.

What about the protector *devas*? If you share merits with the protector *devas*, they will be very pleased. It is like giving them a gift. When someone gives you a gift, what would you do? You would be happy, appreciative, and perhaps wish to return the kindness. In the same way, when protector *devas* receive shared merits, they too may help and protect you in return.

If you share merits with the Four Great Kings, they will take care of you. The *yakkhas* (demons) will have to stay away. The *nāgas* (dragons or poisonous creatures) will also not trouble you, because you are protected by these four great protectors. Therefore, it is important to share merits with the protector *devas* whenever you perform wholesome deeds.

Accumulating wholesome kamma is also a form of protection. To establish lasting protection for yourself, you should also observe the Five Precepts. That is the true



foundation of long-term protection — protection through your own *sīla* (morality).

Dedicating Merits to the Yama King

Another important being to share merits with is King Yama, the ruler who presides over those reborn in the hell realms. He examines beings who have fallen there to determine their causes and conditions.

Some beings are reborn in hell not because of heavy *akusala* (unwholesome kamma), but due to minor misdeeds or carelessness. Such beings may not experience immediate intense suffering. They may be reborn in a place where there is no direct torment, but upon seeing the flames of hell nearby, they become afraid. In that moment of fear, they may try to recall their past *kusala* (wholesome deeds). If they can remember, they may be released from that realm.

If a being wanders uncertainly, unable to determine where to go, the other beings in hell will bring him before King Yama. King Yama, being compassionate, tries to help the being recall his wholesome deeds so that he may escape suffering.

He questions them gently: “When you were living in the human world, did you ever see a child — a messenger from the *devas* reminding you of rebirth?”⁸⁵

“Yes, I have seen.”

⁸⁵ Ma.3.217 (MN130 Devadūta Sutta)

“Thinking that you too would be reborn as a child one day, did you perform any wholesome deeds?”

“I was negligent.”

“Then, due to your negligence, you must now face the results of unwholesomeness.”

But King Yama continues,

“Did you see another divine messenger — people who were sick? By seeing them, did you reflect, ‘One day I too will be sick. I may or may not recover from that illness. I should perform wholesome deeds as insurance for my future life’?”

“I did not do so,” replies the being.

“Then you must now face suffering because of your lack of *kusala*.”

Still, King Yama persists out of compassion:

“Did you see the old, frail people nearing death? By seeing them, did you understand that you too would grow old one day and therefore perform wholesome deeds?”

Again, the being replies, “I was negligent.”

Finally, King Yama asks about the last divine messenger — the dead.

“Did you see the bodies of the deceased while you were in the human world? By seeing them, did you contemplate, ‘I too will die one day’? Did you perform wholesome deeds with that understanding?”



Death is the most certain and powerful of the divine messengers. Some beings may remember their wholesome actions at this point, while others may not.

For those who cannot remember, King Yama checks further: “Did this person ever share merits with me?” If he has received your merits even once or twice, King Yama will remember — because he is a *deva*, and time in the deva realm passes differently. What seems a long time for humans may be only a few days for him. In general, *devas* possess clearer awareness and sharper knowledge than humans.⁸⁶

If King Yama remembers your merit-sharing, he will say, “You have shared merits with me before. Please try to recall that wholesome act.” Hearing this, the being may remember his good deeds and thereby be freed from that realm.

But if he cannot recall any *kusala*, then King Yama can only look on compassionately as the beings of hell take him away to undergo the torments of that realm. King Yama cannot intervene because those sufferings arise from one’s own deeds.

Most of us may not fall into such a place because of the many merits we have accumulated. Still, when we perform wholesome actions, we should remember to share merits

⁸⁶ Vi.Ṭṭha.1.220 (pārājikakaṇḍa-aṭṭhakathā, sikkhāpaccakkhānavibhaṅga-vaṇṇanā)

devatā nāma mahāpaññā tihetukapaṭisandhikā atikhippaṃ jānanti, cittañca nāmetaṃ lahuparivattaṃ.

Devas with great wisdom and three-rooted rebirth-linking know very quickly, and this mind is indeed changing rapidly.

with King Yama. If, unfortunately, one were to be reborn in that realm, King Yama would grant time and opportunity to recall one's wholesome deeds. That is the special benefit of sharing merits with King Yama.

Sharing Merits with Other Beings

What about sharing merits with other people or other *devas*? When we see someone doing wholesome deeds, and we rejoice sincerely in their goodness, that too is *kusala*.

During the Buddha's time, Visākhā built a monastery in the city of Sāvattthī. It was named Pubbārāma. This was different from the Jetavana Monastery, which was located on the southern side of Sāvattthī and was donated by Anāthapiṇḍika. Pubbārāma Monastery, which stood on the eastern side of the city, was offered by Visākhā.

On one of her visits to Pubbārāma, her attendant lady accompanied her. When this attendant saw the beautiful monastery, she felt great joy and rejoiced in Visākhā's meritorious act of offering it to the Buddha. Because of that wholesome kamma of rejoicing, when she passed away, she was reborn as a female deva.⁸⁷ She attained this deva existence merely through rejoicing — without performing any *kusala* of her own. This shows that rejoicing in others'

⁸⁷ Khu.1.61 Vimānavatthumhi (Vihāravimānavatthu) and its commentary (Khu.Ṭṭha.8.174)



wholesome deeds is itself *kusala* and can lead to rebirth in a heavenly realm.

When we share merits with other people or other *devas*, if they know about it and feel happy, they too can gain *kusala*. However, for them, the results are not immediate — they must wait for those *kusala* to mature at the right time.

If we share merits with beings who are completely unaware of our *kusala*, it is uncertain whether they will receive the merits. There is little chance for them to benefit. If they are closely related to us, because of the bond between us, it might be slightly possible for them to feel happiness or peace of mind, but they cannot actually receive *kusala* if their minds are not directed toward our merits. If, at that time, they are overcome by unwholesome thoughts, they cannot receive the benefits. Thus, awareness and rejoicing are essential for the sharing of merits to be effective.

Now, returning to our original story —

With these teachings in mind, Anāthapiṇḍika and his relatives made donations and dedicated the merits to their departed family members for about three months. Because of this continuous offering, the Buddha and the *bhikkhus* did not go to see King Pasenadi of Kosala during that time.

After one month, King Pasenadi wondered why the *bhikkhus* had not been coming. He asked the reason, and the Buddha explained to him about the story of the doll and the donation made for the *peta* of the doll.

Hearing this, King Pasenadi understood. He, too, offered *dāna* to the bhikkhu Saṅgha led by the Buddha, dedicating the merits to the *petas* for a full month. Seeing the king's example, the people of the country followed likewise. They continued to make donations for another month in memory of their departed relatives.

The purpose of sharing these stories is to help us understand the great benefits of sharing merits. Therefore, whenever you perform wholesome deeds, may you wisely share your merits — with the protector *devas*, with your departed relatives, and with King Yama.

May all beings be able to rejoice and receive your merits.

Sādhu! Sādhu! Sādhu!



8. Aspirations

(Edited from a Dhamma talk given at Dhammavijaya Meditation Centre on 19 March 2018)

In the previous Dhamma talks, we have discussed *dāna* (giving), the qualities of the receiver, the qualities of the donor, and the proper way to give.

Today, I will speak about **making aspirations**.

Wholesomeness as *Cintāmaṇi* and *Kapparukkha*

According to the *Vimānavatthu*, wholesomeness is like a *cintāmaṇi* ruby⁸⁸—a wish-fulfilling gem. Whoever possesses this gem will obtain whatever he wishes for.

Do you want such a gem?

But perhaps it is better not to get it right now! (laughs) If you could instantly obtain whatever you wished for, you might leave this retreat immediately and return home to Singapore!

The *cintāmaṇi* ruby symbolizes the power of wholesomeness. When one accumulates wholesome kamma, one will eventually obtain whatever one aspires for.

Another simile says that wholesomeness is like a *kapparukkha*, a wishing tree. It is a kind of tree from which

⁸⁸ Khu.Ṭṭha.8.28 (*Vimānavatthu* commentary) – reference for both *cintāmaṇi* and *kapparukkha*.



anything one wishes for can be obtained. Such trees are found in the deva realms, but in the human world, we sometimes see symbolic *kapparukkha* trees during the *Kathina* season, especially in Myanmar.

People create the shape of a tree using wood, forming its trunk and branches. Then they hang offerings on it—red packets, towels, detergent, even money. All these items are later given as donations to the *Saṅgha* or to other receivers. Such a tree is called a *kapparukkha*.

So, just as devas can obtain whatever they wish from the *kapparukkha* according to their kamma, the power of wholesomeness can bring us whatever we aspire for.

When we perform wholesome deeds, we create the causes that allow our aspirations to be fulfilled.

Aspirations in the Jātaka Stories

In the *Jātaka* stories, we find many examples of how aspirations made with faith and wholesome intention can bear fruit in future lives.

(a) The Aspiration of Princess Pabhāvatī

In the *Kusa Jātaka*⁸⁹, there was a very beautiful princess named Pabhāvatī—she was the future Yasodharā. Her body

⁸⁹ Khu.Ṭṭha.21.296 (Commentary to Jātaka no. 531: Kusa Jātaka)

was radiant; even in a dark room without lamps, her body emitted light.

This radiance was the result of an aspiration she had made in a past life. At that time, she offered fresh ghee to a *Pacceka Buddha*. As the ghee glowed under the sunlight, she made the aspiration:

“Wherever I am born, may my body shine as brightly as this ghee. May I be incomparably beautiful!”

But because she was angry at the Bodhisatta then, she also wished, “May I never have to live with this rude man again!”

When the *Bodhisatta* heard this, he in turn made the aspiration:

“In the future, even if this woman lives a hundred *yojanas* away, may I have the power to win her and take her as my wife.”

Because both of them made their aspirations after performing superior wholesome deeds of offering to a *Pacceka Buddha*, those wishes were fulfilled. In her later life, she was reborn as Princess Pabhāvatī, radiant and beautiful beyond compare, while the Bodhisatta was born as King Kusa. Through great effort and perseverance, he eventually won her heart, just as he had wished.



(b) The Aspiration of Ummānantī

Another story concerns Ummānantī⁹⁰, who in the time of our Gotama Buddha became the Arahant *bhikkhunī* Uppalavaṇṇā.

Prior to the life as Ummānantī, she was a girl from a very poor family. One day, she saw other women wearing fine robes and longed to wear something as beautiful. But since her family was poor, she agreed to work for three years in a rich man's house in exchange for a single scarlet robe.

She worked diligently, and before the three years were over, the rich man gave her the robe out of compassion and to reward her for her dedication.

As she was about to bathe in the river and wear the robe, she saw a *bhikkhu* who had no proper robes—his robes had been stolen by thieves, and he was wearing only leaves and branches. Seeing this, she was moved with faith and offered her hard-earned robe to the *bhikkhu*.

With a joyful heart and strong faith, she made the aspiration: “In the future, may I be born with such beauty that whoever sees me will be overwhelmed and lose control of himself. May no woman be more beautiful than I.”

Due to her wholesome offering and aspiration, in her later life she was reborn in a wealthy family as Ummānantī, a woman of extraordinary beauty. Anyone who looked upon

⁹⁰ Khu.Ṭṭha.21.221 (Commentary to Jātaka no. 527: Ummadantī Jātaka).

her would lose composure, driven mad by her loveliness—hence her name, “Ummānantī,” meaning “one who drives others mad.”

At that time, the Bodhisatta was born as a king. Ummānantī’s father offered her in marriage to the king. The king sent ministers to see her. When they met her, her beauty so astonished them that they lost all sense of decorum—some placed rice on their heads instead of eating, some dropped it into their armpits, others threw it against the wall. Seeing this, Ummānantī laughed and dismissed them.

Humiliated, the ministers returned and told the king she was a witch. Thus, the king did not marry her, and she was instead given in marriage to his commander-in-chief.

One day, during a festival in the city, the King was about to lead a grand procession. Before leaving home to take up his duty, the commander-in-chief warned Ummānantī not to show herself to the King. However, resentful that the King had not chosen her as his wife, Ummānantī deliberately positioned herself to attract the King’s attention as the procession passed her house.

The moment the King caught sight of her, he became completely captivated by her beauty. Filled with desire, he immediately wished to marry her. Yet, as he was the Bodhisatta, he understood the Law of Kamma. He first asked whether she was unmarried. When he learned that Ummānantī was already the wife of his commander-in-chief,



he was deeply disappointed. He lost all interest in the procession and returned straight to the palace.

From that moment, the King was no longer his usual self. Intoxicated by Ummānantī's beauty, he lay in bed constantly speaking about her.

Seeing this, the commander-in-chief offered his wife to the King. But the King, being the Bodhisatta, clearly understood kamma and its consequences. He knew the heavy unwholesome results that would come from taking another man's wife, so he refused the offer. In time, he renounced the household life.

This was how Ummānantī's aspiration came to fruition.

The Aspiration of Jotika

Another inspiring example is Jotika⁹¹.

Ninety-one aeons ago, before the time of Buddha Vipassī, there were two brothers who offered sugarcane juice to a group of *Pacceka Buddhas*. After the offering, the elder brother aspired for liberation, while the younger wished to enjoy happiness in the human and deva realms before attaining liberation.

Which aspiration would you prefer? One aspired to attain the highest goal without delay. The other aspired to attain

⁹¹ Khu.Ṭṭha.3.432 Dhammapade (Commentary to Dhammapāda Verse 416 – Jātilatheravatthu & Jotikatheravatthu)

liberation only after first enjoying the sensual pleasures of the human and deva realms.

Because of their wholesome offering, after they passed away, they were reborn in the deva realm, where they enjoyed sensual happiness. When Vipassī Buddha appeared in the human world, they were reborn as humans and received the opportunity to listen to the Buddha's Teaching.

The elder brother, who had aspired only for liberation, wished to ordain immediately after listening to the Dhamma taught by Vipassī Buddha. He ordained and soon attained Arahantship.

The younger brother, however, could not relinquish his attachment to his wealth and sensual pleasures, and therefore was unable to ordain as a bhikkhu. He consulted his elder brother on what he could do. The elder brother advised him to build and offer a perfume chamber to the Buddha.

The younger brother followed this advice and constructed a perfume chamber made of the seven types of precious gems. He allowed anyone who came to pay respect to the Buddha to take some precious gems if they wished, and he would replace them with new ones. In this way, even those who came with the intention of obtaining gems might still have the opportunity to listen to the Buddha's teaching, and some of them might be able to understand and realise the Dhamma.

He also placed a large and extremely valuable precious stone at the Buddha's feet. One day, a brahmin who had no faith in



the Buddha pretended to come to pay respect, intending only to steal that precious stone.

When the younger brother saw the brahmin taking it away, he became very angry. He sought the Buddha's advice, and following the Buddha's suggestion, he made the aspiration: "From this day onward, may it never be possible for kings or thieves, no matter how many of them, to deprive me of my property, not even a single thread of it. May my property never be burned by fire, nor swept away by water."

In this way, the elder brother who aspired for direct liberation attained full liberation in just one life. He realised Nibbāna and the complete cessation of suffering shortly after meeting the Buddha. But the younger brother, who aspired to enjoy sensual pleasures before attaining liberation, continued to wander in saṃsāra among humans and devas for another 91 aeons. Finally, during the time of our Gotama Buddha, he was reborn as Jotika.

Due to his past superior merits, Jotika became extremely wealthy—wealthier even than the King. His seven-storey mansion was entirely made of the seven types of precious gems and was surrounded by wishing trees and treasure chests that would never be depleted no matter how much was taken from them.

When King Ajātasattu killed his father and seized the throne, he grew jealous of Jotika's wealth and wanted to take possession of his mansion. The King led his army towards Jotika's residence. At that time, Jotika was in the monastery

listening to the Buddha's teaching. Because of his past aspiration, *yakkhas* guarded his mansion. When Ajātasattu approached, the guardian *yakkha* chased the King and his army away.

The terrified King fled and eventually took shelter in the monastery, where he saw Jotika listening to the Buddha. Angry and embarrassed, he scolded Jotika: "After ordering your men to fight me, you sit calmly here pretending to listen to the Dhamma?"

Jotika asked, "Your Majesty, were you trying to take over my house?"

The King admitted, "Yes, that was my intention."

Jotika replied, "Your Majesty, even a thousand kings could not take my house from me against my will."

He then stretched out his hands and said, "I have rings on my fingers. Try to remove even one against my wish."

Although King Ajātasattu was very strong, he could not remove a single ring from Jotika's fingers, due to the power of Jotika's past aspiration.

After the King failed, Jotika said, "Now, I shall give them to you." He simply lifted his hand, and all the rings fell off easily.

"As you can see, Your Majesty, it is impossible for you to take my belongings against my will."

These events aroused strong *saṃvega* (sense of urgency) in Jotika. He renounced all his property and ordained as a



bhikkhu. Soon afterward, he attained Arahantship and achieved full liberation. His liberation came 91 aeons later than his elder brother, because he had to endure many lives as a wealthy human or deva.

Understanding the Suffering inherent in Life

Even though there are sensual pleasures in such lives, as long as there is existence, there will be aging, sickness, and death. There will be immeasurable suffering despite all the wealth and pleasure.

During one aeon, if the bones we leave behind were collected and did not disintegrate, they would form a heap as high as the Vepulla Mountain.⁹² In this long wandering through saṃsāra, the tears we have shed due to loved ones passing away exceed the water in the four great oceans.⁹³

⁹² Saṃ.1.392 (SN 15.10 Puggala Sutta):

“Bhikkhus, this saṃsāra is without discoverable beginning. A first point is not discerned of beings roaming and wandering on hindered by ignorance and fettered by craving. One person, roaming and wandering on hindered by ignorance and fettered by craving, would leave behind a stack of bones, a heap of bones, a pile of bones as large as this Mount Vepulla, if there were someone to collect them and what is collected would not perish.

For what reason? Because, bhikkhus, this saṃsāra is without discoverable beginning. A first point is not discerned of beings roaming and wandering on hindered by ignorance and fettered by craving. For such a long time, bhikkhus, you have experienced suffering, anguish, and disaster, and swelled the cemetery. It is enough to experience revulsion towards all formations, enough to become dispassionate towards them, enough to be liberated from them.”

⁹³ Saṃ.1.388 (SN 15.3 Assu Sutta):

So even though Jotika experienced riches and sensual pleasures, throughout those 91 aeons he also suffered greatly. Because of his aspiration to enjoy sensual pleasures before attainment, he had to endure the pains of existence for a long time. One who does wholesome deeds without an aspiration for liberation will receive only worldly happiness as the result. Normally, we only know worldly things; we do not know Nibbāna.

In everyday life, we do not truly understand the nature of suffering. We only know what we experience through seeing, hearing, smelling, tasting, touching, and thinking. When we see someone with good fortune, desire arises to be like that person. When we see a rich person, we wish to be rich. When we see beauty, we desire to be beautiful. When we see someone knowledgeable, we want to be knowledgeable too.

Already in daily life, many worldly desires arise. Because of this, when we do good deeds, even without making any aspiration, we may still gain worldly results according to our desires. If we make aspirations based on worldly wishes, we will receive only worldly results.

If we aspire as Jotika once did—to realise Nibbāna only after enjoying sensual pleasures—we may eventually attain

“For a long time, bhikkhus, you have experienced the death of a mother ... the death of a father ... the death of a brother ... the death of a sister ... the death of a son ... the death of a daughter ... the loss of relatives ... the loss of wealth ... loss through illness; as you have experienced this, weeping and wailing because of being united with the disagreeable and separated from the agreeable, the stream of tears that you have shed is more than the water in the four great oceans. ...”



Nibbāna, but only after a long, turbulent journey through saṃsāra, perhaps as long as 91 aeons or even longer.

On the other hand, if we can aspire for liberation without attachment to worldly existence, attainment can come swiftly.

Making the Right Aspiration

Now, you have accumulated much wholesomeness by observing precepts, giving donations, and practising meditation. Whatever wholesome wishes you aspire for, you have the potential to fulfil them. Wholesomeness is like wealth. It is like the *cintāmaṇi* jewel or the *kappārukkha* tree: whatever you truly wish for can be obtained according to your aspiration.

Everything has been taught in the Buddha's Dispensation. If you aspire to become a Buddha, the Buddha has shown the path to Buddhahood. If you aspire to become a *Pacceka Buddha*, the path to that attainment has also been expounded. If you wish to be a king of devas, the Buddha has explained the causes needed to achieve that status. Whichever destination we choose, the path leading there has been clearly laid out in the Buddha's Teaching. All that we need to know is available right here in the Buddha's Dispensation.

If we have the support of abundant wholesomeness, whatever we aspire for can be fulfilled. If we are lacking in

wholesomeness, even if we make wishes, they cannot bear fruit.

Now, you possess great wholesomeness. What do you wish to aspire for? Your aspirations can be realised. The Buddha encouraged this wholesome direction of the mind with the term *pahitatta*⁹⁴ – directing the mind towards Nibbāna as the final goal, without turning back halfway. So, when you practise meditation, do it with the aim of liberation. When you give donations, do so with the aim of liberation. When you observe *sīla*, observe it with the aim of liberation.

If you have aspired for liberation in the past, when you again encounter the Buddha’s Teaching in a future life, a strong urge to renounce and relinquish worldly attachments will naturally arise.

Some people are able to relinquish easily because they have already made strong aspirations for renunciation in the past. For others who may not have such powerful aspirations, they might only join a short retreat like this one (laugh). Still, the fact that you choose to participate in this temporary renunciation shows that among the many aspirations you have made, one of them is certainly for liberation even though it may not have been strong enough.

If you wish to develop a strong, unwavering desire for liberation, then whenever you perform any wholesome deed,

⁹⁴ “*Pahitatta*” is the combination of “*Pahita*” and “*Atta*”. “*Atta*” refers to the mind, “*Pahita*” means to direct. Therefore, “*Pahitatta*” means directing the mind towards something, towards achievement, towards Nibbāna.



you should make that aspiration for liberation. Even if the wholesome action seems small, you should still wish for liberation. Even when you are not doing any particular wholesome deed, you should still incline your mind towards the aspiration for liberation.

Wholesomeness and Pāramī

There are two conditions for a wholesome action to become *pāramī* (perfection): first, the wholesome deed itself; second, the aspiration for liberation. When these two factors are complete, the *pāramī* is strengthened.

For some people, the conditions in their lives are perfect for renunciation. They have enough wealth; their health is good; they do not lack anything. Yet they still choose to remain in the worldly life. Although they accumulated wholesome deeds in the past, they did not aspire for liberation.

For others, they have a strong desire to practise, but their health is poor, or they lack financial support. This means they may have aspired for liberation, but they did not accumulate enough supporting wholesomeness.

But for the very fortunate ones, both conditions are fulfilled. They have suitable material support, good health, favourable circumstances, and a mind that inclines toward practice. This means they have gathered sufficient *pāramī* for liberation.

Conclusion

This is the power of aspiration. When we understand this clearly, we can make wise decisions regarding our own aspirations. May you skilfully direct your aspirations towards liberation, and may all your wholesome wishes be fulfilled according to your desire.

Sādhū, sādhu, sādhu!



9. The Buddha's Advice for Regular Donors

(Edited from a Dhamma talk given at Dhammavijaya Meditation Centre on 22 March 2018)

Today, I will give a short Dhamma talk based on the *Pīti Sutta*.⁹⁵ There are two discourses with this same name — one in the Aṅguttara Nikāya and another in the Saṃyutta Nikāya.

As the Buddha gave these teachings especially for regular donors, they are very relevant for those who frequently perform acts of *dāna*.

Anāthapiṇḍika and His Friends

Anāthapiṇḍika was the great donor who offered the Jetavana Monastery, where the Buddha often resided.

From time to time, Anāthapiṇḍika and his five hundred friends would visit the Buddha's monastery. They regularly supported the Saṅgha with the four requisites — food, clothing, dwellings, and medicine. After making their offerings, they would return home joyfully.

On one such occasion, the Buddha gave them this advice:

“You should not be satisfied merely with donating material things to the Saṅgha. Instead, you should reflect: ‘How can

⁹⁵ Saṃ.2.198 (SN 28.3 Pīti Sutta) and Aṅ.2.182 (AN 5.176 Pīti Sutta).



we, from time to time, enter and dwell in the *pīti* — the joy or rapture — born of seclusion (*paviveka-pīti*)?”

Because laypeople cannot remain constantly in seclusion, the Buddha said, “from time to time.”

He encouraged them to make the effort to experience *paviveka-pīti* — joy arising from mental solitude and seclusion.

***Paviveka-pīti*: Joy Born of Seclusion**

What does *paviveka-pīti* mean?

In the commentaries, *paviveka-pīti* is explained as the rapture associated with the first and second *jhānas*.

In the first *jhāna*, there are five *jhāna* factors: *vitakka* (initial application), *vicāra* (sustained application), *pīti* (rapture or joy), *sukha* (happiness or bliss), and *ekaggatā* (one-pointedness).

In the second *jhāna*, *vitakka* and *vicāra* cease, leaving *pīti*, *sukha*, and *ekaggatā*.

Because both the first and second *jhānas* contain *pīti*, *paviveka-pīti* refers to the joy arising from these meditative absorptions — joy that is born of seclusion.

Everyone needs to experience true joy and happiness.

When people feel unhappy, they often seek relief through unwholesome ways — by drinking alcohol, taking drugs, or seeking sensual entertainment.

Everyone desires happiness, but it should be pursued in the right way.

Paviveka-pīti is joy born of seclusion — not from seeing beautiful sights, hearing pleasant sounds, or tasting delicious food.

It is joy that arises within, independent of sensual stimulation.

Such happiness, pure and inwardly generated, is called *paviveka-pīti* — rapture and joy born of seclusion.

The Five Freedoms from Suffering and Defilement

When the Buddha had finished giving the teaching to Anāthapiṇḍika and his five hundred friends, the Venerable Sāriputta praised the Buddha, saying:

“Bhante, this is a most wonderful teaching! When a person enters and dwells in *paviveka-pīti*, five kinds of feelings do not occur to him.”

He then enumerated them:⁹⁶

⁹⁶ Añ.2.182 (AN 5.176 Pīti Sutta):

yampissa kāmūpasamhitam dukkham domanassam, tampissa tasmim samaye na hoti. yampissa kāmūpasamhitam sukham somanassam,



1. Pain and grief connected with sensuality do not arise.
2. Pleasure and happiness connected with sensuality do not arise.
3. Pain and grief connected with the unwholesome do not arise.
4. Pleasure and happiness connected with the unwholesome do not arise.
5. Pain and grief connected with the wholesome do not arise.

When someone enters and dwells in the first or second *jhāna*, at that time he experiences happiness — a happiness that is not connected with unwholesomeness.

(3&4) There are, however, other kinds of happiness that *are* rooted in unwholesomeness. For example, some people take delight in fishing for pleasure. When they succeed in catching a fish, they feel happy — but that happiness arises together with unwholesome states.

In contrast, when one experiences *paviveka pīti* — the rapture born of seclusion — there is no pain or grief, no bodily or mental suffering connected with unwholesomeness. Take, for instance, the royals of the past. For sport or pastime, kings and ministers would go into the

tampissa tasmim samaye na hoti. yampissa akusalūpasamhitam dukkham domanassam, tampissa tasmim samaye na hoti. yampissa akusalūpasamhitam sukham somanassam, tampissa tasmim samaye na hoti. yampissa kusalūpasamhitam dukkham domanassam, tampissa tasmim samaye na hoti.

forest to hunt. If they succeeded in shooting a deer, they felt joy; but if they missed their mark, they felt frustration and disappointment. Such pleasure and pain are both tied to unwholesomeness.

But one who experiences *paviveka-pīti* is free from both these states. He neither delights in unwholesome happiness nor suffers from unwholesome disappointment.

(1&2) Likewise, *paviveka-pīti* is also free from sensual happiness. Eating delicious food, using luxurious items, or enjoying pleasant sights and sounds — these are pleasures connected with sensuality.

When one enjoys *paviveka-pīti*, there is joy without dependence on sensual pleasure, and there is no pain or loss associated with sensual craving.

Sometimes people endure great effort or suffering to pursue sensual pleasures, and when they lose them, they feel distress. Such pain is suffering connected with sensuality. In *paviveka-pīti*, none of these arises.

(5) There is also suffering connected with wholesomeness.

For example, when someone wishes to donate but lacks sufficient funds or worthy recipients, he may feel some mental discomfort.

Or when one meditates and experiences physical pain before attaining *jhāna*, that is suffering connected with wholesome effort.

In *paviveka-pīti*, even this kind of suffering does not arise.



Thus, when one abides in the first or second *jhāna*, experiencing *paviveka-pīti*, all five of these conditions — happiness and suffering connected with sensuality (1&2), happiness and suffering connected with unwholesomeness (3&4), and suffering connected with wholesomeness (5) — are absent.

That is why Venerable Sāriputta said, “This is indeed a wonderful teaching.”

The Buddha’s Advice for Donors

In the *Pīti Sutta* of the *Aṅguttara Nikāya*, the Buddha advised regular donors such as Anāthapiṇḍika:

“You should practice by reflecting, ‘How can I, from time to time, enter and dwell in *pīti* born of seclusion?’”

This is the Buddha’s compassionate instruction for lay donors — to cultivate not only generosity, but also the inner joy of meditation.

Sāriputta’s Serene Joy (Saṃyutta Nikāya’s Pīti Sutta)

There is another Pīti Sutta⁹⁷ found in the Saṃyutta Nikāya.

One day, after returning from *piṇḍapāta* (alms-round) and eating, Venerable Sāriputta went to the Andhavana Forest — the “Blind Men’s Forest” — located just behind Jetavana Monastery. Monks often went there in the daytime to practise meditation.

Venerable Sāriputta sat under a tree to meditate for the day.

That evening, after emerging from seclusion, he returned to Jetavana. Venerable Ānanda saw him from a distance and said: “Friend Sāriputta, your faculties are serene, and your complexion is pure and bright. In what dwelling has the Venerable Sāriputta spent the day?”⁹⁸

Venerable Ānanda observed that Venerable Sāriputta’s faculties⁹⁹ — the eyes, voice, and bodily expression — were serene (*vippasanna*), clear, and radiant.

⁹⁷ Saṃ.2.198 (SN 28.3 Pīti Sutta):

In the Sāriputtasamyyutta, there are several closely related suttas (SN 28.1–SN 28.9). They differ only in the level of jhāna attainment given as the explanation for Bhante Sāriputta’s serene faculties and pure, bright facial complexion.

⁹⁸ “*vippasannāni kho te, āvuso sāriputta, indriyāni; parisuddho mukhavaṇṇo pariyodāto. katamenāyasmā sāriputto ajja vihārena vihāsī*”ti?

⁹⁹ Here, “faculties” refers to the six controlling faculties: the eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind. In this context, however, what can be observed are the eyes, voice, and bodily expressions, which reflect the state of these inner faculties.



His facial complexion was entirely pure (*parisuddha*) and bright (*pariyodāta*).

He asked what Venerable Sāriputta had been practising that day.

Venerable Sāriputta replied: “Here, friend, with the fading away of rapture, I dwelt equanimous, mindful, and clearly comprehending. I experienced happiness with the body and entered and dwelt in the third *jhāna*, of which the Noble Ones declare: ‘He is equanimous, mindful, and one who dwells happily.’ Yet, it did not occur to me, ‘I am attaining the third *jhāna*,’ or ‘I have attained it,’ or ‘I have emerged from it.’”¹⁰⁰

The Beauty of Humility and Purity

Here, the phrase “I experience happiness with the body” means that after emerging from the third *jhāna*, the whole body is pervaded, or thoroughly suffused, with happiness. The noble ones announce or declare this kind of happiness, together with the equanimity that arises when one abides happily and mindfully. They describe their direct experience of such happiness as associated with the attainment of the third *jhāna*.

¹⁰⁰ “*idhāhaṃ, āvuso, pītiyā ca virāgā upekkhako ca vihāsiṃ sato ca sampajāno sukhañca kāyena paṭisaṃvedemi; yaṃ taṃ ariyā ācikkhanti ‘upekkhako satimā sukhavihārī’ ti tatiyaṃ jhānaṃ upasampajja viharāmi. tassa mayhaṃ, āvuso, na evaṃ hoti — ‘ahaṃ tatiyaṃ jhānaṃ samāpajjāmi’ ti vā ‘ahaṃ tatiyaṃ jhānaṃ samāpanno’ ti vā ‘ahaṃ tatiyā jhānā vuṭṭhito’ ti vā’ ti.*”

However, Venerable Sāriputta did not think that he was attaining, had attained, or had emerged from dwelling in such *jhānic* happiness. This is because, for a long time, he had thoroughly uprooted the wrong view of “I-making,” the attachment of “mine-making,” and the underlying tendency to conceit — *dīgharattaṃ ahaṅkāra-mamaṅkāra-mānā-nusayā susamūhatā*.

Even though he entered and dwelt in *jhāna*, he did not hold on to the notion, “I have entered *jhāna*,” or “This is my *jhāna*.” He was not occupied with ideas of “I,” “mine,” or “others.” Although the complexion of an arahant becomes radiant after emerging from *jhāna*, he does not think, “I am staying in *jhāna*.”

This is simply the natural way of an arahant's mind — unentangled, and free from craving, wrong view and conceit.

In the Brahmajāla Sutta,¹⁰¹ the Buddha mentioned his omniscient knowledge — *sabbaññutañña*. The Buddha said, “I know others' wrong views.” To know others' views is not easy; to know one's own view is easy. *Diṭṭhi*, or wrong view,

¹⁰¹ Dī.1.16 (DN 1 Brahmajāla Sutta, sassatavādo)

“*tayidaṃ, bhikkhave, tathāgato pajānāti — ‘ime diṭṭhiṭṭhānā evaṃgahitā evaṃparāmaṭṭhā evaṃgatikā bhavanti evaṃabhisamparāyā’ti, tañca tathāgato pajānāti, tato ca uttaritaraṃ pajānāti; tañca pajānanaṃ na parāmasati, aparāmasato cassa paccattaññeva nibbuti veditā.*”

“This, bhikkhus, the Tathāgata understands. And he understands: ‘These standpoints, thus assumed and thus misapprehended, lead to such a future destination, to such a state in the world beyond.’ He understands as well what transcends this, yet even that understanding he does not misapprehend. And because he is free from misapprehension, he has realised within himself the state of perfect peace.”



is of many kinds, and that makes it even more difficult to know. Only *sabbaññutañāṇa*, omniscient knowledge, can truly know such kinds of views.

The Buddha said, “I know the different kinds of wrong views. I know the reasons.” He not only knew *what* those wrong views were, but also *why* beings held on to them. The Buddha knew the reasons behind their views — their causes and their conditions.

Yet, the Buddha also said, “Although I know in this way, I do not adhere to that knowledge with wrong view.” The Buddha does not hold the thought, “I know such things, such wonderful, such amazing things.” He knows — but that knowing is pure. It is mere knowing, free from the taint of pride, free from conceit, free from the wrong view of “I know.”

Because of this, the peacefulness of the Buddha is very apparent. Some people may have knowledge, they may do wonderful things, and because of that, pride arises — “I can do that, I am great.” Their minds are not peaceful, because the conceit of “I am” has entered. They think highly of themselves. That is *māna*, conceit; and there is also *ditṭhi*, wrong view.

But for the noble ones — even when they can do great and wonderful things — they do not cling to them with wrong view or pride. And so, the Buddha said, his peace, his serenity, is clearly seen.

This was also the same for Venerable Sāriputta. He entered and abided in the attainment of *jhāna*, yet he did not have conceit, he did not have pride connected with wrong view. Ordinary people, however, may still have — even if just a little — a trace of tender pride, a subtle sense of “I am.” But noble persons do not have such wrong view or conceit.

Because of this, their facial complexion becomes entirely pure and bright. We can understand this more easily through our everyday expression — when we say, “You look very handsome,” or “You are very beautiful.” Such beauty comes from within; it is the radiance of a peaceful and wholesome heart.

One of my female cousins, whenever she feels sorrowful or worried, will go to a beauty shop to make herself look beautiful. It might be possible that if her sorrow is not so strong, seeing agreeable colours and forms may bring her a little cheer. So she does that, but that is only applying colour, putting artificial things on the face. For someone with true understanding, such beauty is only superficial. It cannot compare to the beauty that shines naturally from a calm, virtuous, and happy mind.

If you truly wish to be beautiful, you should emulate the Venerable Sāriputta.

The Venerable Ānanda once said to him, “Your faculties are serene, very clear and transparent; and your facial complexion is entirely pure and bright. It is good. It is very beautiful.”



Indeed, all truly beautiful things bring joy to those who see them. They naturally uplift the heart, producing delight and peace in the beholder. Beauty can make others happy and content simply through its presence.

But then, I have also seen some married couples—both quite handsome and beautiful—who nevertheless do not even wish to look at each other! What is the problem here? Outwardly, they appear attractive, yet inwardly they cannot bear each other's sight. They even feel aversion toward the very person they once loved. Why is that so? What is the reason? This, we must come to understand.

True Beauty Comes from the Heart

Once, while waiting for my turn for a medical review, I was browsing through some newspaper articles and came across a picture that caught my attention—a hamburger. It looked quite delightful in the photo: a neat stack of bread, crisp vegetables, a juicy layer of meat, a golden egg on top, and finally, another soft bun to crown it all. The arrangement looked almost artistic, very appetising and beautiful.

I turned to my *kappiya* and said, “Oh, this food looks very interesting.”

But my *kappiya* replied, “No, Bhante. It is not good. It is very bad food. Those eggs are not fresh, and the meat may also be highly processed. It's unhealthy.”

Immediately, my mind changed. What had seemed beautiful and attractive a moment ago no longer appeared so. I began to reject it. So then, what *is* beauty?

Many devotees are very eager to take photographs of senior monks. They flock to see these venerable ones and leave happy after catching just a glimpse. The appearance of these monks seems to radiate beauty and peace. Yet, if you look closely, some of these senior monks—well advanced in age—may have no teeth at all! Still, when they smile broadly, revealing only their gums, devotees feel inspired and joyful just by seeing them. Why is that so?

Perhaps true beauty lies not in the surface but in the heart. People sense the inner purity, serenity, and compassion that radiate outward. That is why they find such faces beautiful.

External beauty is only the beginning point. At first glance, we see what seems lovely, but when we look deeper, real beauty reveals itself—it is born of the heart.

If you truly wish to be beautiful, develop *paviveka pīti*—the joy and happiness that arise from seclusion, from the quiet peace of the mind free from defilements. When you cultivate such joy, your beauty shines naturally.

That is the Buddha's advice for regular donors.

May you all be truly beautiful — inwardly and outwardly — through the joy born of seclusion.

Sādhu! Sādhu! Sādhu!



10. The Donation of Great Benefits

(Edited from a Dhamma talk given at Dhammavijaya Meditation Centre on 25 March 2018)

For today's talk, I will choose the Dānamahapphala Sutta from the Aṅguttara Nikāya.¹⁰²

“*Dāna*” means giving or donation, and “*mahapphala*” means great fruit or great benefit.

Thus, this discourse concerns the donation that yields great benefits.

At one time, Venerable Sāriputta, together with a group of lay devotees, approached the Blessed One. With deep respect, they paid homage to the Buddha and began to ask questions.

Venerable Sāriputta asked:

“Could it be the case, Bhante, that a donation offered by someone here is not of great fruit and great benefit? And could it be the case that a donation offered by someone here is of great fruit and great benefit?”

The Buddha replied:

“It could be the case, Sāriputta, that a donation offered by someone here is not of great fruit and great benefit. And it

¹⁰² Aṅ.2.442 (AN 7.52 Dānamahapphala Sutta)



could be the case that a donation offered by someone here is of great fruit and great benefit.”

Then Venerable Sāriputta asked:

“Bhante, why is it that one donation is not of great fruit and great benefit, while another donation is?”

That was the question raised by Venerable Sāriputta — to understand why some donations are not of great fruit and great benefit, and why others are.

The Buddha then replied by explaining the different types of donations.

(1) *Taṇhuttariya-dāna*

The Buddha said:

“Sāriputta, someone in this world offers a donation with craving; offers a donation with an attached mind — a mind attached to the results of the donation; offers a donation with the desire of storing up rewards; offers a donation while thinking, ‘After passing away, I will make use of this in the future life.’

Such a person gives to a recluse or a brahmin — a meal or food (*anna*), drink or juice (*pāna*), clothing (*vattha*), vehicle (*yāna*), flower garland (*mālā*), scent (*gandha*), perfume (*vilepana*), dwelling place or lodging (*seyyāvasatha*), or light (*padīpeyya*).

Sāriputta, what do you think? Would someone in this world offer such a donation?”

“*Evaṃ Bhante,*” replied Venerable Sāriputta — “Yes, Bhante.”

Then the Buddha continued:

“Sāriputta, when someone in this world offers a donation with craving, with an attached mind, with the desire of storing up rewards, and with the thought, ‘After passing away, I will make use of this in the future life’ — such a person, after making that donation, with the breaking up of the body, after passing away, will be reborn in the companionship of the Cātumahārājika devas.

That person, having exhausted that *kamma*, having exhausted that power, fame, followers, and authority, *āgāmi hoti.*”

Āgāmi means “the one who comes.” So, *āgāmi hoti* means “he becomes the one who comes” — that is, he will return and come into this world again; he will be reborn in the human realm.

So this is the **first type of donation**, which is **not of great fruit and great benefit**.

In the commentary, this type of donation is given the name *taṇhuttariyadāna*.

Taṇhā means craving; *uttara* means strong; *iya* means having.



Thus, *taṇhuttariya-dāna* may be translated as “the donation that has strong craving.”

In the sub-commentary¹⁰³, it is explained that this type of donation is called “the donation with strong craving” for two reasons:

1. One donates with the intention and wish to enjoy the results of the donation in a future life.
2. Although the results of the donation have not yet materialised, the donor is already filled with an excessive craving to enjoy the future fruits of his offering. Even at the moment of giving, long before any result can arise, his mind clings tightly to the anticipated rewards. Such longing and craving accompany the act of giving itself.

In these two ways, this type of donation is called “the donation with strong craving.”

If we make the aspiration for the realisation of *Nibbāna* at the time of making a donation, when the worldly results of such a donation arise, sometimes we may still try to enjoy those results. However, as the original aspiration was not for attachment to worldly benefits, such enjoyment may not be considered a very strong craving.

¹⁰³ Aṇ.Ṭīkā.3.175 (Sub-commentary to AN 7.52 Dānamahapphala Sutta):

Imaṃ pecca paribhuñjissāmīti sāpekkhassa dānaṃ paralokaphalāsāya sātisayāya ca pubbācāravasena uppajjamānāya anubhavattā taṇhuttaraṃ nāma hotīti āha “paṭhamam taṇhuttariyadānan’ ti.

On the other hand, if we already have the desire to enjoy the results **at the time** of making donations, then when we actually enjoy the results later, our attachment to that enjoyment will be very strong. Therefore, if we donate with the wish to enjoy the results of the donation, it becomes this first type of donation — the *taṇhuttariya-dāna*, the donation with strong craving.

So, this is the first type of donation that does not yield great fruit or great benefit. Although such giving can support a rebirth in the Cātumahārājika deva realm, once the kamma resulting in the deva birth is exhausted, the donor will eventually return again to the human world.

The Buddha then continued to explain the second type of donation.

(2) *Cittikāra-dāna*

The second type of donation is when someone offers a donation while thinking, “*Sāhu dānaṃ.*”

Sāhu means “good.” So, one makes an offering with the thought that giving is good.

In the commentary, *sāhu* is further defined as *sadhu* and *sundaram* — meaning “well done,” “nice,” or “beautiful.”

Therefore, this kind of donation is named *cittikāra-dāna* — the donation made with respect.



The sub-commentary explains that this kind of respect and esteem arises by reflecting that such a donation is praised by the Buddha, or by the *Paccekabuddhas* and the disciples of the Buddha (*Buddhasāvaka*).¹⁰⁴ Hence, it is called *cittikāra-dāna* — the donation made with respect.

Some may give in this way, called *cittikāra-dāna* — a respectful donation, given with reverence. By thinking that *dāna* is good, praised or recommended by the Buddha, they give respectfully. Such a kind of donation is *cittikāra-dāna* — the donation made with respect.

If the kamma of this act of giving ripens, it may lead to rebirth into a deva realm—the Tāvatiṃsa deva realm.¹⁰⁵ Yet when that kamma is finally exhausted, the resulting celestial power, fame, followers, and authority also come to an end. The donor will then take rebirth once again in a human womb.

¹⁰⁴ *Dānaṃ nāma buddhādīhi pasatthanti garuṃ cittikāraṃ upaṭṭhapetvā dātābattā “dutiyaṃ cittikāradānaṃ” ’ti vuttaṃ.*

¹⁰⁵ In the Pāli text, among the seven types of giving mentioned in this sutta, only the first and the last are presented in full. The remaining five are given in an abbreviated form (*peyyāla*).

The first type of giving is shown to result in a rebirth in the first celestial realm — the *Cātummahārājika* deva realm. The last, which is the seventh, leads to rebirth in the Brahma realms.

From this structure, we can infer that the second to the sixth types of giving correspond to rebirth in the second to the sixth deva realms in the following order: Tāvatiṃsa, Yāma, Tusita, Nimmānarati, and Paranimmitavasavatti. This interpretation is also supported by the explanations found in the Myanmar Nissaya.

Therefore, although this type of donation does bring some benefit, it is **not considered a gift of great fruit and great benefit.**

(3) *Hirottappa-dāna*

The Buddha then explained the next type of donation.

Someone offers a donation by thinking, “My father and grandfather had donated before. This has been done by my father and grandfather in the past. It would not be worthy of me to reduce or neglect this ancient family tradition.”

In the commentary, this type of donation is given the name *hirottappa-dāna*. *Hiri* means moral shame, and *ottappa* means moral fear; *dāna* means donation. So, *hirottappa-dāna* means a donation made out of moral shame and moral fear.

One reflects: “My father, forefathers, grandmother, grandfather, great-grandmother, or great-grandfather had donated in the past. This has been a family custom since ancient times. If I do not donate now in my time, it would not be proper — it would be shameful and blameworthy.”

Hence, out of moral shame and fear, one continues to donate so as not to abandon this ancient family custom. The sub-commentary explains,¹⁰⁶ ‘It is not proper to abandon what

¹⁰⁶ *Pubbakehi pitupitāmahehi dinnapubbaṃ katapubbaṃ jahāpetuṃ nāma nānucchavikanti attabhāvasabhāgavasena hirottappaṃ paccupaṭṭhapetvā dātabbato “tatiyaṃ hirottappadānaṃ” ’ti vuttaṃ.*



was given before, what was done before by former ancestors, by grandfather and great-grandfather'—because it should be given having established a sense of moral shame and moral fear in accordance with one's natural disposition', such a kind of donation is called *hirottappa-dāna* (the gift of moral shame and moral dread).

If the kamma of this act of giving ripens, it may result in rebirth in the *Yāma* deva realm. However, when that kamma is exhausted, the accompanying celestial power, fame, followers, and authority also fade away. After that, the donor will again take rebirth in the human world.

Therefore, although this type of donation does bring benefit, it is **not regarded as a gift of great fruit and great benefit.**

(4) *Niravasesa-dāna*

Another type of donation occurs when someone offers a donation by thinking, “I cook; these people do not cook. It is not proper for those who cook not to offer to those who do not cook.”

In the commentary, this type of donation is given the name *niravasesa-dāna* — the donation without remainder.

The sub-commentary explains that someone who donates with such a perception will donate “without remainder.”¹⁰⁷ I

¹⁰⁷ “*Ahaṃ pacāmi, na ime pacanti, nārahāmi pacanto apacantānaṃ dānaṃ adātun'ti evaṃsaññī hutvā dento niravasesaṃ katvā detīti āha “catutthaṃ niravasesadānan' 'ti.*”

think this means that the person with such a perception will continue to give repeatedly and for a long time. Hence, it is called a donation without remainder — *niravasesa-dāna*.

The ripening of the kamma of this act of giving may lead to rebirth in the Tusita deva realm. Yet, when that kamma is exhausted, and its accompanying celestial power, fame, followers, and authority fade away, the donor will once again return to the human world.

Therefore, although this type of donation does bring some benefit, it is still **not considered a gift of great fruit and great benefit.**

(5) *Dakkhiṇeyya-dāna*

The Buddha continued to explain the next type of donation:

Someone offers a donation by thinking, “Just as those great offerings or great donations (*mahāyañña*) were made by the sages of old — namely Aṭṭhaka, Vāmaka, Vāmadeva, Vessāmitta, Yamadaggi, Aṅgirasa, Bhāradvāja, Vāseṭṭha, Kassapa, and Bhagu — in the same way I shall offer my donation accordingly.”

The commentary defines *mahāyañña* as *mahādāna* — a great *pūjā* or great offering. It refers to offerings complete with *sappi* (clarified butter), *navanīta* (fresh butter), *dadhi* (curds or ghee), *madhu* (honey), *phāṇita* (jaggery or molasses), and so on.



The commentary also refers to this type of donation as *dakkhiṇeyya-dāna* — a gift offered to those who are truly worthy of receiving it. In this context, an arahant, one who has destroyed all taints and completely eradicated defilements, is regarded as the supreme *dakkhiṇeyya*, the one most worthy of offerings.

In the sub-commentary ¹⁰⁸, *dakkhiṇeyya-dāna* is further clarified. It explains that one reflects: “Just as those great offerings made by the sages of the past bore abundant fruit, so too will this offering of mine become fruitful.” With this perception established in the mind, one gives gifts and offerings to recipients who are truly deserving—those endowed with pure morality and who have completely destroyed defilements. Because such gifts are offered to the highest field of merit, the arahants, this type of donation is called *dakkhiṇeyya-dāna*, the offering to the worthy ones.

The ripening of the kamma of this act of giving may lead to rebirth in the Nimmānarati deva realm. However, when that kamma is exhausted, the resulting celestial splendour, power, fame, and followers also fade away, and the donor will once again take rebirth in the human world.

Therefore, although this type of donation does bring benefit, it is still **not regarded as a gift of great fruit and great benefit.**

¹⁰⁸ “Yathā tesam pubbakānaṃ isīnaṃ tāni mahāyaññakāni ahesuṃ, evaṃ me ayaṃ dānaparibhogo bhavissatī’ti evaṃsaññīno dānaṃ dakkhiṇāṃ arahesu dātābato “**pañcamam dakkhiṇeyyadānan**’’ti vuttaṃ.

(6) *Somanassupavicāra-dāna*

The next type of donation is when one offers a donation while thinking, “This donation of mine clears my mind and causes pleasure (*attamanatā*) and happiness (*somanassa*) to arise.”

In the commentary, this type of donation is called *somanassupavicāra-dāna*. *Somanassa* means happiness, and *upavicāra* means applying one’s mind to.

In the sub-commentary, *upavicāra* is explained as *upacāra* — meaning approaching, being near to, or in the neighbourhood of.

The sub-commentary¹⁰⁹ further explains that this type of donation, which clears the mind, gives rise to joy and happiness (*pīti-somanassa*). It brings about the attainment of abundant happiness and is close to, or in the vicinity of, happiness (*somanassupacāraṃ*).

Hence, it is called *somanassupavicāradāna* — the donation with the mind applied to happiness; the donation that produces much happiness.

This type of donation can also produce benefits, such as rebirth in the heavenly realms. One can enjoy the fruits of

¹⁰⁹ “*Imaṃ me dānaṃ dadato cittaṃ pasīdatī’tiādinā pītisomanassaṃ uppādetvā dentassa dānaṃ somanassabāhullappattiyā somanassupacāraṃ nāma hotīti āha “chaṭṭhaṃ somanassupavicāradānan’*’ti vuttaṃ.



such giving, but after the power of that *kamma* is exhausted, one must return again to human life.

The ripening of the *kamma* of this act of giving may lead to rebirth in the Paranimittavasavatti deva realm. However, when that *kamma* is exhausted, the resulting celestial splendour, power, fame, and followers also vanish, and the donor will once again be reborn in a human womb.

Therefore, although this type of donation does bring benefit, it is still **not regarded as a gift of great fruit and great benefit.**

(7) *Alañkāra-parivāra-dāna*

Finally, the Buddha explained the donation which is of great fruit and benefit.

“Someone does not offer a donation in any of the previous ways. Instead, one offers a donation which is *cittālaṅkāra-citta-parikkhāra* — a donation that is a decoration or ornament of the mind, and a donation that is an accessory or requisite of the mind. In such a way, one donates to a *samaṇa* (recluse) or a *brāhmaṇa* (brahmin): a meal or food (*anna*), drink or juice (*pāna*), clothing (*vattha*), vehicle (*yāna*), flower garland (*mālā*), scent (*gandha*), perfume (*vilepana*), dwelling place or lodging (*seyyāvasatha*), and light (*padīpeyya*). What do you think, Sāriputta — is there such a donation in the world?”

“*Evaṃ Bhante*” — “Yes, Bhante,” replied Venerable Sāriputta.

“In this case, Sāriputta, one does not offer a donation with craving, nor with an attached mind — a mind attached to the results of the donation.

One does not offer a donation with the desire of storing up rewards, nor with the thought, ‘After passing away, I will make use of this in the future life.’

One does not offer a donation thinking, ‘Donation is good.’

One does not offer a donation by thinking, ‘It is not proper for me to reduce or neglect the ancient family custom of donation which has been done by my father and forefathers in the past.’

One does not offer a donation by thinking, ‘I cook, these people do not cook; it is not proper for those who cook not to offer to those who do not cook.’

One does not offer a donation by thinking, ‘Just as those great offerings (*mahāyañña*) were made by the sages of old — Aṭṭhaka, Vāmaka, Vāmadeva, Vessāmitta, Yamadaggi, Aṅgīrasa, Bhāradvāja, Vāseṭṭha, Kassapa, and Bhagu — in the same way, I shall share my donation accordingly.’

Nor does one offer a donation by thinking, ‘This donation of mine clears my mind and causes pleasure (*attamanatā*) and happiness (*somanassa*) to arise.’

Instead, one offers a donation which is *cittālaṅkāra* — a decoration or ornament of the mind, and *citta-parikkhāra* — an accessory or requisite of the mind.”



“Having offered such a donation, with the breakup of the body, after passing away, that person is reborn in the company of the brahmakāyika devas —reborn among the Brahmās. Having exhausted that *kamma*, that power (*iddhi*), that fame (*yasa*), that authority (*ādhīpacca*), he becomes a non-returner (*anāgāmi hoti*) and does not return to this state of being (*anāgantā itthattaṃ*).”

The Buddha concluded:

“Sāriputta, this is the reason, this is the cause, why a donation by someone in this world is not of great fruit (*mahapphala*) and great benefit (*mahānisaṃsa*). Sāriputta, this is the reason, this is the cause, why a donation by someone in this world is of great fruit and great benefit.”

Commentarial Explanation

In the commentary, *cittālaṅkāra-citta-parikkhāra* is defined as follows:

*Cittālaṅkāra-cittaparikkhāranti samatha-vipassanā-cittassa alaṅkāra-bhūtañceva parivāra-bhūtañca.*¹¹⁰

Here, *alaṅkāra-bhūtañceva* means that which is a decoration or ornament (*alaṅkāra*), and *parivāra-bhūtañca* — here replacing *parikkhāra* with *parivāra* — means that which serves as an accessory or accompanying article. In this context, both terms carry the same meaning.

¹¹⁰ Aṇ.3.168 (Commentary to AN 7.52 Dānamahapphala Sutta)

As for *citta*, it refers to the *samatha-vipassanā-citta* — the mind of tranquillity and insight, the mind of concentration and wisdom.

So, the commentary defines *cittālaṅkāra-cittaparikkhāra* as **the donation that decorates and accompanies the minds of *samatha* and *vipassanā***. In the commentary, this type of *dāna* is given the name *alaṅkāra-parivāra-dāna*.

In the sub-commentary,¹¹¹ it is further explained how such a donation becomes the decoration and accessory of the *bhāvanā* (*samatha* and *vipassanā* meditation) mind.

By reflecting on such giving, *pāmojja* (tender joy), *pīti* (rapture), and *somanassa* (happiness) arise.

At the same time, *lobha* (greed), *dosa* (anger), *issa* (jealousy), *macchariya* (stinginess), and other defilements are kept far away.

In this way, the proper *dharmas* conducive to mental cultivation are increased (*anukūla-dhamma-paribrūhaṇa*), and the opposing *dharmas* which obstruct mental cultivation are kept at a distance (*paccanīka-dhamma-vidūrīkaraṇa*).

¹¹¹ *Dānañhi datvā taṃ paccavekkhantassa pāmojjapītisomanassādayo uppajjanti, lobhadosaissāmaccherādayo vidūrībhavanti. Idāni dānaṃ anukūladhammaparibrūhanena paccanīkadhammavidūrīkaraṇena ca bhāvanācittassa upasobhanāya ca parikkhārāya ca hotīti “alaṅkārabhūtañceva parivārabhūtañca deti” ’ti vuttaṃ.*



These are the two reasons why a donation can become the near-beauty (*upasobhana*) and the accessory (*parikkhāra*) of the *bhāvanācitta* — the mind of cultivation.

How the Donation Supports Meditation

The commentary¹¹² also explains that it is not possible to be reborn in the companionship of Brahmās merely through donation alone. Donation by itself cannot be the cause for rebirth in the Brahmā realms.

However, with the support of the donation mind — which decorates and assists the *samatha* and *vipassanā* mind — it becomes easier for *jhāna* (absorption concentration) to arise and for insight knowledge (*vipassanā-ñāṇa*) to mature. Therefore, one may attain *jhāna* and realise the Noble Path (*Ariya Magga*).

With this *jhāna* attainment, one may be reborn in the Brahmā realm upon the breakup of the body and may also become a noble person.

Both the commentary and sub-commentary explain that the great fruit and benefit of such a donation is to become a **non-returner (*anāgāmi*)**, one who does not return to this state of being (*anāgantā itthattaṃ*).

¹¹² *brahmakāyikānaṃ devānaṃ saḥabyatanti* na sakkā tattha dānena upapajjitum. yasmā pana taṃ samathavipassanācittassa alaṅkārabhūtaṃ, tasmā tena dānālaṅkatena cittena jhānañceva ariyamaggañca nibbattetvā jhānena tattha upapajjati.

Becoming a Non-Returner

Becoming an *anāgāmi* means becoming a “*jhāna* non-returner” (*jhānānāgāmī hoti*).

This refers to a noble one whose rebirth in the Brahmā world is produced by *jhāna*. Such beings will not be reborn in the lower or sensual realms again.

If a noble person with *jhāna* is reborn in the Brahmā realm, they will never return to the sensual world. Without coming back to this sensual sphere, they will either arise in higher and higher realms or attain *Parinibbāna* in that same realm, without ever returning to this world.

That is why this last type of donation is called **the donation of great fruit and great benefit**.

It is the most important and the most beneficial form of donation.

Further Explanation

This last donation is called *cittālaṅkāra-citta-parikkhāra-dāna* — the donation that is the decoration or ornament of the mind, and the accessory or requisite of the mind.

Here, which mind is being referred to? It refers to the *samatha* mind and the *vipassanā* mind — the concentration mind and the insight mind.

In order to adorn the *samatha* and *vipassanā* minds with ornaments, one gives donations. Or, one donates to equip



the *samatha* and *vipassanā* minds with all the necessary requisites. This donation is the most beneficial form of *dāna*.

How It Beautifies the Mind

How does a donation decorate the *samatha* and *vipassanā* minds with ornaments, or become the requisite and accessory of those minds?

When someone donates, that act of giving can increase suitable *dharmas* that lead to attainment, concentration, and wisdom. Such a donation can strengthen wholesome mental qualities conducive to concentration and insight.

For example, if you donate before meditating, you may reflect on your act of generosity, thinking, “I have done this wholesome deed.”

This reflection makes the mind happy. That happiness is conducive to the arising of concentration and wisdom.

If someone is unhappy, their mind will not be ready to welcome concentration — concentration cannot arise in an unhappy mind. Because of this, when making donations, you should reflect on your generosity and let your mind become happy. After that, you may practise meditation with that happy mind.

Such a donation can increase *anukūla dharmas* — the proper and supportive *dharmas* — that help concentration and wisdom to arise.

Another aspect of such a donation is that it suppresses the *dhammas* opposite to concentration and wisdom. When you give, it reduces craving and ignorance.

Because of this, through donation, you can suppress the defilements that are contrary to concentration and wisdom. By suppressing the unwholesome *dhammas* that oppose concentration and wisdom, you can develop your meditation successfully.

By increasing the supportive *dhammas* and suppressing the opposing ones, donation can beautify the *bhāvanā citta* — the mind engaged in meditation. The donation thus becomes a requisite or accessory of the *bhāvanā* mind.

Because of this, the donation is called *cittālaṅkāra* — the decoration or ornament of the *samatha* and *vipassanā* minds — and *cittaparikkhāra* — the requisite or supporting condition of the *samatha* and *vipassanā* minds.

The Highest Benefit

This donation is the best. Based on such donation, if you practise *samatha*, you will gain concentration.

Based on such a donation, if you practise *vipassanā*, you will gain attainment — *magga* and *phala*.

For such donors, where do they go? If they are *anāgāmis* (non-returners), they will go to the Brahmā realms. As *anāgāmis*, they will live in the Brahmā world, and after that,



they will never return to human life. From the Brahmā realm, they will eventually pass into final *Parinibbāna*.

Therefore, this produces very great fruit and very great benefit.

Conclusion

In this *sutta*, only the *anāgāmi* stage is mentioned.

Just as in the *Karaṇīya Mettā Sutta*, it says similarly:

“*Na hi jātu gabbhaseyya puna reti*” — “Not coming back to the human world again.”

This means that from human or deva life, one can attain up to the *anāgāmi* stage — the non-returner who never comes back to the sensual realms again. So such a donation is indeed most beneficial.

Therefore, your donation should be made with the intention of developing great concentration and *vipassanā*.

Your donation should become the requisite and support for the concentrative and insight minds. Only then can your donation be called *mahapphaladāna* — the donation of great benefit.

May you all be able to gain great benefits through your donations.

Sādhū! Sādhū! Sādhū!

Special Teaching

Opening the Hand, Opening the Heart: The Bodhisatta's Reflections on the Perfection of Generosity

(Extracted and edited from online Dhamma talks on Dāna Pāramī given during Covid-19 period in October 2021 based on "The Chronicle of Buddhas" by Mingun Sayadaw)

Introduction: Why Reflection Is Needed for Dāna

Sometimes we want to give, but we cannot give.

Sometimes we want to meditate, but we cannot meditate.

Although the wish is there, at that moment we are unable to act. Why does this happen? Because the mind is not yet strong enough.

The Bodhisatta, on his long path to Buddhahood, worked hard to perfect generosity (*dāna pāramī*). To strengthen his mind and overcome any hesitation, he used many wise reflections.

By reflecting again and again, he trained his mind to become brave in giving. These reflections help to increase the wish to donate and remove hesitation.



Mingun Sayadawgyi explained these reflections in detail, and today we will learn how the Bodhisatta reflected so that we too may follow his example and practise *dāna* more readily, freely and joyfully.

Part One: Reflections on Possessions to be Donated

The Bodhisatta reflected on the nature of possessions in various ways to strengthen his resolve to give. These reflections reveal both the dangers of attachment to property and the benefits of generosity.

1. Possessions Are Desired by Others and Therefore Dangerous

The Bodhisatta reflected:

“Property is desired by many people. Others long for it and wish to obtain it.”

When we possess valuable things—gold, jewellery, money—other people may desire them. Because of this, danger can arise. For example, if someone wears gold or diamonds openly, especially in unsafe places, robbers may attack. Possessions that are desired by others can bring fear and insecurity. The more valuable our possessions, the more they may put us at risk.

The Buddha compared sensual pleasures to **a piece of meat (*maṃsa-pesūpamā kāmā*)**¹¹³. When one crow holds the meat, other crows attack it to get the meat. Only when the crow releases the meat does it become free from danger. In the same way, when we hold on to possessions, we must constantly protect them, and our mind is never truly free. Reflecting in this way, the Bodhisatta became willing to let go and to donate.

When we reflect on this danger, we may find the courage to donate.

2. Possessions vs. True Wealth

Having property creates problems. Letting go of property might seem like a loss, but it is actually a beneficial loss. When we give with a good mind, we create happiness that will last through many lifetimes. No one can steal this merit. No one can rob it. Giving is like putting our wealth in the safest bank possible.

For bhikkhus, this reflection is especially important. Since monks cannot hold money, they must keep it with others. It is better to give it away than to worry about its safety.

¹¹³ Ma.2.28 (MN 54 Potaliya Sutta)



3. The Five Enemies of Property

The Bodhisatta reflected: "My possessions are connected to five enemies."

These five enemies are:

1. Government (which may tax or confiscate)
2. Fire (which can destroy)
3. Water (which can flood and ruin)
4. Thieves (who may steal)
5. Bad heirs (children or inheritors who may waste it)

When we own property, it is not truly "ours" because it remains vulnerable to these five enemies. At any time, it can be taken away, destroyed, or wasted. We may lose the property without any benefit to our mind.

But when we donate, the property becomes truly ours. In Buddhism, we say something becomes our own property only when we give it away. Why? Because once donated, it is connected only to us through the merit we've created. It follows us through saṃsāra as accumulated wholesome kamma. It can no longer be taken away by the five enemies.

If we reflect in this way, we will find courage to give.

4. Possessions Are a Cause of Quarrels and Conflict

The Bodhisatta reflected: "Possessions are a cause of arguments and disputes."

Some people say, "Before I had money, everyone loved me. After I became wealthy, problems began."

Even for bhikkhus, when we have nothing, everyone approaches us with pure faith, and relationships are simple and peaceful. But when we receive many offerings, we may start to wonder: "Why is this person approaching me? What do they want?" When there are many gains, suspicion and conflict may arise.

The Bodhisatta reflected: "Which is better: keeping possessions or relinquishing them?"

By giving up possessions, quarrels disappear. Peace increases.

5. Property Has No Real Essence

The Bodhisatta reflected: "Property has no lasting value, no real essence."

"Essence" here means something valuable and lasting, like the hardwood at the centre of a tree. Hardwood is useful for making furniture that lasts a long time. But property? When we grow old or sick, it becomes useless. When we die, it cannot help us at all.



Many people discovered this clearly during times of illness, such as during COVID-19. Even with much money, medicine and protection were not always available.

But when we donate our property, it gains true essence. It becomes truly useful and valuable through the merit we create. Through dāna, possessions become meaningful and beneficial beyond this life.

6. Protecting Property Leads to Harming Others

To protect our possessions, we sometimes need to scold, harm or mistreat others. This is not good. Without possessions, we do not need to speak harshly or hurt anyone.

There is a humorous story about this. In a monastery with many bhikkhus, if you want to know who the abbot is, drop a plate and let it break. The first person who shouts is the abbot! (laughter)

Why? Because the abbot thinks, "This is my property!" His mind is so attached that he cannot be patient when something breaks. He becomes disturbed and may even scold others.

Other bhikkhus think, "Oh, sometimes plates break. It's normal." They can understand and remain calm.

This shows how protecting property can lead us to harm others with our words and actions.

When the mind clings to ownership, patience disappears.
Anger arises easily.

The Bodhisatta reflected: "If I give away possessions, I will not need to harm or scold anyone to protect them."

7. Loss of Possessions Brings Sorrow and Grief

When possessions are lost, people suffer deeply. Some worry constantly; some even become mentally disturbed.

Reflecting on this, the Bodhisatta understood: "Relinquishing is better than losing."

Giving up wealth willingly brings joy, not grief.

8. Possessions Give Rise to Stinginess and Woeful Rebirth

The Bodhisatta reflected: "When I have property, I may develop stinginess (*macchhariya*). This stinginess can lead to rebirth in the lower realms."

There is a story about a bhikkhu who had old, worn robes. His sister offered him new robes, but he fell ill before he could wear them. When he died, his attachment to those new robes was so strong that he was reborn as a louse living in the cloth!

We might think new clothing brings happiness, but if we become attached, this very attachment can cause our



downfall. Attachment to property can lead to rebirth in woeful states.

However, when we donate with a wholesome mind, this good mental state protects us throughout the long cycle of rebirth (saṃsāra).

Therefore, the Bodhisatta reflected: “Giving protects me throughout long saṃsāra.”

Summary of Property Reflections

By reflecting on the faults of property and the benefits of donation, we can develop the courage and willingness to give. These reflections help transform our attitude toward our possessions.

In many ways, possessions bring harm rather than true happiness. The only escape is to give them away generously. When we do this, we turn something harmful into lasting merit that brings safety and joy through many lives.

Part Two: Reflections Related to the Receiver of Dāna

Even when we know the benefits of giving, sometimes we hesitate because of the receiver. Therefore, the Bodhisatta also reflected deeply on the nature of the receiver.

1. The Receiver is a Trusted Friend

When someone asked the Bodhisatta for something, he reflected: "It is a shameful and difficult thing to ask someone for help. This person must trust me deeply to approach me."

If someone is not friendly with you, they will not ask you for anything. The very fact that they ask shows their trust and confidence in your friendship.

Thus, a receiver is seen as a friend, not a burden.

2. The Receiver is a Guide to Future Wealth

The Bodhisatta thought: "This person is showing me how to take my property to the next life. He is guiding me to carry my wealth across the long journey of saṃsāra."

When we die, we must leave everything behind. But if someone comes to receive our donation, we can actually bring our wealth forward into future lives—transformed into merit. The recipient is like a guide showing us this path.



3. The Receiver Saves Our Property from a Burning House

The Bodhisatta reflected: "This person is like a good friend who helps me remove my valuables from a house that is burning down."

When a house catches fire, we need to quickly carry out our valuable possessions before they burn. Someone who helps us do this is a true friend.

Our life is like that burning house. We are constantly being burned by eleven kinds of fire¹¹⁴:

- Fire of lust
- Fire of hatred
- Fire of delusion
- Fire of aging
- Fire of sickness
- Fire of death
- Fire of sorrow
- Fire of lamentation
- Fire of bodily suffering
- Fire of mental suffering
- Fire of grief

¹¹⁴ Saṃ.2.251 (SN 35.28 Āditta Sutta):

kena ādittaṃ? 'rāgagginā, dosagginā, mohagginā ādittaṃ, jātiyā jarāya maraṇena sokehi paridevehi dukkhehi domanassehi upāyāsehi ādittan'ti vadāmi

Every day we grow older—this is a kind of burning. We experience sadness, crying, sickness, and ageing. When death comes, we will lose everything.

But when a recipient comes to us, we can save our property from these fires by transforming it into merit through donation. The recipient is a friend rescuing our wealth from destruction.

4. The Receiver is a Safe Storehouse

The Bodhisatta saw recipients as a secure place to store his possessions, safe from the fires of life.

This is the best storage place for our wealth—far safer than any worldly bank or vault.

5. Without Receivers, Dāna Pāramī Cannot Be Fulfilled

To become a Buddha, one must practice generosity. Donation creates the merit necessary for Buddhahood. Without receivers, one cannot practice giving and therefore cannot fulfil *dāna pāramī*.

Therefore, the receiver is a great friend in fulfilling one's aspiration for Buddhahood.



6. The Recipient Praises Noble Merit

The Bodhisatta reflected: "This person is praising superior merit. I should definitely practice this kind of merit."

When a recipient comes and speaks about the benefits of giving—the happiness of devas and other good results—they are praising noble merit. We should think: "I must definitely practice this kind of merit. Even if they don't ask directly, I should give. If they do ask, then without question, I must give!"

Bodhisattas who have a strong desire to give actually search for recipients. Sometimes they cannot easily find people to receive their donations, so they must actively seek them out.

If we reflect this way, when recipients come to us, we will be able to give more generously.

Using Reflection to Change Our Attitude

The Buddha taught reflection as a method to transform our minds. We all have weaknesses. Through reflection, we can gradually change our attitudes and correct our thinking.

Most people, when they see someone asking for help, might think: "His hands and legs work fine. Why doesn't he get a job instead of asking?" Some people judge receivers this way.

The Bodhisatta's thinking was completely different. He even had to search for receivers! He thought: "Because of my good

merit, receivers are available to me. I don't even need to search. How lucky I am! I should definitely give."

Supporting Yourself by Supporting Others

When we give to recipients, we are actually supporting ourselves. Donation benefits both the giver and the receiver.

7. Without Receivers, No Perfection of Generosity

The Bodhisatta reflected: "Without recipients, how can I fulfil *dāna pāramī*?"

Having receivers is good fortune. In the deva realms, for example, beings have everything they need, so there is no opportunity to give. When many receivers are available, this is excellent for those wishing to fulfil the perfection of generosity.

8. Keeping Property for Receivers

The Bodhisatta thought: "I am keeping my property only for receivers."

Some people continue to work even when they need nothing. Why? For the sake of giving.

For example, some senior monks have many donors waiting to offer them everything they need. Personally, these monks need nothing more. But they continue to accept offerings—



for the sake of the donors, so that the donors can practice generosity and create merit.

In the same way, if we accumulate property with the intention of donating it, this is good. It helps us fulfil *dāna pāramī*.

The Bodhisatta reflected: "I keep possessions only for those who may ask."

9. Wishing Receivers Would Take Freely

The Bodhisatta even reflected: "When will receivers take my property without asking?"

He wanted receivers to feel so comfortable and friendly that they would simply help themselves!

There is a story from the time of Kassapa Buddha¹¹⁵. A potter named Ghatikāra was an *Anāgāmi*. When the Buddha needed thatched roofs to repair his leaking hut, some bhikkhus went to get them from Ghatikāra's house. But Ghatikāra was not home at the time.

The bhikkhus took the roofs without asking. When Ghatikāra returned home and discovered this, he was extremely happy! He was so pleased that the Buddha and bhikkhus felt close enough to him and had enough trust in him to take what they needed without asking.

¹¹⁵ Ma.2.243 (MN 81 Ghatikāra Sutta)

Because of the Buddha's qualities and Ghatikāra's joyful mind, that place never got rain even though it had no roof—a blessing that lasted throughout this aeon.

10. How Can I Love Receivers?

The Bodhisatta reflected: "In what way can I love receivers? How can receivers become dear to me?"

He was always seeking ways to develop loving feelings toward those who came to him.

11. Finding Joy in Giving

The Bodhisatta thought: "How can I be happy while donating and after donating?"

We should experience joy both during the act of giving and afterwards. The Bodhisatta constantly tried to develop this quality.

12. Attracting Receivers and the Desire to Give

The Bodhisatta reflected: "How can receivers come to me? How can the desire to give arise in me?"

If we have the desire to donate, this is excellent. If receivers come to us, this is also excellent. The Bodhisatta actively wished for both.



13. Understanding Without Words

The Bodhisatta thought: "How can I know what receivers need without them having to ask?"

Only people with a very strong desire to give develop this sensitivity. They constantly observe what receivers might need.

Such a person is called *vadaññū*—one who knows without being told. *Vada* means "saying" and *ññu* means "knower." A *vadaññu* person observes the receivers' actions, conditions, and situation, and understands their needs without verbal communication.

The Bodhisatta aspired to become this kind of person.

14. Not Giving Would Be Deceptive

The Bodhisatta reflected: "I have property, and I have receivers. If I do not donate, this would be a kind of deception, a kind of trickery on my part."

When we have both the means to give and people to receive, not giving is almost like cheating.

15. Willing to Give Life and Limb

The Bodhisatta even thought: "How can I donate my life and my body parts to receivers?"

His mind was always inclined this way, always striving to develop this level of generosity.

These are the reflections of the Bodhisatta concerning receivers.

Part Three: Giving Without Longing for Results

After reflecting on receivers, the Bodhisatta also developed the right attitude about the results of giving.

He trained his mind not to long for worldly results—not for human pleasures or heavenly enjoyments or deva sensual pleasures. However, aspiring to become a Buddha is acceptable, because the purpose of Buddhahood is not personal enjoyment but helping all beings.

The Mosquito Analogy

We may reflect using this comparison:

"Imagine an insect lands on you. You brush it away without any desire for it to return. You have no wish to see that insect again. But often—like a mosquito—it comes back anyway!"
(laughter)



"In the same way, when I give donations, I should not desire the results to come back to me. But just as the mosquito returns even though you don't want it, the results of good deeds will come back to you anyway."

When we give up property through donation, we should have a mind like someone brushing away a mosquito—no attachment, no expectation. Yet the results will naturally return to us, just as the mosquito returns.

Part Four: Right Attitude When Giving

The Bodhisatta also reflected on how to maintain the proper mental attitude toward different types of receivers.

When the Receiver is Dear to You

If someone you love asks for something, you should be glad and think:

"Someone dear to me is asking. How wonderful!"

When the Receiver is Neutral

If the recipient is someone neutral—neither loved nor disliked—you should be glad by thinking:

"By giving to this person, he will become my friend."

When the Recipient is Your Enemy

If your enemy asks for something, you should be especially happy and think:

"By giving this property, my enemy will become my friend."

An Example of This Practice

Most people, when they find enemies, want to oppose them or fight against them. This is normal. But there is another way: try to help them with a good mind. This approach works with most enemies.

However, if an enemy is very foolish or stubborn, they may not change. But most people, if you treat them well, will eventually change their attitude.

My teacher told this story: In one place, there were many bhikkhus, each with his own monastery. One bhikkhu kept throwing rubbish in front of his neighbour's building.

Instead of complaining or retaliating, the neighbour bhikkhu had a different strategy. Whenever he held a ceremony, he always invited the bhikkhu who was throwing rubbish near his dwelling. He invited him again and again to every ceremony.

Eventually, that bhikkhu stopped throwing rubbish in front of his neighbour's dwelling. Sometimes, instead of creating opposition, trying a different approach works better.



This Approach Works with Monastics

Most bhikkhus are good people who have studied the Buddha's teachings. They are not really foolish. Sometimes, because of past enmity or anger, they may do something wrong. But if you respond correctly and kindly, their minds can change.

This is especially true in monastic communities. Most people in Dhamma communities are not truly bad. If they make mistakes, and you respond in a good way—thinking like the Bodhisatta—they will likely change.

So when an enemy asks for something, think: "By giving this, he will become friendly." Give with this thought, and be glad.

Part Five: Overcoming Greed and Attachment

When Stinginess Arises

When the Bodhisatta experienced greed or stinginess and felt unable to give, he reflected firmly with himself:

"You are trying to become a Buddha. You have made a wish to attain Buddhahood. Those who seek Buddhahood must be willing to give up even their body, even their life, to acquire merit.

"Yet here you are, being stingy about mere property! You should not be this way. You must donate."

The Medicine Tree Example

Imagine a very useful tree. People come and take what they need. Some take the leaves. Some take the roots. Some take the trunk or branches. But the tree itself never thinks: "They are taking my flowers, my leaves, my roots." The tree never has such thoughts.

In the same way, some receivers may not acknowledge your kindness. They may take everything. They may use whatever they need from you. But you should not think wrongly about this.

Understanding the Nature of the Body

The Bodhisatta reflected: "This body is made of four elements. Properties are also made of four elements."

The four elements are: earth, water, fire, and wind.

Just as we can make a statue by combining water and cement, our body exists because of these four elements combining. The body has heat (fire element) and movement (wind element), which is why we can move, speak, and maintain body temperature.

Every material thing is made of these four elements. All material things have the nature to break down and be destroyed. There is nothing special about them. There is no soul or permanent self in this body.



Therefore, if someone asks for parts of this body, we should not be stingy. Attachment to the body is what the Bodhisatta called "the glory of delusion."

People think: "This is my beautiful eye, my beautiful ear, my beautiful hair. Why would I give it away?" This is just the glory of delusion—it appears glorious, but it is based on not understanding.

Actually, the body is made of four elements with the nature to be destroyed. There is nothing special, no soul, no permanent self. Being stingy about it is not proper. Becoming attached to it is not right. It is merely the glory of delusion.

The Story of the Bhikkhuni's Eyes

In the Buddha's time, there was a bhikkhuni whom a young man approached. He was attracted to her. The bhikkhuni asked him: "What do you love about me?"

The young man replied: "Your eyes."

At that moment, the bhikkhuni took out her own eyes and tried to give them to him. But after she removed her eyes, they were no longer lovely¹¹⁶.

This story shows that our body is not really precious. The Buddha taught that the body has no essence, no true value.

¹¹⁶ Khu.2.424 Therīgāthe (Therīgāthāpāli, tiṃsanipāto, subhājīvakambavanikātherīgāthā)

Taking Essence from the Body

We can take essence from the body by:

- Doing volunteer service
- Avoiding evil actions
- Practicing precepts

For example, on *uposatha* days, we can practice not taking food after noon. We can avoid killing, avoid stealing, avoid earning money through killing or stealing.

When we use the body in these ways, we extract its true essence and value.

Life is Not So Precious

If you want to practice like the Bodhisatta, you must understand that the body and life are not ultimately so precious.

Day by day, our life is slipping away. It's like a calendar—we tear off one page, then another page, day after day. At the end of the year, all the pages are gone.

In the same way, no matter how precious we say life is, day by day it is decreasing, moving closer to death.

Also, staying alive is not easy! We must protect this body with different kinds of vaccines, wearing masks, maintaining social distance. We are very busy just protecting this body!



Because of this, being stingy about the body is truly just "the glory of delusion."

A Wise Bhikkhu's Response

There is a Tipiṭaka Sayadaw in Myanmar. If you ask him, "How are you?" he will only say: "Still can use."

He never says, "I am fine" or "I am well." Just: "Still can use."

This shows the right perspective on the body and life.

Conclusion: The Purification of Practice

When the Bodhisatta reflected in all these ways, he developed a mind willing to give up even his life to gain omniscient knowledge (the knowledge of a Buddha).

Through these reflections:

- His bodily actions became pure
- His verbal actions became pure
- His mental actions became pure

He became clearly able to practice good deeds and progress toward Buddhahood. He was able to give more and more generously.

Final Reflection Question

So, do you want to reflect in these ways?

Do you want to practice donation like the Bodhisatta?

The path is clearly shown through these reflections. By following the Bodhisatta's example, we too can develop stronger generosity, overcome our stinginess, and progress on the path toward enlightenment.

May all beings benefit from the practice of generosity.
May all beings develop to perfection the *dāna pāramī*.
May all beings attain the peace of Nibbāna.

Sādhu! Sādhu! Sādhu!